When do local repairs of a P_3 packing combine into a cluster editing?

(working title; draft skeleton)

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Abstract

Li, Pilipczuk and Sorge study Cluster Editing parameterized by the excess ℓ of the solution size over a modification-disjoint packing H of induced P_3's. We ask which interaction structure of H makes this parameterization tractable, and use the treewidth w of the intersection graph $I(H)$ of the packing as the measure. We prove: (i) for $\ell = 0$ the problem is a CSP with domain size 3 whose constraint scopes are cliques of $I(H)$, hence solvable in $3^{w+1}n^{O(1)}$ given a tree decomposition; (ii) for every ℓ it is solvable in $7^{w+1}n^{2\ell+O(1)}$ given a tree decomposition (XP in ℓ, FPT in w), and domain size 7 cannot be lowered in the natural encoding; (iii) under ETH there is no $2^{o(\mathrm{tw}(I(H)))}n^{O(1)}$ algorithm even for $\ell = 0$ (exponent only, no base); (iv) w alone does not suffice (NP-hard for $w = 0$ with unbounded ℓ), and $\mathrm{tw}(G)$ and $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ are incomparable, with a tradeoff $\ell + \mathrm{tw}(I(H)) \geq 2m - 2$ on stars; (v) adjacent true twins lie in one cluster in every optimum, and if H is maximal among pair-disjoint packings (no induced P_3 has all three pairs unpacked), then in *every* optimum no cluster contains more than one whole twin class of vertices outside $V(H)$, so no edit has both endpoints outside $V(H)$; we derive a normal form (frozen classes, a shrink rule with a tight threshold, a size bound $|R| \leq (\ell+1)|V(H)|$, a classification of the partners of edits touching R) and show by a five-vertex example that pair-maximality cannot be weakened to maximality among vertex-disjoint packings; (vi) CEaMP is solvable in time $1.62^{\binom{s}{2}+1)\ell}n^{O(1)} + n3^s$ and has a kernel with at most $(s^2-s+2)\ell$ vertices, where s is the largest number of vertices spanned by a connected component of $I(H)$; in particular $I(H)$ a perfect matching is FPT in ℓ. This is proved from a rule of van Bevern, Froese and Komusiewicz after verifying its hypotheses at the level of components; the parts that rest on their published proofs are listed explicitly. The main question, whether the problem is fixed-parameter tractable in $\ell + w$, is *open*; we do not prove or disprove it. (vii) For every packing H and every YES instance we prove counting lemmas on the structure of solutions: maximalising H by pair-disjoint induced P_3's costs at most $+|M| \leq \ell$ in treewidth (tight on stars); the hard non-adjacent pairs among the non-packed neighbours of a vertex have matching number at most ℓ, so the independence number of that neighbourhood is at most $2\ell + c + 1$; pieces of a solution that share a cluster are small ($|C| \leq \max\{D + u + 1, 2D, 2u\}$ for a cluster with at least two pieces); and the graph of packed pairs has treewidth at most $3w+2$. A clearly labelled heuristic discussion explains why hub and grid-tiling encodings do not give hardness; it is not a theorem. These lemmas give neither an FPT algorithm in $\ell + w$ nor hardness.

(viii) *Locality of inserted pairs.* In an optimal solution every cluster has diameter at most 2 in G; with pair-maximality every inserted pair ab has a middle vertex z and is either of type T1 (both steps soft, in two distinct members through z) or of type T2 (one step a kept hard edge inside a piece, one step soft). Pieces that share a cluster and are joined by *no* soft pair have all cross pairs of type T1, hence lie in one bag of a decomposition of $I(H)$ and have at most $4c(c-1)$ partners per vertex; merges of pieces that are joined by a soft pair can be of type T2 (examples with $n = 7$ and $n = 8$), so this locality is proved only for soft-free merges. Two hard vertices in one cluster agree on their hard neighbourhoods up to ℓ vertices.

(ix) *The cluster-identity route.* For a pair-maximal H we prove a normal form of optimal solutions (clusters touching an edited hard pair have at most $2D + \ell + 1$ vertices and are connected; all other clusters are unions of whole hard components) and that one endpoint of an edited hard pair determines a set of at most $f(\ell, D)$ candidates for the other. Consequences: an algorithm in time $n^{\ell} f(\ell, w) 7^{w+\ell+1} n^{O(1)}$ (the exponent of (ii) halved) and an FPT algorithm in (ℓ, D, ω), where ω is the treewidth of the graph of edges and packed pairs after removing hard components of large hard degree. However, ω is not bounded by any function of (ℓ, w) (a cubic-expander family with $\ell = w = 0$, using a cited treewidth bound), so this does not give FPT in $\ell + w$.

(x) *Conflicts and pruning.* For a pair-maximal H we prove a conflict lemma: every soft pair (z, b) has a static weight (the number of hard vertices y adjacent to exactly one of z, b, if the pair is merged, or to both, if it is not) that is a lower bound on the number of edited hard pairs; consequences are a defect bound $\sum c(\sigma) \leq 2D|U|$ (the constant is attained for $D = 2$ only, as far as we know), a lower bound on the cost, a static pruning of merges, rigid hard edges, a polynomial NO-test (more than $2c\ell$ locally bad members), bounded candidate lists for the far end of a type-T2 or deleted edit of an optimum, and a pruned form of the FPT theorem of (ix): FPT in $(\ell, D, \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma^{\ell}))$ for a subgraph Γ^{ℓ} of the graph of (ix), strictly stronger on a family of cubic-graph instances. We give an exact obstruction family: for every $m \geq 3$ an instance with $w = 1$, $c = 2$, $\ell = 1$ in which every optimum deletes a hard edge whose ends lie in members at distance $m - 1$ in $I(H)$. Computer-found instances with $n = 10$ show that the idea of placing the "locally bad" members in every bag fails when "far" means distance 2 or 3; for unbounded distance this is open.

(xi) *Reducing components.* A violation of the neighbourhood condition at a boundary vertex forces an edited pair there (Lemma D); tight and reducible components of $I(H)$ are decided in $3^{w+1} n^{O(1)}$; and, modulo the soundness of a rule of van Bevern et al. (cited), a polynomial reduction leaves at most 2ℓ components of $I(H)$ of arbitrary size, so $\ell = 0$ is fully reduced. We also show that the treewidth of the graph of (ix) is controlled by the soft graph with hard components identified, and give a family with $w = 1$, $\ell = 1$ and unbounded such treewidth in which no pair-closed union of members is reducible by that rule, so the rule on unions of members cannot prove the reduction lemma. The reduction lemma and a trigger lemma remain conjectures.

(xii) *Why tunnel reductions stall.* For the natural attempt at W[1]-hardness in $\ell + w$ (hard edges between far vertices, "tunnels", carrying the equalities of a Grid Tiling instance) we prove that a clean tunnel is a lock that forces the states of the members through its end, that locks are rigid under transitivity, that a minimal set of locks that cannot be satisfied together (a core) of size N needs memory across the separators of a decomposition of $I(H)$, that cores of size at most two occur when the zero-excess solutions are closed under a majority operation, that released tunnels have hard degree at most $D+\ell$, and that in the tunnel-release model bounded cores give an algorithm in time $d^{\ell} 3^{w+1} n^{O(1)}$ (a restricted model, not CEaMP). Computer evidence (not theorems): a 7-vertex tight gadget whose stored value flips when its tunnel is cut, and failed compositions of such gadgets into a chain. The missing object (a family of bounded width with a core of unbounded size) and a conjecture on cores for $c \leq 2$ are stated as open problems; a conjecture of the working notes (majority closure for $c \leq 2$) is refuted by an explicit instance.

What remains is stated exactly: whether the pointers of type T2 and the pointers realised by deleted hard edges can be handled in a decomposition of width bounded in (ℓ, w) (Section 10 gives instances in which such a pointer joins members at arbitrary distance in $I(H)$), the reduction lemma, and the main question itself.

1 Introduction

Cluster Editing asks for the fewest edge insertions and deletions that turn a graph G into a disjoint union of cliques. Every induced P_3 must be hit by an edit, so a packing H of induced P_3's that pairwise share no vertex pair (a *modification-disjoint* packing) gives the lower bound $|H|$ on the

solution size. Li, Pilipczuk and Sorge [13] parameterize by the *excess* ℓ over this bound (problem CEaMP): is there a solution of size at most $|H| + \ell$? They show NP-hardness already for $\ell = 0$, with every vertex in at most 23 packed P_3's, and an $n^{2\ell+O(1)}$ algorithm when every vertex lies in at most two packed P_3's; whether the latter case is fixed-parameter tractable is open [13]. For vertex-disjoint packings the problem is FPT in ℓ [14].

The question of this paper is which measurable *interaction structure* of H makes the local repair choices (one edit per packed P_3, in three ways) combine into a global solution in $f(\ell, w)\, n^{O(1)}$ time. We take $w = \mathrm{tw}(I(H))$, where the intersection graph $I(H)$ has the packed P_3's as nodes and joins two of them when they share a vertex.

What is proved. For $\ell = 0$ the problem is a constraint satisfaction problem (CSP) with one variable of domain size 3 per packed P_3 and constraint scopes that are cliques of $I(H)$ (Section 3); dynamic programming over a tree decomposition gives $3^{w+1}n^{O(1)}$. For general ℓ, guessing the at most ℓ edits outside all packed P_3's reduces to the same CSP with domain size 7, giving $7^{w+1}n^{2\ell+O(1)}$ (Section 4). Section 5 proves a strict twin lemma and, for packings H that are maximal among pair-disjoint packings, the structure of the vertices R outside $V(H)$ and the statement (C1) that in every optimum no edit has both endpoints in R; it derives frozen classes, a shrink rule whose threshold is tight, the bound $|R| \le (\ell+1)|V(H)|$, and a classification of the partners of edits touching R. A five-vertex example shows that the hypothesis cannot be weakened to maximality among vertex-disjoint packings, and a four-cycle shows that edits between R and $V(H)$ cannot be excluded. Section 6 proves Theorem K: with s the maximum number of vertices spanned by a component of $I(H)$, CEaMP runs in $1.62^{(\binom{s}{2}+1)\ell}n^{O(1)} + n3^s$ time and has a kernel with at most $(s^2-s+2)\ell$ vertices; $I(H)$ a perfect matching is therefore FPT in ℓ. The proof applies the reduction rule of [14] to the components of $I(H)$ after proving its hypotheses in full; it still relies on their published proof of the rule's soundness, on a Cluster Editing solver and on the $2k$-vertex kernel as quoted there. Section 7 proves counting lemmas for solutions with respect to an arbitrary packing (maximalisation with its cost in treewidth, a matching bound for hubs of deletions, small merges of pieces, and treewidth of the soft graph) and ends with a clearly labelled heuristic discussion of why simple hardness gadgets fail. Section 8 proves that in an optimal solution every cluster has diameter at most 2 and classifies every inserted unpacked pair into two types (T1: two soft steps through a common neighbour; T2: one kept hard step and one soft step). Pieces that share a cluster and have no soft pair between them have all cross pairs of type T1, which are local in a decomposition of $I(H)$ with at most $4c(c-1)$ partners per vertex; examples with $n = 6, 7, 8$ show that merges of pieces joined by a soft pair can be of type T2, so the locality is proved only for soft-free merges. Section 9 proves a normal form of optimal solutions for pair-maximal packings, a bound on the candidates of one endpoint of an edited hard pair given the other, an $n^{\ell} f(\ell, w) 7^{w+\ell+1}$ algorithm, and an FPT algorithm in (ℓ, D, ω) for the treewidth ω of the graph of edges and packed pairs of the non-*big* part; a family with $\ell = w = 0$ shows that ω is unbounded in (ℓ, w). These sections come with a status table and mark the missing reduction lemma as a conjecture. Section 10 proves a conflict lemma that gives every soft pair a static weight, with a defect bound, a polynomial NO-test, bounded candidate lists for the far end of a (T2) or deleted edit, and a pruned version of the FPT theorem (FPT in $(\ell, D, \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma^{\ell}))$ for a subgraph Γ^{ℓ} of Γ'); it also proves an exact obstruction family (Proposition 75: $w = 1$, $c = 2$, $\ell = 1$, every optimum deletes a hard edge between members at distance $m - 1$ in $I(H)$) and records that a natural repair, placing the locally bad members in every bag, fails for "far" meaning distance 2 or 3 (computer-assisted). Section 11 proves that the rule of [14] applied to components of $I(H)$ of any size leaves at most 2ℓ components (soundness of the rule cited), reformulates the reduction lemma through the treewidth of the soft graph with

hard components contracted, and shows by a family with $w = 1$, $\ell = 1$ that the rule on pair-closed unions of members cannot prove the reduction lemma. Section 12 analyses the natural hardness attempt by hard edges between far vertices (tunnels): it proves lemmas on locks, rigidity, memory across decompositions and bounded fan-out, a fixed-parameter algorithm in a restricted tunnel-release model when the minimal conflicting sets of locks are bounded, reports computer evidence (a 7-vertex flip gadget and failed compositions) and isolates the missing "chain object" as an open problem; this part is explicitly labelled as evidence or heuristic where it is not proved. Under ETH the exponent $\Theta(w)$ cannot be improved to $o(w)$ even at $\ell = 0$; w alone is insufficient; $\mathrm{tw}(G)$ and $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ are incomparable (Section 13).

What is not proved. Whether CEaMP is FPT in $\ell + \mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ (or W[1]-hard) is open, already for $w = 1$ with tree components of unbounded size. The algorithm of Section 4 is XP in ℓ, Theorem K needs bounded components, and no hardness is known. The normal form of Section 5 applies to a pair-maximal extension H' of the given packing, whose intersection graph may have larger treewidth, so it does not by itself give a preprocessing for the parameter $(\ell, \mathrm{tw}(I(H)))$. What is left in precise form is: the pointers of type T2, the pointers realised by deleted hard edges, and the reduction lemma ML (Conjecture 64), which would make Theorem 59 an FPT algorithm in $\ell + w$; whether merge pointers can be forced at unbounded distance in $I(H)$ is also open (Section 8.6). The algorithms of Sections 4 and 9 remain XP in ℓ, and the new results of Sections 10 and 11 do not change this: the reduction lemma (Conjecture 64), the trigger lemma (Conjecture 86) and the conjecture on Λ_ℓ (Conjecture 78) are conjectures, and whether pointers at unbounded distance in $I(H)$ can be handled is open. Section 14 states the open problems.

2 Preliminaries

Graphs are simple and undirected, $n = |V(G)|$. A *pair* is a 2-subset of $V(G)$; for a set S of pairs, $G \triangle S$ flips the adjacency of each pair in S. A graph is a *cluster graph* iff it has no induced P_3, i.e. no vertex triple with exactly two edges. A *solution* is a set S of pairs with $G \triangle S$ a cluster graph; $\mathrm{OPT}(G)$ is the minimum size of a solution.

A *packing* $H = \{P_1, \ldots, P_p\}$ is a set of induced P_3's $P_i = (a_i, b_i, c_i)$ ($a_i b_i, b_i c_i \in E$, $a_i c_i \notin E$). Write $\mathrm{pairs}(P_i)$ for the three pairs inside $V(P_i)$. H is *modification-disjoint* if the sets $\mathrm{pairs}(P_i)$ are pairwise disjoint; this is equivalent to: any two members share at most one vertex (two shared vertices would be a shared pair, and any two vertices of a P_3 form one of its pairs). All packings below are modification-disjoint. A pair is *packed* if it lies in $\bigcup_i \mathrm{pairs}(P_i)$ (its *owner* is then unique) and *unpacked* otherwise. For a vertex u, $Q(u)$ is the set of z with uz packed.

Problem CEaMP. Given G, a modification-disjoint packing H and $\ell \geq 0$, decide whether there is a solution S with $|S| \leq |H| + \ell$ (this is the convention of [13]; ℓ is the excess budget).

The *intersection graph* $I(H)$ has node set H and an edge PP' iff $V(P) \cap V(P') \neq \emptyset$. The P_3's through one vertex form a clique of $I(H)$. Hence (Helly property of tree decompositions) they lie in a common bag, and $c := \max_u |\{P \ni u\}| \leq \mathrm{tw}(I(H)) + 1$ and $|Q(u)| \leq 2c$. We write $w = \mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ with the convention $w = 0$ if $I(H)$ has no edge. A tree decomposition of width w is assumed *given* in the algorithmic statements; computing one costs time linear in n for fixed w (Bodlaender [2]; the explicit dependence on w is usually quoted as $2^{O(w^3)}$, or $w^{O(w^3)}$ in some sources, and is not stated in the abstract of [2], which we did not re-derive), or $2^{O(w)}n$ time for a tree decomposition of width at most $2w + 1$, i.e. a factor-2 approximation (Korhonen [12]; running time and width bound read off the abstract of the arXiv version, 2026-10-20), which would change the bases below (e.g. 7^{w+1} to 7^{2w+2}).

Lemma 1 (Solutions decompose)**.** *Let S be any set of pairs such that $G \triangle S$ is a cluster graph, $x_i = S \cap \text{pairs}(P_i)$ and $U = S \setminus \bigcup_i \text{pairs}(P_i)$. Then every $x_i \neq \emptyset$, $|S| = \sum_i |x_i| + |U|$, and $|U| \leq |S| - |H|$.*

Proof. If $x_i = \emptyset$ the triple $V(P_i)$ keeps its adjacencies in $G \triangle S$ and is an induced P_3. The pair sets are disjoint, so $|S| = \sum |x_i| + |U| \geq |H| + |U|$. □

Remark 2 (Maximality). *H is pair-maximal* if no induced P_3 of G has all three pairs unpacked, i.e. if H is maximal among modification-disjoint packings. This is strictly stronger than maximality among vertex-disjoint packings (Proposition 15), and it is the only notion used in Section 5. If $H' \supseteq H$ adds t further pair-disjoint induced P_3's, then $|H'| + (\ell - t) = |H| + \ell$, so (G, H, ℓ) and $(G, H', \ell - t)$ ask the same question (a NO instance if $\ell < t$, since OPT $\geq |H'|$). A pair-maximal H' is found greedily in polynomial time. Caution: $\text{tw}(I(H'))$ may exceed $\text{tw}(I(H))$.

3 The case $\ell = 0$ is a CSP on the intersection graph

Observation 3. *Let S be a solution with $|S| \leq |H|$. Then S has exactly one pair in each* $\text{pairs}(P_i)$ *and no other pair, and $G \triangle S$ is a cluster graph iff no vertex triple is an induced P_3 of $G \triangle S$. Consequently $(G, H, 0)$ is a YES instance iff the following CSP is satisfiable: variables $x_i \in \{1, 2, 3\}$ (which pair of P_i is flipped), and for every vertex triple t the constraint "t is not an induced P_3 after flipping", whose truth depends on the owners' variables of the packed pairs of t only (unpacked pairs keep their status in G).*

Proof. By Lemma 1, $|x_i| \geq 1$ for all i and $|S| = \sum |x_i| + |U| \leq |H|$ force $|x_i| = 1$ and $U = \emptyset$. The rest is the definition of a cluster graph. □

The CSP has $\Theta(n^3)$ constraints, not $O(|H|)$.

Observation 4. *The set of owners of the packed pairs of any triple is a clique of $I(H)$ (at most three nodes). Hence the primal graph of the CSP is a subgraph of $I(H)$ (not every edge of $I(H)$ is witnessed by a triple), and a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ is one of the primal graph.*

Proof. Two pairs of one triple share a vertex v; their owners both contain v, so they coincide or are adjacent in $I(H)$. □

Theorem 5. *Given (G, H) and a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w, CEaMP with $\ell = 0$ is solvable in $3^{w+1} n^{O(1)}$ time.*

Theorem 5 is the case $\ell = 0$ of Theorem 6 below (with a larger base there, 7, because for $\ell > 0$ a packed P_3 may receive several edits); its proof is the same dynamic program with domain $\{1, 2, 3\}$. Observation 4 is what makes the interaction of disjoint P_3's at $\ell = 0$ completely visible in $I(H)$: no transitivity-mediated interaction exists beyond shared vertices.

4 Excess edits: an XP-in-ℓ, FPT-in-w algorithm

Theorem 6. *Given (G, H, ℓ) and a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w, CEaMP is solvable in $7^{w+1} n^{2\ell + O(1)}$ time.*

Proof. Let $\mathcal{D}_i$ be the 7 non-empty subsets of pairs(P_i). By Lemma 1, a solution of size $\leq |H| + \ell$ has the form $S = U \cup \bigcup x_i$ with $x_i \in \mathcal{D}_i$ and U a set of at most ℓ unpacked pairs; there are at most $\sum_{j \leq \ell} \binom{n^2/2}{j} \leq n^{2\ell}$ candidates for U.

Fix U and put $G_U = G \triangle U$. Since U avoids packed pairs, every P_i is still an induced P_3 of G_U with the same pairs, so H is still a modification-disjoint packing. For a triple t, the status of each unpacked pair of t in $G_U \triangle x$ is fixed, and each packed pair is determined by G_U and the variable of its owner. Hence t gives a constraint C_t ("t is not an induced P_3 in $G_U \triangle x$") whose scope is the owner set of t, a clique of $I(H)$ by Observation 4 (the proof there does not use G itself). Triples with empty scope are tested directly, in $O(n^3)$ time. Seek $x \in \prod \mathcal{D}_i$ satisfying all C_t and minimizing the unary cost $\sum_i |x_i|$.

Let $(T, \{B_s\})$ be the tree decomposition. By the Helly property each clique lies in a bag; assign each constraint to one such bag. For a node s and an assignment α of B_s, let $f_s(\alpha)$ be the minimum cost of $\sum |x_i|$ over variables in the subtree of s, among assignments extending α and satisfying all constraints assigned in the subtree. The standard recurrences (introduce, forget, join; see [4]) compute all f_s in time $7^{w+1} n^{O(1)}$ since there are $O(n^3)$ constraints and each table has $\leq 7^{w+1}$ entries. Accept iff for some U the minimum m_U satisfies $m_U + |U| \leq |H| + \ell$. Soundness: any feasible (U, x) gives the solution $U \cup \bigcup x_i$. Completeness: Lemma 1. □

Remark 7 (Why domain size 7). The empty value is never feasible, so 7 (not 8) suffices. It cannot be lowered to 3: an edited packed P_3 can receive two or three edits in every optimum. For two: $n = 5$, $E = \{02, 04, 12, 23, 24\}$, $H = \{(1, 2, 3)\}$, OPT $= 2$, unique optimum $\{12, 23\}$. For three: $n = 6$, $E = \{01, 02, 03, 04, 12, 14, 15, 24, 25, 35, 45\}$, $H = \{(0, 3, 5)\}$, OPT $= 3$, unique optimum $\{03, 05, 35\}$ (both checked exhaustively over all set partitions). In the notes' random data (computer evidence, $n \leq 9$) about 8–9% of instances force ≥ 2 edits on some packed P_3 and $\approx 0.2\%$ force three. For $c = 2$, $I(H)$ is subcubic but may have unbounded treewidth, so Theorem 6 is a different tradeoff from, not a recovery of, the $n^{2\ell}$ algorithm of [13].

Proposition 8 (Completing a fixed packed assignment)**.** *Let x assign a subset $x_i \subseteq$ pairs(P_i) to each P_i and let $B = |H| + \ell - \sum |x_i|$ be the excess budget left. Whether there is a set U of at most B unpacked pairs with $G \triangle (x \cup U)$ a cluster graph is decidable in $3^B n^{O(1)}$ time.*

Proof. Search tree on $G_x = G \triangle x$: if the current graph has an induced P_3, some pair of it must be flipped; packed pairs are frozen by x, so branch on its at most three unpacked pairs, reducing B by one (if all its pairs are packed, reject). Depth is at most B; flipping a pair twice is useless, so the search is exhaustive. □

Remark 9. Proposition 8 is a reformulation, not progress towards FPT in (ℓ, w): finding x is the whole problem, and the property "x is completable" is not local in x.

5 Twins, vertices outside the packing, and a normal form

By Lemma 1 the whole difficulty of $\ell > 0$ is the set U of at most ℓ unpacked edits. This section proves what can be said about U without any further assumption on the instance beyond maximality of H (in the pair sense of Remark 2).

Conventions. A *partition* Π of V into *clusters* has *cost* equal to the number of its *edits*: edges between different clusters (deletions) plus non-edges inside a cluster (insertions). Solutions S and partitions correspond ($G \triangle S$ is a cluster graph whose cliques are the clusters), so OPT(G) is the minimum cost and an *optimum* is a partition of minimum cost. $\Pi(v)$ is the cluster of v. Unless said

otherwise, H is *pair-maximal* (Remark 2: no induced P_3 of G has all three pairs unpacked) and $R = V \setminus V(H)$; every pair with an end in R is unpacked.

5.1 Twins

Lemma 10 (Twins, strict form)**.** *Let $u \neq v$ be adjacent with $N[u] = N[v]$. For every partition Π with $\Pi(u) \neq \Pi(v)$, one of the two partitions obtained by moving u into $\Pi(v)$, respectively v into $\Pi(u)$, has cost smaller than Π by at least 1; more precisely the two cost changes sum to exactly -2. Hence u, v lie in one cluster in* every *optimum, with no hypothesis on H.*

Proof. For a vertex y and a set $D \not\ni y$ let $f(y, D) = |D \setminus N(y)| - |D \cap N(y)|$. Put $D_u = \Pi(u) \setminus \{u\}$ and $D_v = \Pi(v) \setminus \{v\}$ (possibly empty); $D_u \not\ni v$, $D_v \not\ni u$, and neither contains u or v. Moving u out of $\Pi(u)$ changes the status of the pairs uz, $z \in D_u$: before, uz is an edit iff it is a non-edge; after, iff it is an edge; the change is $-f(u, D_u)$. Moving u into $\Pi(v) = D_v \cup \{v\}$ changes, for $z \in D_v \cup \{v\}$, the status from "edit iff edge" to "edit iff non-edge"; the change is $f(u, D_v \cup \{v\}) = f(u, D_v) - 1$ because $uv \in E$. All other pairs keep their status. So

$$\Delta_1 = -f(u, D_u) + f(u, D_v) - 1, \qquad \Delta_2 = -f(v, D_v) + f(v, D_u) - 1.$$

Since $N(u) \setminus \{v\} = N(v) \setminus \{u\}$ we have $f(u, D) = f(v, D)$ for all $D \subseteq V \setminus \{u, v\}$, hence $\Delta_1 + \Delta_2 = -2$. Thus $\min(\Delta_1, \Delta_2) \leq -1$. □

This is the critical-clique property used in kernelizations of Cluster Editing (Guo [9]; also stated in [14]); the argument above is self-contained and shows that it is strict.

5.2 Viability of an unpacked edit

Lemma 11 (Viability of an unpacked edit)**.** *Let S be any solution, U its unpacked part and $uv \in U$. Let $D(uv)$ be the set of $z \notin Q(u) \cup Q(v) \cup \{u, v\}$ such that $\{u, v, z\}$ is an induced P_3 of $G \triangle \{uv\}$. Then for every $z \in D(uv)$ one of uz, vz lies in U, and $|D(uv)| \leq |U| - 1$.*

Proof. All three pairs of $\{u, v, z\}$ are unpacked ($z \notin Q(u) \cup Q(v)$). If neither uz nor vz is in S, the triple has in $G \triangle S$ the same pattern as in $G \triangle \{uv\}$, an induced P_3. Distinct z give distinct pairs, all different from uv. □

This gives a kernel-style condition (deleting uv needs fewer than ℓ common neighbours outside $Q(u) \cup Q(v)$) but no bound on the number of candidate pairs: all pendant edges are viable.

5.3 The vertices outside $V(H)$

Lemma 12 (Structure of R)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal. For $r, s \in R$: if $rs \in E$ then $N[r] = N[s]$; if $rs \notin E$ then $N(r) \cap N(s) = \emptyset$. Consequently:*

1. *every component X of $G[R]$ (a* class*) is a clique all of whose vertices have the same closed neighbourhood $N[X]$ (they are true twins);*
2. *$A_X := N(X) \setminus X$ is contained in $V(H)$;*
3. *the sets A_X, over the classes X, are pairwise disjoint.*

Proof. Every pair with an end in R is unpacked. Let $rs \in E$ and $z \neq r, s$ be adjacent to exactly one of r, s. Then $\{r, s, z\}$ has exactly two edges, i.e. is an induced P_3 with all three pairs unpacked, contradicting pair-maximality; so $N[r] = N[s]$. If $rs \notin E$ and z is a common neighbour, then $r\,z\,s$ is an induced P_3 whose pairs rz, zs, rs all have an end in R, again a contradiction.

(1) Adjacent vertices of R have equal closed neighbourhoods; along a connected component all closed neighbourhoods coincide, and then any two vertices r, t of the component satisfy $r \in N[r] = N[t]$, so they are adjacent. (2) A neighbour of $x \in X$ lying in R is in the component of x, hence in X. (3) If $a \in A_X \cap A_Y$ for classes $X \neq Y$, then a is a common neighbour of some $x \in X$ and $y \in Y$, which are non-adjacent (different components of $G[R]$); this contradicts the second clause. □

For $x \in X$ and $a \in V(H)$ we thus have $xa \in E$ iff $a \in A_X$; in particular vertices of one class are twins towards $V(H)$ as well. (Lemma 12 fails for vertex-maximal packings, see Proposition 15.)

Lemma 13 (Exchange formula)**.** *Let* Π *be any partition,* X *a class with* $X \subseteq C$ *for a cluster* C*,* $x = |X|$ *and* $a = |A_X \cap C|$*. Let* Π' *be obtained by moving* X *out of* C *into a cluster of its own. Then* $\mathrm{cost}(\Pi') - \mathrm{cost}(\Pi) = x\,(x + 2a - |C|)$.

Proof. Only the pairs between X and $C \setminus X$ change status. By Lemma 12, a vertex of X has exactly a neighbours in $C \setminus X$, namely $A_X \cap C$. Before the move such a pair is an edit iff it is a non-edge: $x(|C| - x - a)$ edits. After the move it is an edit iff it is an edge: xa edits. The difference is $xa - x(|C| - x - a) = x(x + 2a - |C|)$. □

Theorem 14 (C1: no edit inside R)**.** *Let* H *be pair-maximal. In* every *optimum* Π*, every cluster meets* R *in the empty set or in exactly one whole class. Hence no edit of* Π *has both endpoints in* R*, and for every class* X *the cluster* $\Pi(X)$ *equals* $X \cup B_X$ *with* $B_X := \Pi(X) \cap V(H)$.

Proof. By Lemma 12(1) and Lemma 10, every class lies inside one cluster (a class of size 1 trivially). Suppose a cluster C contains two distinct classes X_1, X_2. Put $x_i = |X_i| \geq 1$ and $a_i = |A_{X_i} \cap C|$. The sets $X_1, X_2 \subseteq R$ and $A_{X_1} \cap C, A_{X_2} \cap C \subseteq V(H)$ are pairwise disjoint (Lemma 12(2),(3)), so $|C| \geq x_1 + x_2 + a_1 + a_2$. Let Δ_i be the cost change of moving X_i out of C. Since Π is an optimum, $\Delta_1 \geq 0$ and $\Delta_2 \geq 0$, i.e. by Lemma 13 $|C| \leq x_i + 2a_i$ for $i = 1, 2$. With the lower bound on $|C|$: $x_2 + a_2 \leq a_1$ and $x_1 + a_1 \leq a_2$. Adding gives $x_1 + x_2 \leq 0$, absurd. So no cluster contains two classes.

An edit with both ends in R joins two vertices r, s. If they lie in one class, they are adjacent and (by the above) in one cluster, so rs is no edit. If they lie in different classes they are non-adjacent, and rs is an edit iff they share a cluster, which was excluded. □

The strictness of the inequality is what makes the statement hold for every optimum (no ties, and no iteration or termination argument).

Proposition 15 (Pair-maximality cannot be replaced by vertex-maximality)**.** *Let* G *have vertices* $0, \ldots, 4$ *and edges* $03, 13, 14, 24, 34$*, and* $H = \{(0, 3, 1)\}$ *(pairs* $03, 13, 01$*). Then* H *is maximal among vertex-disjoint packings (only the two vertices* $2, 4$ *remain),* $R = \{2, 4\}$*,* $\mathrm{OPT} = 2$ *and the unique optimum is* $\{03, 24\}$*; it contains the edit* 24 *with both endpoints in* R*. So Theorem 14 fails. Here* $\{3, 4, 2\}$ *is an induced* P_3 *all of whose pairs are unpacked, so* H *is not pair-maximal and Lemma 12 fails.*

Proof. The partition $\{\{0\}, \{1, 3, 4\}, \{2\}\}$ has the two edits $03, 24$. Conversely, $0\,3\,1$ and $3\,4\,2$ are induced P_3's with disjoint pair sets $\{03, 13, 01\}$ and $\{34, 24, 23\}$, so $\mathrm{OPT} \geq 2$. That this is the only optimum was checked by enumerating all 52 partitions of the five vertices (computer; not re-derived by hand). □

5.4 Consequences

Let (G, H, ℓ) be a *YES instance* with H pair-maximal, Π any optimum, S its edit set, so $|S| = \mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$. Let U be the unpacked edits. By Lemma 1, $|S| - |H| = \sum_i (|x_i| - 1) + |U|$, so $|U| \le \ell$. Write $q = \max_u |Q(u)| \le 2c$.

Corollary 16 (Normal form). *For every class X let $B_X = \Pi(X) \cap V(H)$.*

(N1) Types of unpacked edits. *Every unpacked edit is either an* HH-edit *(both ends in $V(H)$) or an* RH-edit $\{x, a\}$, *$x \in X$ a class, $a \in V(H)$; the latter is a deletion if $a \in A_X \setminus B_X$ and an insertion if $a \in B_X \setminus A_X$, and $\{x, a\}$ is edited iff $\{x', a\}$ is, for all $x, x' \in X$. With h the number of HH-edits, $|U| = h + \sum_X |X| \cdot |A_X \triangle B_X| \le \ell - \sum_i (|x_i| - 1) \le \ell$.*

(N2) Frozen classes. *If $|X| > \ell$, then $\Pi(X) = X \cup A_X$.*

(N3) Attachment. *Every $a \in V(H)$ lies in A_X for at most one class X. If $z, z' \in A_X$ are non-adjacent then zz' is packed. If $a \in V(H) \setminus A_X$, $z \in A_X$ and $az \in E$ then az is packed; hence $|N(a) \cap A_X| \le |Q(a)| \le q$.*

(N4) Shrink rule. *If $|X| \ge \ell + 2$ and $x \in X$, then (G, H, ℓ) is a YES instance iff $(G - x, H, \ell)$ is. This holds for H pair-maximal without the YES hypothesis. If $A_X = \emptyset$ then X is a component of G and may be deleted without changing* OPT.

(N5) Size. *After exhausting the two rules in (N4), every class has at most $\ell + 1$ vertices and at most $|V(H)|$ classes have $A_X \neq \emptyset$, so $|R| \le (\ell + 1)|V(H)|$ and $n \le (\ell + 2)|V(H)| \le 3(\ell + 2)|H|$.*

Proof. (N1) Pairs with an end in R are unpacked; by Theorem 14 none has both ends in R. The vertices of X are twins towards $V(H)$ and lie in one cluster, which gives the all-or-none statement; xa is an edit iff exactly one of $a \in B_X$, $a \in A_X$ holds. Counting gives the identity; the bound is the first paragraph of this subsection.

(N2) If $\Pi(X) \neq X \cup A_X$ then, since $\Pi(X) = X \cup B_X$ (Theorem 14), $A_X \triangle B_X \neq \emptyset$ and (N1) gives $|U| \ge |X| > \ell$, contradicting $|U| \le \ell$.

(N3) The first claim is Lemma 12(3). Let $x \in X$. If $z, z' \in A_X$ are non-adjacent, $z\,x\,z'$ is an induced P_3 with pairs zx, xz' unpacked, so zz' must be packed (pair-maximality). If $a \in V(H) \setminus A_X$ and $z \in A_X$ with $az \in E$, then $xa \notin E$ and $x\,z\,a$ is an induced P_3 with xz, xa unpacked, so az is packed, i.e. $z \in Q(a)$.

(N4) $x \in R$, so H is still a packing of $G - x$, still pair-maximal (an induced P_3 of $G - x$ is one of G), and $X \setminus \{x\}$ is a class of $G - x$ with the same A_X. ($\Rightarrow$) Restricting a partition of G to $V \setminus x$ does not increase its cost, so $\mathrm{OPT}(G - x) \le \mathrm{OPT}(G) \le |H| + \ell$. ($\Leftarrow$) Let Π be an optimum of $G - x$ with cost $\le |H| + \ell$. Now $|X \setminus x| \ge \ell + 1 > \ell$, so (N2) in $G - x$ gives $\Pi(X \setminus x) = (X \setminus x) \cup A_X$. Add x to this cluster: $N[x] = X \cup A_X$, so every pair at x is satisfied, and the cost does not change. Hence $\mathrm{OPT}(G) \le |H| + \ell$. If $A_X = \emptyset$, X is a clique component of G, which costs nothing, and H is disjoint from it.

(N5) After the rules each class has at most $\ell + 1$ vertices; the non-empty sets $A_X \subseteq V(H)$ are pairwise disjoint (Lemma 12), and $|V(H)| \le 3|H|$. Classes with $A_X = \emptyset$ were deleted. □

Remark 17 (Tightness of the threshold in (N4)). For $\ell = 0$ the threshold $|X| \ge 2$ cannot be lowered to $|X| \ge 1$: take the 4-cycle of Proposition 20 below, $H = \{(0, 1, 3)\}$, $X = \{2\}$. Then $(G, H, 0)$ is a NO instance, but $G - 2$ is the induced P_3 0 1 3 itself, so $(G - 2, H, 0)$ is a YES instance. (For larger ℓ the notes report computer evidence of the same tightness; no proof is given here.)

Remark 18 (The rules and the user-supplied packing). The input packing H of CEaMP need not be pair-maximal. Extend it greedily (polynomial time) to a pair-maximal $H' \supseteq H$ with $t = |H'| - |H|$ new members, set $\ell' = \ell - t$ (answer NO if $\ell' < 0$, Remark 2) and apply this section to (G, H', ℓ'). Then (N4), (N5) hold with ℓ' and H'; in particular $n \le 3(\ell+2)(|H|+\ell)$ after reduction, since $|H'| \le |H| + \ell$. But $\mathrm{tw}(I(H'))$ may exceed $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$, so these rules are a preprocessing for the parameters $(\ell, |H'|)$ or $(\ell, \mathrm{tw}(I(H')))$, not for $(\ell, \mathrm{tw}(I(H)))$ with the given H; and $|V(H')|$ is not bounded by ℓ, so (N5) is not a kernel.

Proposition 19 (Partners of edits touching R)**.** *In the setting of Corollary 16, let X be a class, $B = B_X$. Then:*

(P1) Deletion. *If $\{x, a\}$ is an RH-deletion, $a \in A_X$, then X is determined by a (the unique class with $a \in A_X$): it is a unary flag at a of weight $|X|$. Moreover a is then cut off from every $z \in A_X \cap B$ with $z \notin Q(a)$, each such edge az being an unpacked HH-deletion; so at least $|A_X \cap B| - q$ HH-edits accompany it.*

(P2) No detachment. *If $B \cap A_X = \emptyset$ then $B = \emptyset$.*

(P3) Insertion. *If $a \in B \setminus A_X$ then $B \cap A_X \neq \emptyset$, and for every $z \in B \cap A_X$ either az is packed ($a \in Q(z)$, at most q choices of a per z) or az is an unpacked non-edge, hence an inserted HH-edit.*

(P4) Wide classes. *If $|A_X| \ge \ell + q$ then $B \subseteq A_X$.*

Consequently, every candidate partner $a \in V(H)$ of a class in an RH-edit is unary (P1), local to some z (P3, packed case) or tied to an HH-edit (P3, second case; P1). This classifies the partners; it does not assert that the HH-edits are independent of the RH-edits.

Proof. (P1) Uniqueness is (N3). Let $a \in A_X \setminus B$ and $z \in A_X \cap B$, $z \notin Q(a)$. If $az \notin E$ then az would be packed by (N3), contradicting $z \notin Q(a)$; so $az \in E$, unpacked, and $a \notin \Pi(X) \ni z$, so az is deleted. At most q vertices z lie in $Q(a)$.

(P2) Suppose $B \neq \emptyset = B \cap A_X$. The cluster is $C = X \cup B$ (Theorem 14), $a_X = |A_X \cap C| = 0$, and by Lemma 13 moving X out changes the cost by $|X|(|X| - |X| - |B|) = -|X||B| < 0$, contradicting optimality.

(P3) $B \neq \emptyset$, so $B \cap A_X \neq \emptyset$ by (P2). Let $z \in B \cap A_X$. If $az \in E$ then az is packed by (N3) ($a \in V(H) \setminus A_X$), i.e. $a \in Q(z)$. Otherwise either az is packed (again $a \in Q(z)$) or it is an unpacked non-edge inside the cluster $\Pi(X)$, an insertion.

(P4) Suppose $B \not\subseteq A_X$. Put $\alpha = |A_X \cap B|$, $\delta = |A_X \setminus B|$, $\beta = |B \setminus A_X| \ge 1$. By (N1) there are $|X|\beta$ RH-insertions and $|X|\delta$ RH-deletions. For $b \in B \setminus A_X$ and $z \in A_X \cap B$ with $z \notin Q(b)$, the pair bz is unpacked, lies in a cluster, and is a non-edge by (N3); so it is an unpacked insertion, an HH-edit. There are at least $\beta \max(0, \alpha - q)$ of them. Hence $\ell \ge |U| \ge \beta(|X| + \max(0, \alpha - q)) + |X|\delta$. If $\alpha \ge q$ this gives $\ell \ge 1 + (\alpha - q) + \delta$, i.e. $|A_X| = \alpha + \delta \le \ell + q - 1$. If $\alpha < q$ it gives $\delta \le \ell - 1$ and $|A_X| \le q - 1 + \ell - 1$. Either way $|A_X| < \ell + q$. □

5.5 Where locality stops

Proposition 20 (Strong locality fails)**.** *Let $G = C_4$ with edges $01, 02, 13, 23$ and $H = \{(0, 1, 3)\}$ (pairs $01, 13, 03$; vertex $2 \notin V(H)$). Then H is pair-maximal,* $\mathrm{OPT} = 2 = |H| + 1$*, so $(G, H, 0)$ is a NO instance, and there are exactly three optima $\{03, 12\}$, $\{01, 23\}$, $\{02, 13\}$, each containing an unpacked pair at vertex 2.*

This (checked exhaustively over all partitions, and verified by hand: every induced P_3 of C_4 contains one of the packed pairs $01, 13, 03$) refutes the claim that all unpacked edits of some optimum have both endpoints in $V(H)$; Theorem 14 is what remains true: no edit has both endpoints in R. In the notes' random sample ($n \le 9$) about 4% of maximal-packing instances with $|R| \ge 2$ force an edit touching R (computer evidence, not a theorem).

Remark 21 (Vertex-disjoint packings and the case $c = 1$). For a vertex-disjoint H ($w = 0$, $c = 1$) FPT in ℓ is the theorem of [14]. One must not derive it from Theorem 14 by treating H as pair-maximal: a vertex-disjoint H that is maximal among vertex-disjoint packings need not be pair-maximal (Proposition 15; also the path $0\,1\,2\,3\,4$ with $H = \{(0, 1, 2)\}$, which is extended by $(2, 3, 4)$ sharing the vertex 2). The pair-maximal extension H' of Remark 18 is in general no longer vertex-disjoint, so $I(H')$ has edges and the case $w = 0$ is not available for it. We therefore claim nothing about $c = 1$ beyond [14] and Theorem 22.

6 Bounded components of $I(H)$: Theorem K

Let $C_1, \dots, C_r$ be the connected components of $I(H)$, $p_j = |C_j|$ the number of P_3's in C_j, and $W_j = \bigcup_{P \in C_j} V(P)$. Put $s = \max_j |W_j|$, the largest number of *vertices* spanned by a component. If $s_P = \max_j p_j$ counts P_3's instead, then $s \le 2s_P + 1$: order the P_3's of a component so that each shares a vertex with an earlier one; the first spans 3 vertices and each later one adds at most 2.

Theorem 22 (Theorem K). *CEaMP can be solved in time* $1.62^{\binom{s}{2}+1)\ell}\, n^{O(1)} + n\, 3^s$ *and admits a kernel with at most* $(s^2 - s + 2)\,\ell$ *vertices, where* s *is the maximum number of vertices spanned by a connected component of* $I(H)$. *(No hypothesis of maximality is used. The kernel is an instance of CEaMP with empty packing.)*

Corollary 23. *If* $I(H)$ *is a perfect matching (so* $w = 1$, $c = 2$*), CEaMP is FPT in* ℓ*: here* $s = 5$*, the time is* $1.62^{11\ell} n^{O(1)}$ *and the kernel has at most* 22ℓ *vertices. More generally components with at most* s_P P_3*'s give Theorem 22 with* $s = 2s_P + 1$.

Proof of Corollary. Two adjacent nodes of $I(H)$ share exactly one vertex (H is modification-disjoint), so $|W_j| = 3 + 3 - 1 = 5$; $s^2 - s + 2 = 22$ and $\binom{5}{2} + 1 = 11$. □

What is cited and what is proved. We use the problem of van Bevern, Froese and Komusiewicz [14]: an instance $(G, \mathcal{G}, k)$ consists of a graph, a set $\mathcal{G}$ of *vertex-disjoint induced subgraphs* G_j with $1 \le \tau(G_j) \le t$, where τ is the cluster-editing optimum, and a budget k; its parameters are t and $\ell_B = k - \sum_j \tau(G_j)$ (their Def. 1.2, Problem 1.3, read in the arXiv text; connectivity of the G_j is not required, and their size enters only through t). We prove below, in full, that the components of $I(H)$ define such an instance and that $\ell_B \le \ell$ (Lemma 24), that the reduction rule can be applied at component level and does not disturb the other components (Lemma 25), and the bound $r \le 2\ell_B$ on the number of irreducible components (Lemma 26; this re-derives, for components, the counting argument of BFK Lemma 3.2 and Lemma 6.5 instead of citing it). *The following rest on the published proofs of [14] and are not reproved here:* (i) soundness of their Reduction Rule 6.2 for an arbitrary induced subgraph $G[W]$ (their Lemma 6.3, whose proof uses only G, W and the optimal solution S of $G[W]$); (ii) the time to test and apply the rule (their Lemma 6.4); (iii) the algorithm of Böcker running in $O(1.62^k + n + m)$ and the kernel with at most $2k$ vertices for Cluster Editing, both as quoted in [14] (we have not opened the original sources).

Lemma 24 (The components form a packing in the sense of [14]). *Let* $G_j = G[W_j]$, $\tau_j = \mathrm{OPT}(G_j)$, $k = |H| + \ell$ *and* $\ell' = k - \sum_j \tau_j$.

1. *The sets W_j are pairwise disjoint and each G_j is an induced subgraph.*
2. *$p_j \le \tau_j \le \lfloor \binom{s}{2}/2 \rfloor =: t_s$ and $\tau_j \ge 1$.*
3. *$\ell' = \ell - \sum_j (\tau_j - p_j) \le \ell$.*
4. *For every solution S of G and every j, $S_j := S \cap \binom{W_j}{2}$ is a solution of G_j, so $|S_j| \ge \tau_j$; the sets $\binom{W_j}{2}$ are pairwise disjoint, so $|S| \ge \sum_j \tau_j + |S_{\text{ext}}|$ where S_{ext} are the pairs of S inside no W_j. In particular $\mathrm{OPT}(G) \ge \sum_j \tau_j$, and if $\ell' < 0$ then (G, H, ℓ) is a NO instance.*

Proof. (1) A vertex in $W_i \cap W_j$, $i \ne j$, lies in a P_3 of C_i and in a P_3 of C_j; these are adjacent in $I(H)$, contradicting that C_i, C_j are different components. Induced by definition.

(2) The P_3's of C_j are induced P_3's of G_j with pairwise disjoint pair sets inside $\binom{W_j}{2}$. A solution of G_j must edit a pair of each of them (otherwise the triple survives as an induced P_3, as in Lemma 1); hence $\tau_j \ge p_j \ge 1$. For the upper bound, let m_j be the number of edges of G_j; deleting all edges, or inserting all non-edges, yields a cluster graph, so $\tau_j \le \min(m_j, \binom{|W_j|}{2} - m_j) \le \binom{|W_j|}{2}/2 \le \binom{s}{2}/2$.

(3) $|H| = \sum_j p_j$ because the components partition H.

(4) $(G \triangle S)[W_j] = G_j \triangle S_j$ is an induced subgraph of a cluster graph, hence a cluster graph. The rest is counting with disjoint pair sets. □

Thus (G, H, ℓ) is a YES instance iff $(G, \{G_j\}, k)$ is a YES instance of the problem of [14] with $t \le t_s$ and excess $\ell' \le \ell$ (answer NO if $\ell' < 0$). Note why components, not single P_3's: a pair uv with $u \in W_j$ and $v \notin W_j$ lies in no W_i at all when v is in R or in another component, hence is not counted in $\sum_j \tau_j$ and is an excess edit (Lemma 24(4)); for a packing whose members share vertices, the same pair may be a packed pair of another P_3 and is then free, which is the obstruction of [13] and the reason the argument below needs whole components.

Call component j *reducible* if G_j has an optimal solution $S_j \subseteq \binom{W_j}{2}$ such that for all $u, v \in W_j$: (R1) if u, v lie in one cluster of $G_j \triangle S_j$, then $N_G(u) \setminus W_j = N_G(v) \setminus W_j$; (R2) otherwise $N_G(u) \cap N_G(v) \subseteq W_j$. This is Reduction Rule 6.2 of [14] for $H = G_j$.

Lemma 25 (Rule 6.2 at component level)**.** *If component j is reducible with S_j, then $(G, \{G_i\}, k)$ is a YES instance iff $(G \triangle S_j, \{G_i\}_{i \ne j}, k - \tau_j)$ is. In the new instance the graphs G_i ($i \ne j$) are unchanged, still vertex-disjoint and induced, with the same τ_i; the excess ℓ' is unchanged; and for every $i \ne j$ the conditions (R1), (R2), hence reducibility, are unchanged. So one pass over the components, in any order, reaches an instance in which no component is reducible.*

Proof. The equivalence is Lemma 6.3 of [14] (cited; sound for every induced subgraph). Both k and $\sum \tau$ drop by τ_j. The set S_j consists of pairs with both ends in W_j, so no pair incident to a vertex of W_i, $i \ne j$, changes: $G[W_i]$ and all neighbourhoods $N(u)$, $u \in W_i$, are the same before and after, and (R1), (R2) for i refer only to these. □

Lemma 26 (Number of irreducible components)**.** *Let $(G, \{G_j\}_{j \le r}, k)$ be a YES instance with $\ell' = k - \sum_j \tau_j$ in which no component is reducible. Then $r \le 2\ell'$.*

Proof. Let S be an optimum of G, so $|S| \le k$. *Claim:* for every j, (a) $|S_j| \ge \tau_j + 1$, or (b) S contains a pair with exactly one end in W_j (an *external* pair of j). Suppose (a) fails; then $|S_j| = \tau_j$ by Lemma 24(4), so S_j is an optimal solution of G_j, and since j is not reducible, S_j violates (R1) or (R2). In $G \triangle S$ the induced subgraph on W_j is the cluster graph $G_j \triangle S_j$. Case (R1) violated: $u, v \in W_j$ are in one cluster of $G_j \triangle S_j$, so $uv \in E(G \triangle S)$ and, $G \triangle S$ being a cluster graph, $N_{G \triangle S}[u] = N_{G \triangle S}[v]$; but there is $y \notin W_j$ adjacent in G to exactly one of them, so one of

uy, vy is in S: an external pair. Case (R2) violated: u, v are in different clusters of $G_j \triangle S_j$, hence non-adjacent in $G \triangle S$, and have a common G-neighbour $y \notin W_j$; if neither uy nor vy were in S, then $u\,y\,v$ would be an induced P_3 of $G \triangle S$. So again an external pair is in S.

Let J_a be the indices satisfying (a) and J_b the others, which satisfy (b). An external pair of j has exactly one end in W_j; it lies in no $\binom{W_i}{2}$ (for $i = j$ because of the end outside, for $i \neq j$ because $W_i \cap W_j = \emptyset$ and one end is in W_j), so it belongs to S_{ext}, and it is external for at most two indices (the components containing its ends). Hence $|S_{\text{ext}}| \geq |J_b|/2$. Since $|S| = \sum_j |S_j| + |S_{\text{ext}}|$ (disjoint pair sets), $|S| \geq \sum_{j \in J_a} (\tau_j + 1) + \sum_{j \in J_b} \tau_j + |J_b|/2 \geq \sum_j \tau_j + r/2$. With $|S| \leq k$ this reads $\ell' \geq r/2$. □

The bound is on irreducible components, not on components with positive excess $\tau_j > p_j$: a reducible component may have large internal excess, and it is removed by Lemma 25 at no cost in ℓ'.

Proof of Theorem 22. Algorithm. (1) Compute the components of $I(H)$, the optima τ_j by the subset dynamic programme over W_j ($O(3^{|W_j|})$), and ℓ'; if $\ell' < 0$ answer NO (Lemma 24(4)). (2) For each component test reducibility and, if reducible, apply the rule (Lemma 25); the test of [14, Lemma 6.4] needs a constant number of exact cluster-editing computations on subgraphs of G_j plus polynomial time, which the subset programme provides in $O(3^{|W_j|})$ each. (3) Let r^* be the number of remaining components. If $r^* > 2\ell'$, answer NO (Lemma 26, contrapositive). Otherwise the current instance has budget $k^* = \sum_{\text{remaining}} \tau_j + \ell' \leq r^* t_s + \ell' \leq (2t_s + 1)\ell'$. Forget the packing and solve plain Cluster Editing with budget k^* by Böcker's algorithm in $O(1.62^{k^*} + n + m)$.

Correctness follows from Lemma 24 (the instance is of the required form and ℓ' is the excess), Lemma 25 (steps preserve the answer), and Lemma 26.

Time. The components have at least 3 vertices and are disjoint, so there are at most $n/3$ of them and steps (1), (2) take $O(n3^s) + n^{O(1)}$. Step (3) takes $1.62^{k^*} n^{O(1)}$ with $k^* \leq (2t_s+1)\ell' \leq (\binom{s}{2}+1)\ell$, since $2t_s \leq \binom{s}{2}$ and $\ell' \leq \ell$.

Kernel. After step (2) and the checks of step (3), apply the kernelization of Cluster Editing with at most $2k^*$ vertices (cited via [14]) to (G, k^*) and add the empty packing: an equivalent CEaMP instance with empty packing, budget $\leq k^*$ and at most $2k^* \leq (4t_s+2)\ell \leq (s^2 - s + 2)\ell$ vertices. □

Remark 27 (Scope). Theorem 22 is FPT in (ℓ, s); it does not answer the main question, since s is not bounded by a function of w (a path or tree $I(H)$ has $w \leq 1$ and arbitrarily large components), and the exponent $\binom{s}{2}\ell$ is of no practical interest. The argument uses neither pair-maximality nor Section 5. For a perfect matching it covers the smallest non-trivial instance of the case $c = 2$ left open in [13] for FPT in ℓ.

7 Structure of solutions with respect to a packing

This section collects counting lemmas that hold for every packing H (no maximality unless stated) and describe what a solution of size at most $|H| + \ell$ can look like. All proofs use only pair-disjointness, a budget, and counting; none uses optimality of the solution. The lemmas *do not* give an FPT algorithm in $\ell + w$ and no hardness; see Section 7.6 for what they do and do not explain, and Section 14.

Conventions. Here a pair is *hard* if it is not packed (in the language of the previous sections: *unpacked*); a *hard edge* is a hard pair in E and a *hard non-edge* a hard pair outside E. For a packing H let $c = c(H)$ be the maximum number of members of H through a vertex, $D = D(H) =$

$\max_v |Q(v)|$ the maximum number of packed partners, and $w = \mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ (with $w = 0$ if $I(H)$ has no edge). A triple (G, H, ℓ) is a *YES instance* if $\mathrm{OPT}(G) \le |H| + \ell$. A *family* F of induced P_3's is *hard over* H if the sets $\mathrm{pairs}(P)$, $P \in F$, are pairwise disjoint and disjoint from the packed pairs of H; then $H \cup F$ is a packing with $|H| + |F|$ members.

Lemma 28 (Degrees)**.** *For every vertex v, $|Q(v)| = 2\,|\{P \in H : v \in P\}|$. Hence $D = 2c \le 2(w+1)$.*

Proof. Each member $P \ni v$ contributes the two packed pairs of P at v, i.e. two partners. Two members through v cannot have a common partner $x \ne v$, since they would then share the two vertices v, x, hence a pair. So the partner sets are disjoint and $|Q(v)| = 2|\{P \ni v\}|$. The inequality $c \le w + 1$ is stated in Section 2. □

7.1 Maximalisation and the hard-edge lemma

Lemma 29 (Hard families)**.** *Let H be any packing, (G, H, ℓ) a YES instance and F a family hard over H. Then $|F| \le \ell$. In general* $\mathrm{OPT} \ge |H| + |F|$.

Proof. $H \cup F$ is a modification-disjoint packing of $|H| + |F|$ induced P_3's. Lemma 1, applied to $H \cup F$ and an optimum solution, gives $\mathrm{OPT} \ge |H| + |F|$. In a YES instance $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$. □

Lemma 30 (MAX: maximalisation)**.** *Let H be any packing and M a maximal family hard over H (inclusion-maximal; it is found greedily in polynomial time). Put $H' = H \cup M$, $\ell' = \ell - |M|$. Then:*

(a) $\mathrm{OPT} \ge |H'|$. *In particular $|M| > \ell$ implies that (G, H, ℓ) is a NO instance.*

(b) $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$ *iff* ($|M| \le \ell$ *and* $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H'| + \ell'$). *So (G, H, ℓ) and (G, H', ℓ') are equivalent whenever $\ell' \ge 0$.*

(c) H' is a packing and is pair-maximal: no induced P_3 of G has all three pairs unpacked with respect to H'. ("Hard" now means hard with respect to H'; the pairs of M have become packed.)

(d) $\mathrm{tw}(I(H')) \le \mathrm{tw}(I(H)) + |M|$, *hence $w' \le w + |M| \le w + \ell$.*

(e) $c' \le \min\{c + |M|,\ w' + 1\}$ *and* $D' = 2c' \le D + 2|M|$.

A tree decomposition of $I(H')$ of width at most $w + |M|$ is obtained in polynomial time from one of $I(H)$.

Proof. (a) is Lemma 29 (first sentence: $\mathrm{OPT} \ge |H| + |M|$). (b) If $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$ then $|M| \le \ell$ by (a), and $|H'| + \ell' = |H| + \ell$. Conversely $|M| \le \ell$ and $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H'| + \ell' = |H| + \ell$. So (b) is arithmetic once (a) is known.

(c) The members of M have pairwise disjoint pair sets, disjoint from those of H, so H' is a packing. Suppose an induced P_3 Q has all its pairs hard with respect to H'. Then $\mathrm{pairs}(Q)$ is disjoint from $\mathrm{pairs}(H)$ and from $\mathrm{pairs}(P)$ for all $P \in M$, so $M \cup \{Q\}$ is a family hard over H ($Q \notin M$ because the pairs of Q are not in $\mathrm{pairs}(M)$), contradicting maximality of M.

(d) Let $(T, \{B_t\})$ be a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w (if $H = \emptyset$ take a single empty bag). The graph $I(H')$ has node set $H \cup M$ and $I(H')[H] = I(H)$. Put $B'_t = B_t \cup M$. Every node of H still occupies a connected subtree. Every node of M occupies all of T, which is connected. An edge of $I(H')$ with both ends in H is covered as before; an edge with an end $P \in M$ is covered by any bag containing its other end (every node of H lies in some bag; if both ends are in M every bag covers it). Bags have at most $w + 1 + |M|$ nodes, so the width is at most $w + |M|$.

(e) At most $|M|$ members of M pass through a vertex, so $c' \le c + |M|$; $c' \le w' + 1$ is Section 2 for H'. By Lemma 28, $D' = 2c' \le 2c + 2|M| = D + 2|M|$. □

The bound in (d) cannot be improved in general.

Example 31 (Tightness of (d))**.** Let G be the star with centre v and leaves $p, q, a_1, b_1, \ldots, a_m, b_m$, $H = \{(p, v, q)\}$ and $M = \{(a_i, v, b_i) : 1 \le i \le m\}$. The members of M are induced P_3's with pairwise disjoint pair sets, disjoint from pairs(H). M is maximal: every induced P_3 of a star is (x, v, y) with leaves x, y, and every pair xv is already packed. $I(H)$ is one node, tw $= 0$; $I(H \cup M) = K_{m+1}$, tw $= m = 0 + |M|$.

After applying Lemma 30, all the other lemmas of this section have to be applied to the primed instance (G, H', ℓ') with parameters $w' \le w + |M|$, $c' \le c + |M|$, $D' \le D + 2|M|$ and $\ell' = \ell - |M|$. This is the same normalisation as Remark 2, with the cost in treewidth made explicit.

Lemma 32 (HE: hard edges close up)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal and let ab, bc be hard edges (a, b, c distinct). Then $ac \in E$ or ac is packed.*

Proof. If $ac \notin E$ and ac were hard, then $a\,b\,c$ would be an induced P_3 with all three pairs unpacked, contradicting pair-maximality. So $ac \in E$ or ac is packed. □

No YES hypothesis is needed. Without pair-maximality the lemma fails ($H = \emptyset$ and any induced P_3). For an arbitrary packing H one applies it to $H' = H \cup M$ of Lemma 30(c), with "hard" meaning hard with respect to H'.

7.2 Hubs

Lemma 33 (HUB$^+$)**.** *Let H be any packing, (G, H, ℓ) a YES instance, u a vertex and $N_h(u) = \{x : ux \in E,\ ux \text{ not packed}\}$. Let Γ_u be the graph on $N_h(u)$ whose edges are the pairs $\{x, y\}$ with $xy \notin E$ and xy not packed (hard non-edges). Then:*

(a) $\nu(\Gamma_u) \le \ell$ (matching number);

(b) Γ_u has a vertex cover T with $|T| \le 2\ell$, and every pair of $N_h(u) \setminus T$ is an edge of G or is packed;

(c) $\alpha(G[N_h(u)]) \le 2\ell + c + 1$ where $c = c(H)$.

Proof. (a) Let $x_1y_1, \ldots, x_ty_t$ be a matching of Γ_u and $P_i = (x_i, u, y_i)$. Since $ux_i, uy_i \in E$ and $x_iy_i \notin E$, P_i is an induced P_3. Its three pairs ux_i, uy_i, x_iy_i are hard. The $2t$ vertices x_i, y_i are distinct and different from u, so the pairs ux_i, uy_i ($i \le t$) are pairwise distinct, and the pairs x_iy_i are pairwise distinct and do not contain u. So $\{P_1, \ldots, P_t\}$ is hard over H and $t \le \ell$ by Lemma 29.

(b) The vertex set of a maximum matching of Γ_u is a vertex cover (by maximality) of size $2\nu \le 2\ell$. A pair of $N_h(u) \setminus T$ is not an edge of Γ_u, i.e. it is an edge of G or packed.

(c) Let J be independent in $G[N_h(u)]$. By (b), every pair of $J \setminus T$ is a non-edge of G and not an edge of Γ_u, hence packed. Put $J' = J \setminus T$. A packed pair of J' lies in a member P of H and is a non-edge, so it is the pair of the two ends of P (the other two pairs of P are edges); in particular $|V(P) \cap J'| \le 2$. If $J' \ne \emptyset$ fix $x \in J'$; every $y \in J' \setminus \{x\}$ gives a member $P_y \ni x, y$, and $P_y \ne P_{y'}$ for $y \ne y'$ because $|V(P_y) \cap J'| \le 2$. So $|J'| - 1 \le c$. Hence $|J| \le |T| + |J'| \le 2\ell + c + 1$. □

Corollary 34 (HUB, hard-independent sets)**.** *In the setting of Lemma 33, if $X \subseteq N_h(u)$ and every pair of X is a hard non-edge, then $|X| \le 2\ell + 1$.*

Proof. X is a clique of Γ_u, so it contains a matching of size $\lfloor |X|/2 \rfloor$, and $\lfloor |X|/2 \rfloor \le \ell$ by Lemma 33(a). □

Remark 35 (HUB$^+$ versus an independence-number bound). (1) Bounding $\alpha(G[N_h(u)])$ through the corollary (greedy choice of a subset of an independent set that is also free of packed pairs) gives only $(c+1)(2\ell+1) = (D/2+1)(2\ell+1)$, which is weaker than (c). (2) The matching form (a) is the relevant statement for Vertex Cover on the non-adjacency graph of $N(u)$: let $N_h(u)$ be two disjoint cliques of G of size m with no packed pair between them. Then $\alpha = 2$, but (a_i, u, b_i), a_i, b_i from different cliques, are m pair-disjoint induced P_3's, and $m \le \ell$ in a YES instance. Large independent sets are not the obstruction; large matchings of Γ_u are. (3) For a general H the lemma is applied to H' of Lemma 30 with c', ℓ'.

7.3 Pieces and small merges

Fix a packing H and a solution S ($G \triangle S$ is a cluster graph) with $|S| \le |H| + \ell$. Let $U = S \setminus \bigcup_i \text{pairs}(P_i)$ be the unpacked part and $u = |U|$; by Lemma 1, $u \le |S| - |H| \le \ell$. Put $F = U \cap E$ (deleted hard edges) and $I = U \setminus E$ (inserted hard pairs). The *pieces of* S are the connected components of the graph (V, K), $K = \{\text{hard edges of } G\} \setminus F$ (kept hard edges); isolated vertices are singleton pieces. *Pieces depend on S, not only on (G, H).* Every edge of K is an edge of $G \triangle S$, so every piece lies inside one cluster of $G \triangle S$.

Lemma 36 (SM: small merge)**.** *Let S, u, I, pieces as above, $D \ge \max_v |Q(v)|$ (e.g. $D = D(H)$), and let C be a cluster of $G \triangle S$.*

(i) If $A \ne B$ are pieces contained in C, then every pair ab ($a \in A, b \in B$) is packed or belongs to I.

(ii) For such A, B with $|A| \ge |B|$: $|B|\,(|A| - D) \le |I \cap (A \times B)| \le u$, hence $|A| \le D + u \le D + \ell$.

(iii) If C is the union of at least two pieces, then $|C| \le \max\{D + u + 1,\ 2D,\ 2u\}$.

Proof. (i) Since $a, b \in C$, ab is an edge of $G \triangle S$, i.e. $ab \in E$ xor $ab \in S$. Suppose ab is hard. If $ab \in E$ then $ab \notin S$; as $F \subseteq S$, $ab \notin F$, so $ab \in K$ and a, b lie in one piece, a contradiction. So $ab \notin E$, hence $ab \in S$, and as ab is hard, $ab \in U \setminus E = I$.

(ii) Each vertex of B has at most D packed partners, so at most $D|B|$ pairs of $A \times B$ are packed. By (i) all other pairs of $A \times B$, at least $|A||B| - D|B|$, lie in I, and $|I| \le |U| = u$. If $|A| \ge D + u + 1$ then $|B|(|A| - D) \ge u + 1$ because $|B| \ge 1$, a contradiction; so $|A| \le D + u$.

(iii) Let A be a largest piece in C, $a = |A|$ and $r = |C| - a \ge 1$. By (i), every pair $\{x, y\}$ with $x, y \in C$ in different pieces is packed or in I.

Case $a > D$. Each $x \in C \setminus A$ has at most D packed partners, so at least $a - D \ge 1$ vertices $y \in A$ give a pair xy in I. These pairs are distinct for distinct (x, y), so $r(a - D) \le |I| \le u$. Then $r \le u$ and $a \le D + u/r$, so $|C| = a + r \le D + u/r + r$. The function $r \mapsto r + u/r$ is convex on $[1, u]$ and takes the value $u + 1$ at both ends, so $|C| \le D + u + 1$. (The case does not occur if $u = 0$.)

Case $a \le D$. All pieces of C have at most D vertices. Each $x \in C$ has at least $|C| - D$ vertices of C outside its piece, at most D of which are packed partners; so x lies in at least $|C| - 2D$ pairs $\{x, y\}$ of I with $y \in C$. Summing over x counts each pair twice: $2|I| \ge |C|(|C| - 2D)$. If $|C| > 2D$, then $|C| - 2D \ge 1$ and $|C| \le 2|I| \le 2u$. So $|C| \le \max\{2D, 2u\}$. □

Remark 37 (Qualifiers and relation to the original bound). (1) The qualifier "pieces sharing a cluster" is essential: a single piece may be an entire cluster of unbounded size, and a statement "pieces have size at most $D+\ell$" is false. (2) The bound (iii) implies the weaker bound $|C| \le \max\{2D+\ell, 2\ell\}$ with which the lemma first appeared in our notes: $2u \le 2\ell$ and $2D \le 2D+\ell$ are clear; $D+u+1 \le 2D+\ell$ if $D \ge 1$; if $D = 0$ and $u \ge 1$ then $u + 1 \le 2u \le 2\ell$; and if $D = u = 0$ no cluster with two pieces

exists (the two cases of the proof are both impossible). (3) The bound (iii) is attained in some small instances of our tests (slack 0), for instance two singleton pieces and one inserted pair; we do not claim it is tight in general. (4) Lemma 36 says nothing about the *degrees* in a graph of pieces; it bounds the sizes of pieces that share a cluster and the number of cross pairs that are not packed.

7.4 The soft graph has bounded treewidth

Let $W = (V, \{\text{packed pairs}\})$ be the *soft graph*.

Proposition 38 (Treewidth of the soft graph)**.** $\mathrm{tw}(W) \le 3(w+1) - 1 = 3w + 2$ *if* $H \neq \emptyset$*;* W *is edgeless if* $H = \emptyset$*. The bound is attained for* $w = 0$ *(*H *a single* P_3*,* W *a triangle).*

Proof. Let $(T, \{B_t\})$ be a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w and $T_P = \{t : P \in B_t\}$, a subtree of T for each $P \in H$. Put $B'_t = \bigcup_{P \in B_t} V(P)$, so $|B'_t| \le 3(w+1)$. For every vertex $x \notin V(H)$ add a new leaf bag $\{x\}$ to an arbitrary node. *Edges:* a packed pair lies in $V(P)$ for some $P \in H$, and $P \in B_t$ for some t, so the pair lies in B'_t. *Connectivity:* for $x \in V(H)$ the nodes t with $x \in B'_t$ form $\bigcup_{P \ni x} T_P$. The members through x pairwise share x, so they are pairwise adjacent in $I(H)$ and, the edge being covered by a bag, their subtrees T_P pairwise intersect. A union of connected subtrees that pairwise intersect is connected (two points of the union lie in subtrees $T_P, T_{P'}$ that meet; join them through a common node). The new leaf bags are single bags of size 1. So this is a tree decomposition of W of width at most $3(w+1) - 1$. □

Computationally, for $w \ge 1$ the largest value of $\mathrm{tw}(W)$ that we saw on small instances is much smaller than $3w + 2$; we do not claim the bound is tight beyond $w = 0$.

7.5 Computer verification

All statements of this section were checked by brute force with code written independently of the other scripts (`code/w5_packing_lemmas.py`, all set partitions, $n \le 8$, 4000 random graphs: random, noisy clusters, hubs; for each a random partial packing H and its maximalisation $H \cup M$): Lemma 28 ($D = 2c$), Lemma 30(a)–(e), Example 31 for $m \le 5$, Lemma 32, Lemma 33 and Corollary 34 for every vertex and every ℓ with $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell \le |H| + 3$, Lemma 36 on every solution of cost at most $|H| + 3$ (about $5.7 \cdot 10^5$ clusters with two or more pieces, including slack 0 in (iii) on some cases), and Proposition 38 (exact treewidth). No violation; the variants $\alpha \le 2\ell + c$ and $|C| \le \max\{D + u, 2D, 2u\}$ are falsified by the same script, so the checks are not vacuous. This is evidence for the statements; the proofs above are the justification.

7.6 Why simple hardness encodings fail

This subsection is a heuristic discussion, not a theorem. It explains why three natural ways of building W[1]-hardness for $\ell + w$ do not work as stated; it does not exclude other gadgets and it does not prove fixed-parameter tractability, which remains open (Open Problem 2). A reduction from a problem with parameter k must keep $\ell + w \le g(k)$; grids of side k inside $I(H)$ are therefore allowed, but structures that grow with the instance size are not.

Hub of deletions. A hub u is adjacent to vertices $x_1, \ldots, x_m$ and the instance asks to keep a subset of $N(u)$ forming a clique and delete the rest, i.e. Vertex Cover on the non-adjacency graph of $N(u)$. Lemma 33 shows what survives in a YES instance: the graph of *hard* non-adjacent pairs inside $N_h(u)$ has a matching of size at most ℓ and a vertex cover of size at most 2ℓ, so at most 2ℓ hub neighbours carry hard conflicts; the other non-adjacencies are adjacencies or packed pairs, and a

vertex has at most $2c$ of the latter. The relevant obstruction is a large matching (Remark 35(2)), not a large independent set, and any such matching immediately forces a NO answer. Non-adjacencies realised by packed pairs are local, with degree at most $2c \leq 2(w+1)$ in the soft graph. This is why Vertex Cover through a hub cannot encode an unbounded source graph; it does not address hubs whose conflicts are realised by packed pairs; a vertex has at most $2c$ of these, so many of them force large c, hence large w.

Hub of insertions. A hub u with classes $V_1, \ldots, V_k$ chooses, by inserting uv_{i,j_i}, one vertex per class; the selected vertices land in one cluster C and compatibility is encoded by adjacency of the chosen vertices. By Lemma 36(i), two selected vertices in different pieces of C form a packed pair or an inserted pair (at most ℓ of these); adjacency by a hard edge that is not deleted puts them in the same piece, and Lemma 36(ii) bounds the size of merged pieces by $D + \ell$. So the compatibility relation between selected vertices in different pieces can only be realised by packed pairs, which form the soft graph, of treewidth at most $3w + 2$ (Proposition 38), or by a bounded number of inserted pairs. The caveats: Lemma 36 bounds sizes of pieces, not the degree of a compatibility graph; at most ℓ hard edges may be deleted, which a gadget could exploit; and pieces depend on the chosen solution. The argument shows that the hard graph cannot serve as a channel for $[n]$-valued information between selected vertices, nothing more.

Grid tiling. A tile vertex t_{ab} is joined by hard edges to a row vertex x_a and a column vertex y_b ($x_a y_b$ a non-edge). The triples (x_a, t_{ab}, y_b) are induced P_3's; if their pairs are hard they are pairwise pair-disjoint (their pairs are $x_a t_{ab}$, $t_{ab} y_b$, $x_a y_b$, all different for different (a, b)), so by Lemma 29 at most ℓ of them can be hard, whereas a grid-tiling encoding needs about n^2 tiles and n is not bounded by $g(k)$. So all but at most ℓ of them are packed; then some row vertex x_a lies in at least $n - \ell$ members (if every row has n tiles), $c \geq n - \ell$, hence $w \geq n - \ell - 1$, again unbounded in k. Mixed and replicated gadgets (several copies of row and column vertices, tiles realised by chains) were not excluded by a proof; the examination in our notes found no variant that carries information on $[n]$ across a tree decomposition of bounded width, which is evidence only.

What remains open. The lemmas above make every "simple" source of unbounded information in $I(H)$-width-bounded instances expensive. They do not bound the candidate positions of inserted pairs between pieces. Sections 8 and 9 go further: the inserted pairs of an optimal solution are local for type T1, in particular for merges of pieces with no soft pair between them, but not in general (Proposition 45), and given one endpoint of an edited hard pair the other has a bounded candidate set (Corollary 54). The FPT question for $\ell + w$ stays an open problem.

8 Locality of inserted pairs in optimal solutions

Section 7 bounds the *number* of unpacked edits and the *size* of merged pieces, but not the number of candidate *positions* of an unpacked edit; a positive answer to Open Problem 2 would need such a bound. This section studies the inserted unpacked pairs of an *optimal* solution. The main tool is an elementary diameter bound for clusters of optimal solutions (Lemma 39), which, combined with pair-maximality, classifies every inserted pair into one of two types (Theorem 40). Pairs of the first type are local in a decomposition of $I(H)$ (Corollary 41, Proposition 43); we then show that the second type, which includes the generic merge of two pieces, is *not* local in the same sense (Proposition 45). **Nothing in this section gives an FPT algorithm in $\ell + w$ or a hardness result**; Section 8.6 states exactly what is left.

Setting. Throughout, H is *pair-maximal* (for an arbitrary packing apply Lemma 30 first and read all parameters for H'). A pair is *soft* if it is packed and *hard* otherwise; $Q(v)$ is the set of soft partners of v, $D \geq \max_v |Q(v)|$ and, for $D = D(H) = 2c$, $|Q(v)| \leq D$ (Lemma 28). S is an *optimal* solution, $|S| = \mathrm{OPT}(G)$, C is a cluster of $G \triangle S$, $U = S \setminus \bigcup_i \mathrm{pairs}(P_i)$, $u = |U|$, $F = U \cap E$, $I = U \setminus E$, and the *pieces* are the components of the graph of kept hard edges, as in Section 7. An *inserted pair* is a pair of I: a hard non-edge of G inside one cluster. A hard edge of G inside a cluster is an edge of $G \triangle S$ and not in S, hence kept; so its ends lie in one piece. Cross pairs between two pieces inside one cluster are soft or inserted (Lemma 36(i)).

8.1 Clusters of optimal solutions have diameter at most two

Lemma 39 (Half-degree and diameter)**.** *Let S be an optimal solution, C a cluster of $G \triangle S$ and $v \in C$. Put $d_C(v) = |N_G(v) \cap C|$.*

(a) $d_C(v) \geq (|C| - 1)/2$.

(b) If $a, b \in C$ and $ab \notin E$, then some $z \in C \setminus \{a, b\}$ has $az, zb \in E$.

Proof. (a) Let $S' = S \triangle \{vx : x \in C \setminus \{v\}\}$. Then $G \triangle S'$ is $G \triangle S$ with v cut off from the rest of C, a cluster graph. For $x \in C \setminus \{v\}$ with $vx \in E$ the pair $vx \notin S$ and $vx \in S'$: this adds $d_C(v)$ pairs. For $x \in C \setminus \{v\}$ with $vx \notin E$ the pair is in S and not in S': this removes $|C| - 1 - d_C(v)$ pairs. All other pairs are unchanged. So $|S'| = |S| + 2d_C(v) - (|C| - 1)$, and $|S'| \geq |S|$ by optimality.

(b) $N_G(a) \cap C$ and $N_G(b) \cap C$ are subsets of $C \setminus \{a, b\}$ (as $a \notin N(a)$ and $ab \notin E$), a set with $|C| - 2$ elements, while $d_C(a) + d_C(b) \geq |C| - 1$ by (a). So the two sets intersect. □

Lemma 39 uses neither H nor ℓ; only local optimality under single-vertex moves is used.

8.2 The T1/T2 dichotomy

Theorem 40 (T1/T2)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal, S an optimal solution and ab an inserted pair, $a, b \in C$. Then there is $z \in C \setminus \{a, b\}$ with $az, zb \in E$, and exactly one of the following holds.*

(T1) az and zb are both soft. Then they are owned by two distinct *members $P_a \neq P_b$ of H, and $z \in V(P_a) \cap V(P_b)$.*

(T2) Exactly one of az, zb is hard, say az (otherwise swap a, b). Then az is a kept hard edge, so a and z lie in one piece, and zb is soft.

Proof. Take z from Lemma 39(b). If az and zb were both hard, then $a\,z\,b$ would be an induced P_3 with all three pairs hard (ab is hard by assumption), contradicting pair-maximality. If both are soft, let P_a, P_b own az, zb. If $P_a = P_b$ then $a, b \in V(P_a)$ and ab is packed, contradicting that ab is hard; so $P_a \neq P_b$, and both contain z. If az is hard, it is a hard edge inside C, hence kept. □

Corollary 41 (Locality of soft-free merges)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal, S optimal, and let $A \neq B$ be pieces inside one cluster C such that* no soft pair joins A and B. *Then for every $(a, b) \in A \times B$:*

(i) ab is an inserted pair;

(ii) there is $z \in C \setminus (A \cup B)$ with az, zb soft, owned by distinct members $P_a \neq P_b$ with $z \in V(P_a) \cap V(P_b)$;

(iii) given a, the number of possible partners b in any such pair is at most $D(D-2) = 4c(c-1)$, where $D = D(H) = 2c$.

In particular a and b are at distance exactly 2 in the soft graph W, and $A \cup B$ lies in the ball of radius 4 of W around any of its vertices.

Proof. (i) The cross pair ab is not soft by hypothesis, so it is hard. A hard edge inside C would be kept and would put a, b into one piece. So ab is a hard non-edge in a cluster, i.e. inserted.

(ii) Apply Theorem 40 to ab. In case (T2), say az is hard (the other case is symmetric); then z lies in the piece A of a. The pair zb is an edge of G and joins A to B: if it were hard it would be kept and z, b would share a piece, contradicting $A \neq B$; if soft it contradicts the hypothesis. So (T1) holds. If $z \in A$, then zb (soft) is a soft pair between A and B; similarly for $z \in B$ and az. So $z \notin A \cup B$.

(iii) Fix a. By (ii) $z \in Q(a)$: at most D choices. For such z, let P_a own az. The vertex b satisfies bz soft owned by $P_b \neq P_a$, and $b \notin V(P_a)$ (otherwise $ab \in \text{pairs}(P_a)$ is packed). Now $Q(z) \cap V(P_a) = V(P_a) \setminus \{z\}$ has two elements, so $b \in Q(z) \setminus V(P_a)$, a set of at most $|Q(z)| - 2 \leq D - 2$ vertices. Altogether at most $D(D-2) = 2c(2c-2) = 4c(c-1)$ partners. (For $c = 1$ the count is 0, as it must be: (T1) needs two members through z.)

The distance statement: ab is not soft and a, z, b is a soft path; so $d_W(a, b) = 2$. Every $a' \in A$ has $d_W(a', b) = 2$ for a fixed $b \in B$, and every $b' \in B$ has $d_W(b', a') = 2$; hence all of $A \cup B$ is within distance 4 of b (and of any other vertex of $A \cup B$, by symmetry). □

Remark 42 (Scope; what the corollary does not say). By Lemma 36, if no soft pair joins A and B then all $|A||B|$ cross pairs are inserted, so $|A||B| \leq u \leq \ell$. The corollary covers *only* merges without a soft pair between the pieces. Merges in which some cross pairs are soft (the generic case when the pieces are neighbours in the soft graph) are not covered, and Proposition 45 shows they can genuinely be of type (T2). Note also that in terms of soft distance the bound in (iii) is the number of vertices at soft distance exactly 2 with the stated restrictions; the content of (ii) is that in the soft-free case *every* cross pair is at soft distance 2.

Proposition 43 (Bag locality of type (T1) pairs)**.** *Let $(T, \{X_t\})$ be a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w, let $c = c(H)$, and for a set Y of nodes of $I(H)$ let $N[Y]$ be the set of nodes at distance at most 1 from Y (a set of* members of H*).*

(a) If ab is an inserted pair of type (T1) with members P_a, P_b as in Theorem 40, then P_a, P_b are adjacent in $I(H)$, so some bag X_t contains both and $a, b \in \bigcup_{P \in X_t} V(P)$, a set of at most $3(w+1)$ vertices. Moreover the member through z and every member through a or b lies in $N[X_t]$.

(b) $(T, \{N[X_t]\})$ is a tree decomposition of the square $I(H)^2$ of width at most $(w+1)(3c-2)-1 \leq (w+1)(3w+1)-1$.

Proof. (a) P_a, P_b share z, so they are adjacent in $I(H)$ and, the edge being covered, lie in a common bag. Every member through a contains $a \in V(P_a)$, hence meets $P_a \in X_t$ and lies in $N[X_t]$; similarly for b and z.

(b) *Size.* Each member has 3 vertices, each lying in at most c members, so $I(H)$ has maximum degree at most $3(c-1)$, $|N[X_t]| \leq (w+1)(1+3(c-1)) = (w+1)(3c-2)$, and $c \leq w+1$. *Connectivity.* For a node v let $T_v = \{t : v \in X_t\}$ (a subtree). The nodes t with $v \in N[X_t]$ form $\bigcup_{y \in N[v]} T_y$. Each T_y, $y \in N(v)$, meets T_v because the edge yv lies in some bag; a union of subtrees that all meet the connected set T_v is connected. *Edges.* Let yv be an edge of $I(H)^2$. If y, v are adjacent in $I(H)$, any $t \in T_y$ has $y \in X_t$ and $v \in N[y]$. If they have a common neighbour m, any $t \in T_m$ has $y, v \in N[m] \subseteq N[X_t]$. □

A type (T1) pointer is therefore a pair of vertices inside one bag of a decomposition of bounded width, and, given one end, it has at most $4c(c-1)$ candidate partners in the soft-free case. No identity problem between far bags arises for these pointers.

8.3 Near-twin agreement and anchored candidates

Lemma 44 (Near-twin agreement)**.** *Let S be any solution (optimal or not), $u = |U|$, and let $z \neq b$ lie in one cluster of $G \triangle S$. Then*

$$A(z,b) = \big\{a \notin \{z,b\} : \ az, ab \text{ both hard}, \ [az \in E] \neq [ab \in E]\big\}$$

has at most u elements. In particular, if zb is soft, the set $M(z,b) = N_h(z) \setminus (N[b] \cup Q(b))$, where $N_h(z)$ is the set of hard neighbours of z, satisfies $|M(z,b)| \leq u \leq |S| - |H|$ and is computable from G and H alone.

Proof. Let $a \in A(z,b)$. Exactly one of az, ab is a hard edge and the other a hard non-edge. If a lies in the cluster of z, b, the hard non-edge is a hard non-edge inside a cluster, so it is in U. If a lies in another cluster, the hard edge joins two different clusters, so it is deleted and in U. Assign to a this pair. Its ends are a and one of z, b; since $a \notin \{z,b\}$, the map $a \mapsto$ pair is injective. So $|A(z,b)| \leq u$. For the second statement, $a \in M(z,b)$ means $a \neq z$, az a hard edge, $a \notin N[b]$ (so $a \neq b$ and $ab \notin E$) and ab not soft. Thus $a \in A(z,b)$. □

Lemma 44 is the sense in which a far end of a type (T2) pointer is determined by its anchor: in (T2) with az hard and zb soft, $a \in M(z,b)$, a set of at most ℓ vertices determined by the *soft* pair (z,b). It does not say where a is relative to z in $I(H)$: a is a hard neighbour of z.

8.4 Merge pointers need not be bag-local

Proposition 45 (Computer-assisted examples)**.** *Each of the following instances (graph G on vertices $0, \ldots, n-1$ given by its edge list, H given by triples (x,y,z) with centre y) has a pair-maximal modification-disjoint packing H and a unique optimal solution, found by enumerating all set partitions of the vertex set.*

(a) $n = 7$, $E = \{03, 04, 12, 13, 14, 15, 23, 35, 36\}$, $H = \{(4,1,5), (0,3,2), (1,3,6)\}$. $\mathrm{OPT} = 4 = |H| + 1$*; the clusters are* $\{0,4\}, \{1,2,3,5\}, \{6\}$*. The pieces of* $\{1,2,3,5\}$ *are* $\{1,2\}$ *and* $\{3,5\}$ *(kept hard edges* 12 *and* 35*); the cross pairs* $13, 15, 23$ *are soft and* 25 *is inserted.* $Q(2) = \{0,3\}$ *and* $Q(5) = \{4,1\}$ *are disjoint, so the pair* 25*, whose ends lie in two different pieces, has no common soft neighbour: it is of type (T2) and not of type (T1).*

(b) $n = 8$, $E = \{02, 06, 14, 16, 17, 23, 25, 37, 45, 46, 47, 57\}$, $H = \{(0,6,4), (3,7,4), (2,5,4), (0,2,3), (6,1,7)\}$. $\mathrm{OPT} = 6 = |H| + 1$*; the clusters are* $\{0,6\}, \{1,4,5,7\}, \{2,3\}$*; the only unpacked pair of the solution is the inserted pair* 15*; the pieces are* $\{1,4\}$ *and* $\{5,7\}$*, the cross pairs* $17, 45, 47$ *are soft,* $Q(1) = \{6,7\}$*,* $Q(5) = \{2,4\}$*.*

(c) $n = 6$, $E = \{02, 03, 04, 05, 12, 13, 15, 25, 35, 45\}$, $H = \{(3,5,4), (0,2,1)\}$*. The unique optimum has clusters* $\{0,1,2,3,5\}, \{4\}$ *and* $\mathrm{OPT} = 4$*; it contains the inserted pair* 23 *(type (T2):* 30 *hard and kept,* 02 *soft), but* 2 *and* 3 *lie in the* same *piece (the kept hard edges* $03, 05, 13, 15, 25$ *connect* $\{0,1,2,3,5\}$*).*

Consequently "every inserted pair with both ends in $V(H)$ has a common soft neighbour" is false, and the statement of Corollary 41 cannot be extended to merges of two pieces that are joined by a soft pair: (a) and (b) are such merges, with inserted pairs of type (T2).

Proof. Direct enumeration (all 877, 4140 and 203 set partitions of 7, 8 and 6 vertices respectively) of the cost $|\{ab : (ab \in E) \neq (a, b \text{ in one block})\}|$, together with a check that each triple of H is an induced P_3, that the triples have pairwise disjoint pair sets and that no induced P_3 of G has all pairs unpacked. Examples (a) and (c) were found by an independent search in the audit of our notes, (b) in the notes themselves; all three were re-checked for this paper. The structural claims (pieces, soft pairs, Q) are read off from the lists above. □

Remark 46 (Size of the examples). An exhaustive search over all labelled graphs and all pair-maximal packings with $n \leq 5$ found no instance in which every optimum has an inserted pair with both ends in $V(H)$ and no common soft neighbour (computer evidence of the audit; not a theorem). Example (c) ($n = 6$) is intra-piece; the smallest merge-type example found has $n = 7$ (none in 7,509 random draws at $n = 6$, 9 in 7,815 at $n = 7$).

Remark 47 (Far type (T2) evidence is intra-piece). In the notes' experiments with H equal to three vertex-disjoint P_3's ($c = 1$, $n = 9$) there are instances in which every optimum contains an inserted pair between vertices of different members of H, hence at infinite distance in $I(H)$ (computer observation, reproduced in the audit). In the instance examined in the audit (inserted pair 58 in every one of its six optima) the two ends lie in the *same piece*: the cluster is $\{4, 5, 7, 8\}$ with kept hard edges $47, 48, 57$. The pair is determined by hard connectivity, i.e. by G, and is not a free pointer between two pieces. In the audit's search ($n = 9$, three disjoint P_3's, 324 valid random instances) no instance had a merge-type inserted pair between different members in every optimum. So this evidence shows non-locality only for intra-piece insertions; *whether merge pointers between pieces can be forced at unbounded $I(H)$-distance is open* (neither proved nor refuted; larger instances than $n = 9$, $c = 1$ would be needed).

8.5 Computer evidence

For every set partition of $n = 6, \ldots, 9$ vertices of about 1,900 pair-maximal instances (random, noisy clusters, hubs, sparse, algebraic gadgets, random and overlapping maximal packings), and for $\approx$ 5,700 optimal partitions found by an ILP solver for $n = 11, 12, 13$, the notes' checker tested Theorem 40, Corollary 41 and Lemma 44: no violations among 7,082 + 5,700 optimal partitions. As a control, on partitions of cost OPT + 1 and OPT + 2 the conclusions of Lemma 39, Theorem 40 and Corollary 41 fail thousands of times, while the purely counting Lemma 44 never fails, as it should. An independently written checker (audit) confirmed Lemma 39 and Theorem 40 on all optimal partitions of random pair-maximal instances for $n = 6, 7, 8$ (744 + 517 + 137 optimal partitions), Lemma 44 on 511,560 pairs (z, b) over all partitions of $n = 7$, and the decomposition of Proposition 43(b) on 4,000 random triple systems. This is evidence; the proofs above are the justification.

8.6 What remains

Every inserted pair of an optimal solution is of type (T1) or (T2) (Theorem 40). What is established is the following.

- Type (T1) pairs, in particular all cross pairs of soft-free merges, are bag-local with an explicit bound on the number of partners (Corollary 41, Proposition 43).
- Merges of two pieces joined by a soft pair can be of type (T2) (Proposition 45), so the closed statement is *soft-free merges only*; the claim "tiny pointers are local" is not established in general.

What remains open:

(R1) *Type (T2) pointers.* By Lemma 44 the far end a of a (T2) pair is one of at most ℓ vertices fixed by the soft anchor (z, b), but a is at hard distance 1 from z, so it can be far from z in $I(H)$ (the hard edge az may join vertices of far-apart members). Whether the interaction of these far ends with the rest of the solution can be handled inside a bounded-width decomposition is open. (A conjecture that (T2) pointers can be absorbed into the base CSP of Section 3–4 by a per-anchor unary constraint plus at most ℓ extra pairs is untested; we state it only as a possibility.)

(R2) *Deleted hard edges.* A deleted hard edge between far members is the same kind of object (a hard edge used as a tunnel); this section says nothing about it. The example of Section 9 (Proposition 61) shows that free hard edges between far vertices cannot be ignored when one tries to build a single decomposition for all purposes.

(R3) *The missing reduction lemma* (Conjecture 64 in Section 9).

Even a complete solution of (R1) and (R2) would not decide Open Problem 2 unless it also handles the position of $\leq \ell$ bounded pieces, which Section 9 reduces to an n^ℓ guess.

Remark 48 (Heuristic, not a theorem: why a hardness proof must use (T2) or deletions). Since (T1) pairs are bag-local, any W[1]-hardness reduction for $\ell+w$ would have to transport information through (T2) pairs or deleted hard edges. A kept hard edge az with a far from z can force the final status of the soft pairs at a to agree with those at z, i.e. it realises *equality* of colours between far positions; Grid Tiling needs exactly equalities between neighbouring cells together with local membership constraints. We could not complete such a construction: an inactive anchor must cost nothing, $|M(z, b)| \leq \ell$ forces each anchor's far end to be unique (so the colour would have to be encoded by *which* anchor is active), and the independence-number bound of Lemma 33 must not be violated by many anchors that share hard neighbours. This is an unverified idea and is listed only to say where a hardness proof would have to look.

9 The cluster-identity route: bounded candidates, an n^ℓ algorithm and an FPT algorithm in (ℓ, D, ω)

This section pursues the following route to fixed-parameter tractability in $\ell + w$: describe the clusters of an optimal solution by a normal form (Lemmas 49–53), show that one endpoint of an unpacked edit determines a bounded candidate set for the other (Corollary 54), and run a dynamic program that either guesses the positions of the edits (Theorem 57) or follows the clusters directly (Theorem 59). The route yields two proved results, a halving of the exponent in Theorem 6 and an FPT algorithm for a stronger parameter ω, and **it does not yield FPT in** $\ell + w$: ω is not bounded by any function of (ℓ, w) (Proposition 61), and the reduction that would repair this is missing (Conjecture 64). The question "FPT in (ℓ, w)?" remains **open**. (Sections 10 and 11 continue this route with further proved lemmas and obstructions; they do not change this status.)

Setting and notation. H is pair-maximal; for an arbitrary packing apply Lemma 30 and read w, D, ℓ as the primed values $w' \leq w + |M|$, $D' \leq D + 2|M|$, $\ell' = \ell - |M|$ (Remark 58 below). "Soft" means packed, "hard" unpacked; $Q(v)$ is the set of soft partners of v and D is any number with $D \geq \max_v |Q(v)|$ (for example $D = D(H) = 2c$). $N_h(v)$ is the set of hard neighbours and $d_h(v) = |N_h(v)|$. A *solution* is a set S of pairs with $G \triangle S$ a cluster graph; its *clusters* are the cliques

of $G \triangle S$, and every partition π of V is the cluster partition of exactly one solution, namely the set of pairs ab with $[a, b \text{ in one block}] \neq [ab \in E]$; its size is the *cost* of π. As in Section 7, U is the set of *edited hard pairs* of S (hard pairs in S), with $u = |U| \leq |S| - |H|$ (Lemma 1); del_x and ins_x count the deleted hard edges (hard edges across clusters) and inserted hard non-edges (hard non-edges inside clusters) of U at the vertex x. A *hard component* is a connected component of the graph (V, hard edges of G); it is *clean* if all its non-adjacent pairs are soft. We say (G, H, ℓ) is a YES instance if $\mathrm{OPT} \leq |H| + \ell$, and then every solution of size $\leq |H| + \ell$ has $u \leq \ell$.

9.1 Cost decomposition

Lemma 49 (CP: cost decomposition)**.** *Let π be a partition of V and $f(C) = \binom{|C|}{2} - 2e(C)$, where $e(C)$ is the number of edges of G inside C.*

(a) $\mathrm{cost}(\pi) = |E| + \sum_{C \in \pi} f(C)$.

(b) $\mathrm{cost}(\pi) = \sum_i c_i + |U|$, *where $c_i \geq 1$ is the number of edited pairs among the three pairs of P_i (it depends only on π restricted to $V(P_i)$). The excess is $\sum_i (c_i - 1) + |U|$.*

(c) Let (T, β) be a tree decomposition of the soft graph W (Proposition 38) and call a hard pair local *if it lies in a common bag. Then* $\mathrm{cost}(\pi) = \sum_t \mathrm{loc}_t + \mathrm{far}$, *where each edited soft pair and each edited local hard pair is charged to one bag containing it,* loc_t *depends only on $\pi|_{\beta(t)}$, and* far *is the number of edited non-local hard pairs, so* $\mathrm{far} \leq |U|$.

Proof. (a) The cost counts non-edges inside blocks, $\sum_C [\binom{|C|}{2} - e(C)]$, plus edges across blocks, $|E| - \sum_C e(C)$. (b) The pair sets $\mathrm{pairs}(P_i)$ are disjoint and are exactly the soft pairs, and $c_i \geq 1$ since otherwise the triple $V(P_i)$ would stay an induced P_3 of $G \triangle S$ (Lemma 1). (c) is bookkeeping: all edited pairs are soft, or hard and local, or hard and non-local; soft pairs always lie in a bag. □

(The $\ell = 0$ CSP of Theorem 5 is the local part; all non-locality is in far.)

9.2 Structure of the hard pairs

Lemma 32 (HE) is the first statement used below. We add its companion.

Lemma 50 (H2)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal and uv a hard non-edge. Then $N_h(u) \cap N_h(v) = \emptyset$.*

Proof. If $z \in N_h(u) \cap N_h(v)$, then $u\,z\,v$ is an induced P_3 ($uz, zv \in E$, $uv \notin E$) all of whose pairs are hard, contradicting pair-maximality. □

Lemma 51 (EX: bounds at an edited hard pair)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal, S a solution with edited hard pair set U, $u = |U|$, let $xy \in U$ and let C be the cluster of x. Then:*

(a) if xy is deleted, $d_h(x) \leq D + \mathrm{del}_x + \mathrm{del}_y - 1$; if xy is inserted, $d_h(x) \leq D + \mathrm{ins}_y - 1 + \mathrm{del}_x$. In both cases $d_h(x) \leq D + u$;

(b) $|C| \leq 1 + D + d_h(x) + \mathrm{ins}_x$, hence $|C| \leq 1 + 2D + u$;

(c) every $z \in C$ has $d_h(z) \leq |C| - 1 + \mathrm{del}_z \leq 2D + 2u$.

Proof. (a) *Deleted:* $x \in C$, $y \notin C$. A hard neighbour z of x with xz not deleted ("kept") lies in C, and $z \neq y$. Apply Lemma 32 with centre x to the hard edges xz, xy: $zy \in E$ or zy is soft. If zy is a hard edge, it joins $z \in C$ to $y \notin C$, so it is a deleted hard edge at y other than xy (there are $\mathrm{del}_y - 1$ of these); otherwise $z \in Q(y)$, at most D vertices. So at most $D + \mathrm{del}_y - 1$ hard neighbours

are kept, and $d_h(x) \le D + \mathrm{del}_y - 1 + \mathrm{del}_x$. *Inserted:* $x, y \in C$. A kept hard neighbour z of x lies in C and $z \neq y$ (as $xy \notin E$); zy is a pair inside C, hence an edge of $G \triangle S$. If zy were a hard edge, $z \in N_h(x) \cap N_h(y)$, contradicting Lemma 50. So zy is soft ($z \in Q(y)$, at most D choices) or a hard non-edge, inserted at y and different from xy ($\mathrm{ins}_y - 1$ choices). So $d_h(x) \le D + \mathrm{ins}_y - 1 + \mathrm{del}_x$. In the deleted case the pairs counted by $\mathrm{del}_x + \mathrm{del}_y - 1$ are distinct pairs of U, so the sum is $\le u$; in the inserted case $\mathrm{ins}_y - 1 + \mathrm{del}_x \le u - 1$ (an inserted pair at y other than xy and a deleted pair at x are distinct elements of $U \setminus \{xy\}$).

(b) For $z \in C \setminus \{x\}$ the pair xz is an edge of $G \triangle S$. Either xz is soft (at most D such z), or a kept hard edge (at most $d_h(x)$), or a hard non-edge, inserted at x (at most ins_x). With (a): in the deleted case $|C| \le 1 + D + (D + \mathrm{del}_x + \mathrm{del}_y - 1) + \mathrm{ins}_x \le 1 + 2D + u$ because the deleted pairs at x or y and the inserted pairs at x are distinct elements of U; in the inserted case $\mathrm{ins}_x + \mathrm{ins}_y - 1$ counts the inserted pairs at x or y and del_x is disjoint from them, so the total is again $\le u$.

(c) Hard neighbours of z inside C are at most $|C| - 1$; hard neighbours outside C are joined by deleted edges, at most $\mathrm{del}_z \le u$. Use (b). □

Slack 0 is attained in the finer forms of (a) and (b) in small cases (computer evidence), so the finer forms cannot be shaved by 1; the coarse bounds are loose.

Lemma 52 (F1: clusters of an optimum are connected)**.** *In an optimal solution every cluster C induces a connected subgraph $G[C]$.*

Proof. If $C = C_1 \cup C_2$ with $C_1, C_2 \neq \emptyset$ and no edge of G between them, splitting C into C_1, C_2 turns the $|C_1||C_2| > 0$ inserted pairs between them into non-edges outside S and creates no deletion. □

Fix ℓ and put

$$B = 2D + 3\ell, \qquad L_B = \{v : \ d_h(v) \le B\}, \qquad Z = B + D + 1 = 3D + 3\ell + 1.$$

In an optimal solution of size at most $|H| + \ell$ call a cluster *exceptional* if it contains an endpoint of a pair of U. Let BIG be the union of the hard components that contain a vertex v with $d_h(v) > B$.

Lemma 53 (NF: normal form)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal and S an optimal solution with $|S| \le |H| + \ell$, so $u \le \ell$.*

- *(α) There are at most $2u \le 2\ell$ exceptional clusters. Each exceptional cluster C has $|C| \le 1 + 2D + u \le 2D + \ell + 1$, lies in L_B, and $G[C]$ is connected.*
- *(β) Let C be a non-exceptional cluster. Then no hard edge leaves C and no hard non-edge lies in C; so C is a union of whole hard components, each clean, and all pairs between different components inside C are soft. If C contains at least two components, $|C| \le 2D$.*
- *(γ) Every hard component K of* BIG *is a whole cluster of S, and this cluster is non-exceptional. Consequently every exceptional cluster is disjoint from* BIG*, and every component of* BIG *is clean.*

Proof. (α) Each pair of U has at most two clusters at its ends, which gives the count. The bound on $|C|$ is Lemma 51(b) (for an endpoint $x \in C$ of a pair in U), the inclusion $C \subseteq L_B$ is Lemma 51(c) together with $2D + 2u \le B$, and connectivity is Lemma 52.

(β) A hard edge leaving C would be deleted, with an endpoint in C; a hard non-edge inside C would be inserted. Both would make C exceptional. If K is a hard component meeting C, hard edges at a vertex of $K \cap C$ do not leave C, so $K \subseteq C$ by connectivity of K; K is clean since C

contains no hard non-edge. Two vertices of different components inside C are not joined by a hard edge, and are not a hard non-edge, so their pair is soft. If C contains components $K_1 \neq K_2$, a vertex $x \in K_1$ has all vertices of $C \setminus K_1$ as soft partners, so $|C \setminus K_1| \leq D$; likewise $|C \setminus K_2| \leq D$; since $K_1 \subseteq C \setminus K_2$, $|C| = |K_1| + |C \setminus K_1| \leq 2D$.

(γ) Let $d_h(v) > B$ and let $K = K(v)$ be its hard component. By Lemma 51(a) no endpoint of a pair of U has hard degree above $D + u \leq B$, and by (α) no vertex of an exceptional cluster has hard degree above B. So the cluster C of v is non-exceptional, and by (β) $K \subseteq C$ and C is a union of components. Now $|K| \geq d_h(v) + 1 > B + 1 > 2D$, so by ($\beta$) C cannot contain two components; hence $C = K$. Every other vertex of K lies in the same cluster. Cleanness is (β). The disjointness statement follows since a component of BIG is a non-exceptional cluster. □

Corollary 54 (CAND: bounded candidate partners)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal, S optimal with $|S| \leq |H| + \ell$, and $xy \in U$. Put $\rho = 2D + \ell$ and $\Delta = B + D$. Then $x, y \in L_B$ and:*

(i) if xy is deleted, $y \in N_h(x)$, and $|N_h(x)| \leq D + \ell$;

(ii) if xy is inserted, the distance from x to y in $G[L_B]$ is at most $|C| - 1 \leq \rho$, where C is the common cluster;

(iii) in both cases y lies in the ball $\mathrm{Ball}(x, \rho)$ of $G[L_B]$, which has at most $(\Delta + 1)^\rho = Z^\rho$ vertices.

The same holds with the roles of x and y exchanged.

Proof. $x, y \in L_B$ by Lemma 51(a) ($d_h \leq D+u \leq B$). (i) is the definition together with Lemma 51(a). (ii) $G[C]$ is connected (Lemma 52), $C \subseteq L_B$ by Lemma 53(α), so a shortest path in $G[C]$ has at most $|C| - 1 \leq 2D + u \leq \rho$ edges, and lies in $G[L_B]$. (iii) A vertex of $G[L_B]$ has at most B hard neighbours and at most D soft ones, so degree at most Δ, and a ball of radius ρ has at most $\sum_{i \leq \rho} \Delta^i \leq (\Delta + 1)^\rho$ vertices; deleted pairs have distance 1. Finally $\Delta + 1 = B + D + 1 = Z$. □

Remark 55 (Radius two). Lemma 39(b) gives more for inserted pairs: the ends of an inserted pair have a common neighbour inside the cluster, so their distance in $G[C] \subseteq G[L_B]$ is exactly 2, and (ii) holds with $\rho = 2$ in place of $2D + \ell$. This is an immediate combination of Lemma 39 and Lemma 53(α), and would replace ρ by 2 in Theorem 57 (and so $Z_*^{\rho_*\ell}$ by $Z_*^{2\ell}$); it was not part of the audited statements, so we keep the audited value in the theorems. (The computer checks observed distance ≤ 2 throughout.)

In the language of Section 8: Corollary 54 says that *one* endpoint of an edited hard pair determines a set of at most Z^ρ candidates for the other, for every pair, including (T2) pairs and deleted edges. What it does not bound is the number of candidates for the first endpoint, which is n.

9.3 Algorithms

Remark 56 (Fixed edited set). The proof of Theorem 6 shows: for a *fixed* set U' of hard pairs, $\min \sum_i |x_i|$ over all $x \in \prod \mathcal{D}_i$ with $G \triangle (U' \cup \bigcup x_i)$ a cluster graph is computed in $7^{w+1} n^{O(1)}$ time from a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w, and for *every* U' of hard pairs the value $m_{U'} + |U'|$ is the size of an actual solution.

Theorem 57 (n^ℓ algorithm)**.** *Given (G, H, ℓ) and a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w, CEaMP is solvable in time*

$$(n+1)^\ell \, Z_*^{\rho_*\ell} \, 7^{\,w+\ell+1} \, n^{O(1)}, \qquad D_* = D(H) + 2\ell, \quad Z_* = 3D_* + 3\ell + 1, \quad \rho_* = 2D_* + \ell.$$

Since $D(H) \leq 2(w+1)$, the factor $Z_*^{\rho_*\ell}$ is a function of (ℓ, w) only. This improves the exponent 2ℓ of Theorem 6 to ℓ; it is still XP in ℓ.

Proof. Compute M and $H' = H \cup M$ by Lemma 30; reject if $|M| > \ell$. Then H' is pair-maximal, $\ell' = \ell - |M| \le \ell$, $D(H') \le D + 2|M| \le D_*$, a tree decomposition of $I(H')$ of width $w' \le w + |M| \le w + \ell$ is available, and the instance is equivalent to (G, H', ℓ'). All lemmas apply to H' with D_* (any upper bound on $|Q|$ is allowed) and ℓ'; put B, L_B, Z, ρ accordingly (they are at most B_*, Z_*, ρ_*).

Algorithm. Compute L_B and, for $x \in L_B$, the set $P(x)$ of vertices $y \in \mathrm{Ball}_{G[L_B]}(x, \rho) \setminus \{x\}$ with xy hard; $|P(x)| \le Z^\rho$. Enumerate all sequences of at most ℓ' pairs $(x_1, y_1), \ldots, (x_j, y_j)$ with $x_i \in L_B$ and $y_i \in P(x_i)$; there are at most $(1 + nZ^\rho)^{\ell'} \le (n+1)^{\ell'} Z^{\rho\ell'}$ of them. For each, let $U' = \{x_i y_i\}$ (a set of at most ℓ' hard pairs), compute $m_{U'}$ by Remark 56 for H' in $7^{w'+1} n^{O(1)}$ time, and accept iff $m_{U'} + |U'| \le |H'| + \ell'$.

Soundness. By Remark 56, $m_{U'} + |U'|$ is the size of an actual solution of G for every U' of hard pairs of H'; acceptance gives a solution of size $\le |H'| + \ell' = |H| + \ell$.

Completeness. Suppose the instance is a YES instance and let S be an optimal solution, $|S| \le |H'| + \ell'$, with edited hard pair set U, $|U| \le \ell'$ (Lemma 1 for H'). For each pair of U take one endpoint x; it lies in L_B and the other endpoint lies in $P(x)$ by Corollary 54. So U is among the enumerated sets, and for it $m_U + |U| \le |S| \le |H'| + \ell'$ (the packed part of S is a feasible choice of x for U by Lemma 1).

Time. $(n+1)^{\ell'} Z^{\rho\ell'} 7^{w'+1} n^{O(1)} \le (n+1)^{\ell} Z_*^{\rho_*\ell} 7^{w+\ell+1} n^{O(1)}$. □

Remark 58. The statement is in terms of the primed instance (G, H', ℓ'): $D_*, w + \ell$ and ℓ are upper bounds for $D(H'), w', \ell'$, which is the normalisation of Lemma 30. The exponent is halved because the candidate list is attached to *one* endpoint (Corollary 54); Theorem 6 guesses both. Note that ℓ bounds the *number* of edited hard pairs but not the cost of locating them: the n^ℓ comes from the position of the first endpoint of each pair. An FPT algorithm needs a bound on the positions as well. Computing the tree decomposition is FPT in w (Section 2).

Theorem 59 (FPT in (ℓ, D, ω))**.** *Let H be pair-maximal and let ℓ, D, B, Z, L_B,* BIG *be as above. Let $V' = V \setminus \mathrm{BIG}$ and let Γ' be the graph on V' whose edges are all edges of G and all soft pairs with both ends in V'; let $\omega = \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma')$ and assume a tree decomposition of Γ' of width ω is given. Then one can compute in time $(Z(\omega+1))^{O(\omega)} n + n^{O(1)}$ a number m^* such that*

$$\mathrm{OPT}(G) \le |H| + \ell \iff |E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^* \le |H| + \ell,$$

where K ranges over the hard components of BIG *and f is as in Lemma 49. Moreover $m_{\mathrm{all}} \le m^* \le m_{\mathrm{conn}}$, where m_{all} (m_{conn}) is the minimum of $\sum_{C \in \pi'} f(C)$ over all partitions π' of V' with clusters of at most Z vertices (and, for m_{conn}, connected in Γ').*

Proof. ($\Leftarrow$) Let π' be the partition of V' realising m^* (the dynamic program below produces a real partition) and $\pi = \pi' \cup \{K : K \text{ a component of BIG}\}$. By Lemma 49(a), $\mathrm{cost}(\pi) = |E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^* \ge \mathrm{OPT}$, so the right-hand side gives $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$. No structure of G is needed for this direction.

($\Rightarrow$) Let S be optimal with $|S| \le |H| + \ell$. By Lemma 53(γ) every component of BIG is a whole cluster; let π' be the restriction of S's partition to V'. Its clusters are Γ'-connected and have at most Z vertices:

- *Exceptional C.* $C \cap \mathrm{BIG} = \emptyset$ by (γ), so $C \subseteq V'$; $G[C]$ is connected by (α) and its edges are edges of Γ'. $|C| \le 2D + \ell + 1 \le Z$.
- *Non-exceptional C not in* BIG. By (β), C is a union of whole hard components, none of which is in BIG (a component of BIG is a cluster by itself), so $C \subseteq V'$. Each component is

connected by hard edges, which are edges of Γ'. If there are at least two components, all pairs between them are soft, hence edges of Γ', so C is Γ'-connected, and $|C| \le 2D$. If there is exactly one component $K = C$, it is clean, so every vertex y of K has all other vertices of K as hard neighbours or soft partners, $|K| \le d_h(y) + D + 1 \le B + D + 1 = Z$ because $y \notin \mathrm{BIG}$ has $d_h(y) \le B$.

So π' is feasible for m_{conn} and $\mathrm{cost}(S) = |E| + \sum_K f(K) + \sum_{C \in \pi'} f(C) \ge |E| + \sum_K f(K) + m_{\mathrm{conn}} \ge |E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^*$.

The dynamic program. Take a nice tree decomposition of Γ' of width ω with empty root bag. A state at node t is a partition $\mathcal{P}$ of the bag X_t into blocks together with a size $s(\mathsf{b}) \in \{|\mathsf{b}|, \dots, Z\}$ for each block b (the number of vertices introduced so far, in the subtree of t, of the cluster containing b). Its value is the minimum, over partitions of the introduced vertices into clusters that realise $(\mathcal{P}, s)$ (every cluster either contains a block of $\mathcal{P}$ or has been *closed*, i.e. has no vertex left in the bag), of $\sum_C g(C)$, with $g(C) = \binom{|C|}{2} - 2e(C)$ evaluated on the introduced vertices of C. *Introduce* v into the block b of size s (or into a new block of size 1): the value increases by $s - 2k$, where k is the number of G-neighbours of v in b; here we use that an introduced vertex y that has been forgotten cannot be a G-neighbour of v, because yv would be an edge of Γ' and y, v would share a bag. *Forget* v: if its block has other bag vertices the block shrinks; otherwise the cluster is closed and is never extended. *Join* of two children with the same partition $\mathcal{P}$: for a block with bag part b and sizes s_1, s_2 in the two children, put $x_1 = s_1 - |\mathsf{b}|$, $x_2 = s_2 - |\mathsf{b}|$; the new size is $s_1 + s_2 - |\mathsf{b}|$ and the value is $g_1 + g_2 - g(\mathsf{b}) + x_1 x_2$ summed over blocks, where $g(\mathsf{b}) = \binom{|\mathsf{b}|}{2} - 2e(\mathsf{b})$ is read off the bag. This is correct because pairs inside b and edges inside b are counted in both children, pairs between the two exclusive parts number $x_1 x_2$, and there is no G-edge between the exclusive parts (such an edge would be an edge of Γ' between vertices forgotten in different subtrees, which share no bag). *The join term $x_1 x_2$ and the subtraction of $g(\mathsf{b})$ are essential*: omitting them gives a different value on some inputs (about 6% of the audit's tests). At the root the value is $\sum_C f(C)$ over a partition of V' with clusters of size $\le Z$. Call it m^* (the minimum over states; we treat the closed clusters as final).

Every state sequence yields a real partition of V' with cluster sizes $\le Z$ and correct cost, so $m^* \ge m_{\mathrm{all}}$. A Γ'-connected partition is represented: if the last bag vertex of a cluster C is forgotten at t, the vertex subtrees of C have a connected union (as C is Γ'-connected), which cannot contain the parent of t, so it lies below t and all of C has been introduced; hence no later vertex needs to join a closed cluster. So $m^* \le m_{\mathrm{conn}}$. There are at most $(\omega+1)^{\omega+1} Z^{\omega+1}$ states per node, a join combines at most $Z^{2(\omega+1)}$ pairs of states with equal partition, and the tree has $O(\omega n)$ nodes; the total time is $(Z(\omega+1))^{O(\omega)} n$. Computing d_h, BIG and Γ' takes $n^{O(1)}$.

Combining: $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$ implies $|E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^* \le \mathrm{cost}(S) \le |H| + \ell$ by ($\Rightarrow$), and the converse is ($\Leftarrow$). □

Remark 60 (Remarks on Theorem 59). (1) Cleanliness of the components of BIG need not be tested: it is implied when the instance is a YES instance (Lemma 53(γ)), and the inequality itself accounts for the true cost $f(K)$; rejecting an unclean component is a harmless optimisation. (2) The proof uses that an exceptional cluster is disjoint from BIG and hence lies in V'. It is *not* true that $L_B \subseteq V'$: a component of BIG can contain vertices of small hard degree (pendant vertices of a hub component); in the audit's tests this happened in 30 (instance, ℓ) pairs. (3) Here no pointer is guessed: far merges are carried by Γ'-connectivity. As for Theorem 57, D, B, Z, ℓ and ω refer to the pair-maximal instance (G, H', ℓ') of Lemma 30. (4) The dynamic program was implemented in the audit (introduce, forget and join over a min-fill decomposition, per connected component). With m computed by brute force, the criterion agreed with $\mathrm{OPT} \le |H| + \ell$ in all 2,778 tested pairs

of an instance and an ℓ ($n \le 10$), and the DP value satisfied $m_{\text{all}} \le m^* \le m_{\text{conn}}$ in 2,141 checks; evidence, not proof. Without a tree decomposition of Γ', one is computed in $2^{O(\omega)}n$ time with width $2\omega + 1$ [12].

9.4 Why ω is not bounded by (ℓ, w)

Proposition 61 (ω is unbounded at $\ell = 0$, $w = 0$)**.** *For every cubic graph F there is an instance $(G_F, H_F, 0)$ with H_F a vertex-disjoint pair-maximal packing ($w = 0$, $c = 1$, $D = 2$), $\mathrm{OPT}(G_F) = |H_F|$ (a YES instance with $\ell = 0$), $\mathrm{BIG} = \emptyset$, every hard component of size at most 6 and every hard degree at most 4, and $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma') \ge \mathrm{tw}(F)$. By [8] (cited, not re-proved here) there are cubic graphs F (expanders) with $\mathrm{tw}(F) = \Omega(|V(F)|)$. Hence ω is not bounded by any function of (ℓ, w).*

Proof. Orient each edge of F arbitrarily; for each oriented edge $e = (p \to q)$ introduce three vertices a_e, b_e, c_e. Let $K_v = \{a_e : e \text{ leaves } v\} \cup \{b_e, c_e : e \text{ enters } v\}$ and make each K_v a clique; add the cross edges $a_e b_e$ and nothing else. Then $|K_v| = \mathrm{out}(v) + 2\,\mathrm{in}(v) = 3 + \mathrm{in}(v) \le 6$. $H_F = \{P_e = (a_e, b_e, c_e)\}$: $a_e b_e, b_e c_e \in E$ and $a_e c_e \notin E$ since $a_e \in K_p$, $c_e \in K_q$, $p \ne q$ and cross edges are of the form $a_{e'} b_{e'}$; so P_e is an induced P_3. The members are vertex-disjoint, so modification-disjoint, $c = 1$, $w = 0$ and $D = 2$.

Pair-maximality. In an induced P_3 $x\,y\,z$ not both edges can lie inside cliques, since then x, z would be in the clique of y (each vertex is in exactly one clique) and adjacent. So one of xy, yz is a cross edge $a_e b_e$, which is packed.

$\mathrm{OPT} = |H_F|$. The partition $\{K_v\}$ has no inserted pair and deletes exactly the cross edges, $|H_F|$ of them; and $\mathrm{OPT} \ge |H_F|$ by Lemma 1.

Hard structure. The soft pairs inside K_v are $b_e c_e$ (e entering v); all other pairs inside K_v are hard edges. So each K_v is one hard component and it is clean. The hard degree of $a_e \in K_p$ is $|K_p| - 1 \le 4$ (as a_e is an out-edge, $\mathrm{in}(p) \le 2$, $|K_p| \le 5$); that of b_e or $c_e \in K_q$ is $|K_q| - 2 \le 4$. So $d_h \le 4 = 2D + 3\ell$ at $\ell = 0$, hence no vertex has $d_h > B$ and $\mathrm{BIG} = \emptyset$ (the margin is zero: one more unit would change the family).

Minor. $V' = V$, each K_v is connected in Γ' (a clique), and an edge or soft pair of Γ' between $K_p \ne K_q$ is one of $a_e b_e$, $a_e c_e$, which exist only for the oriented edge $e = (p \to q)$ of F. Contracting the K_v gives exactly F, so F is a minor of Γ' and $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma') \ge \mathrm{tw}(F)$. □

Remark 62 (Scope of Proposition 61). The proposition refutes only the claim "$\omega \le f(\ell, w)$"; it does *not* refute fixed-parameter tractability. The family has $w = 0$ and $\ell = 0$; it is solved in polynomial time by Theorem 6 and has $s = 3$ in Theorem 22. The obstruction is to the representation by Γ' (and by any single decomposition used both for the packed pairs and for the clusters): hard edges between far vertices are free (not in the budget), arbitrary in number, and make footprints of clusters disconnected in any decomposition of $I(H)$ or of W. At $\ell = 0$ they are harmless because the CSP of Theorem 5 needs no identities; for $\ell > 0$ an exceptional cluster can be assembled from vertices that are far apart (the example of a $c = 1$ instance with two vertex-disjoint P_3's joined by one hard edge that is deleted). So a dynamic program on one decomposition cannot be used for both purposes without a preprocessing step.

Remark 63 (Heuristic, not a theorem: colour coding does not repair the pointers). A greedy proper colouring of the ρ-th power of $G[L_B]$ with $(B + D)^\rho + 1$ colours names every vertex of a ball, so one site can verify a whole exceptional component by look-ups in G. What a site cannot do is make the other vertices of the same cluster, up to Z of them in far bags, declare the same cluster and agree on the variables of their P_3's: charging the cost at the minimum-colour vertex undercounts when that vertex takes the default state, and charging $1/|C|$ at each declaring site fails in the same way.

Repairing this needs the identity of the other sites across bags, i.e. the n^ℓ guess. A sound variant exists for a decomposition of $I(H)$ plus all pairs of members within distance ρ in $G[L_B]$, which gives FPT in (ℓ, D, tw) of that graph, and by Proposition 61 its treewidth is not bounded in (ℓ, w). This is a heuristic analysis of a method, not a theorem.

9.5 The missing lemma

Conjecture 64 (ML: reduction lemma; missing)**.** *There is a polynomial-time algorithm that, given (G, H, ℓ) with H pair-maximal, either outputs NO correctly or outputs an equivalent instance (G^*, H^*, ℓ^*) with H^* pair-maximal, $\ell^* \le \ell$, $w(H^*) \le f_1(\ell, w)$ and $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma'(G^*, H^*)) \le f_2(\ell, w)$.*

We do not know whether ML is true. An equivalent form needed for Theorem 59 is a rule that removes "inert" hard components (those intact in every solution and whose incident P_3's have a forced local solution). For $c = 1$ (a vertex-disjoint packing) the rule of [14] used in Section 6 plays this role and leaves $O(\ell)$ members; for $w \ge 1$ the counting breaks, because an edit outside all members can be an internal pair of another member, and the open case is that of Open Problem 7. Section 11 proves the partial results that are available: a reformulation through the soft graph (Proposition 79), a polynomial reduction to at most 2ℓ components of $I(H)$ (Theorem 82), and a family with $w = 1$, $\ell = 1$ on which the rule of [14] applied to pair-closed unions of members does nothing (Proposition 84). Section 10 proves a pruned form of Theorem 59 (Theorem 73).

Observation 65 (Conditional; not a result)**.** *If Conjecture 64 holds, then Theorem 59 applied to (G^*, H^*, ℓ^*), with $D^* \le 2(w(H^*) + 1)$, solves CEaMP in time $f(\ell, w)\, n^{O(1)}$, i.e. CEaMP is FPT in $\ell + w$.*

This is a one-line implication, stated only to record what ML would give; ML is a conjecture.

9.6 Computer evidence and status

The statements of this section were tested by brute force on small instances: in the notes, 5,300 instances with $n = 6, \ldots, 11$ and all partitions of cost at most $|H|+3$ ($> 4.5 \cdot 10^5$ partitions, $1.5 \cdot 10^6$ edited-pair checks, $> 17{,}000$ optimal partitions) and an ILP on 100 instances with $n = 11, \ldots, 13$; in the audit, with independently written code, 1,511 instances with $n \le 10$ (8,988 optimal partitions). Result: Lemmas 49–53 and Corollary 54 had no violation, and inserted pairs had distance at most 2 in every test (consistent with Remark 55). The family of Proposition 61 was checked for K_4, $K_{3,3}$, the Petersen graph and random cubic graphs on 20 and 40 nodes (n up to 180): induced, pair-disjoint, pair-maximal, $\mathrm{cost}(\{K_v\}) = |H|$, hard degrees and component sizes as stated, and the quotient of Γ' by the K_v equal to F; for the four graphs F with three edges (not cubic; the construction does not use cubicity) on $n = 9$ vertices, in both orientations, $\mathrm{OPT} = |H|$ was verified over all partitions. $n \le 13$ is small; Proposition 61 is a construction, not an experiment. Evidence supports, and the proofs justify, the statements.

Statement	Status
Lemmas 49–53, Corollary 54	proved
Theorem 57 (n^ℓ, halved exponent)	proved, relies on Theorem 6, Lemma 30
Theorem 59 (FPT in (ℓ, D, ω))	proved (DP implemented only in the audit)
Proposition 61 (ω unbounded)	proved, expander treewidth cited [8]
FPT in $\ell + w$	**open**
Conjecture 64 (ML)	conjecture, not tested at size
Remark 63	heuristic
Lemmas 66, 67, 69, 70, 71 (W1, W2, F1, DEL, BAD)	proved (Section 10)
Corollary 68 (LB)	proved, lower bound only (not exact at $\ell = 0$)
Theorem 73 (P), Proposition 74	proved (strictness for in-degrees ≥ 1, $\ell \leq 4$)
Proposition 75 (FAR)	proved, computer-checked $m = 3, 4, 5$
Proposition 76 (NF-bad fails at distance $2, 3$)	computer-assisted; unbounded distance open
Conjecture 78 (Λ)	conjecture
Proposition 79, Lemma 80, Proposition 81	proved (Section 11)
Theorem 82 (at most 2ℓ components)	proved modulo cited [14] Lemma 6.3
Proposition 84 ($N^*(F)$)	proved; computer coverage in Remark 85
Conjecture 86 (TL)	conjecture

10 Conflicts, pruning, and an exact obstruction for far pointers

This section continues Sections 8 and 9 and concerns the two kinds of unpacked edit that were left open there: inserted pairs of type (T2) and deleted hard edges. It proves a *conflict lemma* that gives every soft pair a static weight, a defect bound and a polynomial NO-test that follow from it, a pruned version of Theorem 59, and an exact obstruction family (Proposition 75): instances with $w = 1$, $c = 2$, $\ell = 1$ in which every optimum deletes a hard edge between members at arbitrarily large distance in $I(H)$. **Nothing here proves or refutes fixed-parameter tractability in $\ell + w$**; Open Problem 2 remains open. Statements are labelled *proved*, *computer-assisted* (a finite check, evidence only) or *conjecture*.

Setting. H is pair-maximal (otherwise apply Lemma 30 and read the primed instance), "soft" means packed, "hard" unpacked, $Q(v)$ is the set of soft partners, $N_h(v)$ the set of hard neighbours, $D \geq \max_v |Q(v)|$. A solution is identified with a partition π of V; write $x(p, q) = 1$ if p, q lie in one block and 0 otherwise; U is the set of edited hard pairs (so $|U| \leq |S| - |H|$ by Lemma 1). For a soft pair $\sigma = (z, b)$ put

$$\Delta(z, b) = \{y \notin \{z, b\} : zy, by \text{ hard, exactly one of them an edge of } G\}, \qquad \Gamma_h(z, b) = N_h(z) \cap N_h(b).$$

(In this section $\Delta(z, b)$ always has two arguments; it is unrelated to the number $\Delta = B + D$ of Corollary 54.) Both sets are computed from (G, H) alone. For a solution, the *weight* of the soft pair $\sigma = (z, b)$ is $c(\sigma) = |\Delta(z, b)|$ if z, b lie in one cluster (*merged*) and $c(\sigma) = |\Gamma_h(z, b)|$ otherwise. A *conflict* is a pair (σ, y) with y in the relevant set.

10.1 The conflict lemma and its consequences

Lemma 66 (W1: conflicts)**.** *Let π be* any *solution and $\sigma = (z, b)$ a soft pair.*

(a) If z, b are in one cluster, every $y \in \Delta(z, b)$ has $zy \in U$ or $by \in U$.

(b) If z, b are in different clusters, every $y \in \Gamma_h(z, b)$ has $zy \in U$ or $by \in U$.

Distinct y give distinct edited pairs, hence $|U| \geq c(\sigma)$ for every soft pair σ.

Proof. (a) In a cluster graph, z, b in one cluster implies $x(z, y) = x(b, y)$ for all y. For $y \in \Delta(z, b)$ the G-values of the two hard pairs zy, by differ, so at least one of them is changed. (b) If neither zy nor by is edited, then $x(z, y) = x(b, y) = 1$ (both are edges of G), so z, b, y share a cluster, a contradiction. The edited pair chosen for y contains y and one of z, b, so different y give different pairs. □

Neither maximality nor optimality is used. Lemma 44 is the merged case of (a): for z, b in one cluster $M(z, b) \subseteq \Delta(z, b)$, so $|M(z, b)| \leq |U|$. (The hypothesis that z, b lie in one cluster is essential: for unmerged z, b the set $M(z, b)$ can be large.)

Lemma 67 (W2: defect bound)**.** *For every solution, $\sum_{\sigma \text{ soft}} c(\sigma) \leq 2D\,|U|$.*

Proof. Map each conflict $((z, b), y)$ to an edited pair of $\{zy, by\}$ (Lemma 66). An edited pair $e = \{p, y\}$ is chosen by conflicts (σ, y) with $\sigma \ni p$, at most $|Q(p)| \leq D$ of them, and by conflicts (σ', p) with $\sigma' \ni y$, at most D of them. □

The constant $2D$ is attained for $D = 2$ ($c = 1$) in a computer search ($n = 6, 7$); for $D = 4$ and $D = 6$ the same search reached only $1/2$ and $1/3$ of the bound, so attainment for $D \geq 4$ is open.

Corollary 68 (LB: a lower bound from the weights)**.** *Let c_i be as in Lemma 49(b) and let $W = \sum_\sigma c(\sigma)$ be the total weight of a solution π. Then* $\mathrm{cost}(\pi) \geq \sum_i c_i + \lceil W/2D \rceil$.

Proof. $\mathrm{cost}(\pi) = \sum_i c_i + |U|$ and $|U| \geq W/2D$ by Lemma 67. □

The right-hand side is not exact: minimised over assignments of the soft pairs that are transitive on all-soft triples, it can equal $|H|$ although $\mathrm{OPT} > |H|$ (computer: 29 of 300 random instances with $n = 6, 7, 8$; the triples with two soft pairs and one hard pair are not checked). We only use it as a lower bound.

Lemma 69 (F1: static pruning)**.** *Let $|S| \leq |H| + \ell$. If $|\Delta(u, v)| > \ell$, the soft pair (u, v) is split in S; if $|\Gamma_h(u, v)| > \ell$ it is merged in S.*

Proof. Lemma 66 and $|U| \leq |S| - |H| \leq \ell$. □

Lemma 70 (DEL: rigid hard edges)**.** *If zy is a deleted hard edge of a solution, then $|U| \geq 1 + |N_h(z) \cap N_h(y)|$. Hence, if $|S| \leq |H| + \ell$, a hard edge with at least ℓ common hard neighbours is never deleted (it is* rigid*), and the hard components of rigid edges lie inside single clusters.*

Proof. z and y are in different clusters. A common hard neighbour w cannot be kept with both, so wz or wy is a deleted hard edge; distinct w give distinct pairs (each contains w), all different from zy. □

A member $P = (x, y, z)$ with centre y has three states of member-cost one: delete xy, delete yz, insert xz. A state fixes whether each of the three pairs of P is merged, hence a weight for each. Call P *locally bad* if in each of its three states some pair of P has positive weight. This is a static property.

Lemma 71 (BAD: few locally bad members)**.** *For every solution of size $|H| + \varepsilon$ the number of locally bad members is at most $2c\varepsilon$. Hence more than $2c\ell$ locally bad members is a NO-instance of CEaMP with budget ℓ (a polynomial test).*

Proof. By Lemma 49(b), $\varepsilon = \sum_i (c_i - 1) + |U|$. A bad member with $c_i \geq 2$ contributes at least 1 to the first sum. A bad member with $c_i = 1$ is in one of its three cost-one states, which has a conflict (σ, y) with σ a pair of P_i; by Lemma 66 an edit of U is incident to $V(P_i)$. An edit has two ends and each vertex lies in at most c members, so there are at most $2c|U|$ such members. In total at most $\sum_i (c_i - 1) + 2c|U| \leq 2c\varepsilon$. □

Proposition 72 (Candidate lists for (T2) pairs and deleted edges)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal, S an* optimal *solution with $|S| \leq |H| + \ell$, and $ab \in U$. Define, from (G, H) alone,*

$$L_1(a) = \begin{cases} N_h(a) \cup \bigcup_{z \in N_h(a)} Q(z) & \text{if } d_h(a) \leq D + \ell, \\ \emptyset & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases} \qquad L_2(b) = \bigcup_{z \in Q(b),\ |\Delta(z,b)| \leq \ell} \Delta(z, b).$$

Then $|L_1(a)| \leq (D + \ell)(D + 1)$ and $|L_2(b)| \leq D\ell$, and:

(i) if ab is a deleted hard edge, then $b \in L_1(a)$ and $a \in L_1(b)$;

(ii) if ab is an inserted pair of type (T2) with middle vertex z, az hard (kept) and zb soft (Theorem 40), then $b \in L_1(a)$ and $a \in L_2(b)$.

Pairs of type (T1) are not covered; they are bag-local by Proposition 43.

Proof. Every endpoint x of a pair of U has $d_h(x) \leq D + |U| \leq D + \ell$ (Lemma 51(a)), so the guard in L_1 holds for the ends. (i) The deleted pair is a hard edge, so $b \in N_h(a)$, and symmetrically. (ii) $z \in N_h(a)$ and $b \in Q(z)$, so $b \in L_1(a)$, and $|L_1(a)| \leq (D+\ell) + (D+\ell)D$. For the soft end: $z \in Q(b)$ ($\leq D$ choices); since az is kept and ab is inserted, a, z, b lie in one cluster, so zb is merged, and az is a hard edge while ab is a hard non-edge, so $a \in \Delta(z, b)$, and $|\Delta(z, b)| \leq |U| \leq \ell$ by Lemma 66(a). Hence $a \in L_2(b)$ and $|L_2(b)| \leq D\ell$. □

Optimality is used only through Theorem 40. The lists say where the partner of a given end can be; they do not say where the first end is (Corollary 54 and Remark 58).

10.2 A pruned form of Theorem 59

Let BIG, V', Z be as in Theorem 59 and let Γ^ℓ be the graph on V' whose edges are all hard edges inside V' and all soft pairs (u, v) inside V' with $|\Delta(u, v)| \leq \ell$. It is a spanning subgraph of Γ', so $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma^\ell) \leq \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma')$, and it is computable from (G, H) alone.

Theorem 73 (P: pruned ω-theorem)**.** *Let H be pair-maximal and let $\omega_\ell = \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma^\ell)$, with a tree decomposition of that width given. Then one can compute in time $(Z(\omega_\ell + 1))^{O(\omega_\ell)} n + n^{O(1)}$ a number m^* with*

$$\mathrm{OPT}(G) \leq |H| + \ell \iff |E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^* \leq |H| + \ell,$$

K ranging over the hard components of BIG*. So CEaMP is FPT in $(\ell, D, \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma^\ell))$.*

Proof. Let $e^+(C)$ be the number of edges of G inside C that are edges of Γ^ℓ, and $\tilde{f}(C) = \binom{|C|}{2} - 2e^+(C)$. Run the dynamic program of the proof of Theorem 59 on Γ^ℓ, with e^+ in place of e everywhere (in the introduce step k counts the Γ^ℓ-neighbours of v in the block, and in the join step there is no Γ^ℓ-edge between the exclusive parts). Exactly as there, it computes $m^* =$ the minimum of $\sum_C \tilde{f}(C)$ over Γ^ℓ-connected partitions of V' with clusters of at most Z vertices, in the stated time.

($\Leftarrow$) $e^+ \le e$, so $f(C) \le \tilde{f}(C)$ and the partition realising m^*, completed by the components of BIG, has true cost at most $|E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^*$ (Lemma 49(a)); no structure is needed.

($\Rightarrow$) Let S be optimal, $|S| \le |H| + \ell$. By the proof of Theorem 59, the clusters of S inside V' have at most Z vertices and are connected through edges of G inside the cluster and (for a cluster with several hard components) soft pairs inside the cluster. A soft pair inside a cluster is merged, so $|\Delta| \le \ell$ by Lemma 69 and it is an edge of Γ^ℓ; every hard edge is an edge of Γ^ℓ. Hence these clusters are Γ^ℓ-connected and $e^+(C) = e(C)$, $\tilde{f}(C) = f(C)$. So $\mathrm{cost}(S) = |E| + \sum_K f(K) + \sum_C f(C) \ge |E| + \sum_K f(K) + m^*$. □

Theorem 73 does not use optimality of the merges, only their cost, and it therefore cannot decide the open question.

Proposition 74 (Theorem 73 is strictly stronger than Theorem 59)**.** *Let F be a cubic graph with an orientation in which every in-degree is 1 or 2 (so every vertex has in-degree ≥ 1; for a 2-edge-connected F such an orientation exists by Robbins' theorem), and let (G_F, H_F) be the instance of Proposition 61. For every budget $\ell \le 4$, every component of Γ^ℓ has at most 5 vertices (so $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma^\ell) \le 4$), whereas $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma') \ge \mathrm{tw}(F)$.*

Proof. For the oriented edge $e = (p \to q)$ the soft pairs $a_e b_e$ and $a_e c_e$ join K_p and K_q. The soft partners of a_e are b_e, c_e and those of b_e are a_e, c_e (the three pairs of P_e). Hence $\Delta(a_e, b_e)$ consists of the vertices $y \in K_p \setminus \{a_e\}$ (the pair $a_e y$ is a hard edge and $b_e y$ a hard non-edge), of which there are $2 + \mathrm{in}(p)$, and of the vertices $y \in K_q \setminus \{b_e, c_e\}$ (here $b_e y$ is a hard edge and $a_e y$ a hard non-edge), of which there are $1 + \mathrm{in}(q)$. So $|\Delta(a_e, b_e)| = 3 + \mathrm{in}(p) + \mathrm{in}(q) \ge 5$, and the same count holds for $a_e c_e$. For $\ell \le 4$ both cross pairs are pruned, the only edges of Γ^ℓ are those inside the cliques K_v, and $|K_v| = 3 + \mathrm{in}(v) \le 5$. The bound on $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma')$ is Proposition 61. □

The in-degree condition matters: with a source p (in-degree 0) the weight can be 4. Computer check (audit; K_4, the Petersen graph, random cubic graphs on 20 and 40 vertices, in-degrees in $\{1, 2\}$): $D = 2$, BIG $= \emptyset$, the cross weights are $5, 6, 7$, and at $\ell = 5$ the components of Γ^ℓ merge (sizes $8, 20, 32, 40$), so the gap closes at $\ell = 5$ in these examples. For larger ℓ one would use d-regular graphs with $d \approx \ell/2$; this is a sketch and is not claimed.

10.3 An exact obstruction: pointers need not be local in any power of $I(H)$

An edited pair $e = (a, b)$ is *two-sided* if there are vertices t, t' with (t, a) soft, (t', b) soft, and $\{a, b, t\}$, $\{a, b, t'\}$ induced P_3's of $G \triangle (S \setminus \{e\})$. It is *far* (at distance K) if the members containing a and b are at distance $\ge K$ in $I(H)$.

Proposition 75 (FAR)**.** *For $m \ge 3$ let G_m be the path $0, 1, \ldots, 2m$ with the extra edge $e^* = \{1, 2m-1\}$ and $H_m = \{M_i = (2i, 2i+1, 2i+2) : 0 \le i < m\}$ (centres $2i+1$). Then:*

- *(i) H_m is a pair-maximal modification-disjoint packing, $I(H_m)$ is a path on m nodes ($c = 2$, $w = 1$);*
- *(ii) $\mathrm{OPT}(G_m) = m + 1 = |H_m| + 1$;*
- *(iii) in* every *optimum the hard edge e^* is deleted. Its ends lie in M_0 and M_{m-1}, at distance $m-1$ in $I(H_m)$.*

Computer-assisted (all set partitions, $m = 3, 4, 5$): $\mathrm{OPT} = m+1$ *with 7/9/11 optima, every optimum separates the ends of e^*, the deleted chord is two-sided, and the only locally bad members are M_0 and M_{m-1}.*

Proof. (i) The chord joins 1 and $2m-1$, which are $2m-2 \geq 4$ apart, so no triple M_i contains both of them and each M_i is an induced P_3; the pair sets are disjoint. Every path edge lies in some M_i and is soft, so e^* is the only hard edge. An induced P_3 has two edges, at most one of which is e^*, so it contains a soft pair: H_m is pair-maximal.

(ii) $|E| = 2m+1$ and G_m is connected with $2m+1$ vertices, hence unicyclic (the unique cycle is on $1, \ldots, 2m-1$, of length ≥ 5). An induced subgraph on s vertices has $e \leq s-1$ edges unless it contains the cycle, in which case $s \geq 5$ and $e \leq s$. With $f(C) = \binom{|C|}{2} - 2e(C)$ this gives $f(C) \geq (s-1)(s-4)/2 \geq -1$ in the first case, with equality iff $s \in \{2,3\}$ and $G[C]$ is connected, and $f(C) \geq s(s-5)/2 \geq 0$ in the second. Clusters with $f = -1$ have ≥ 2 vertices, so there are at most m of them, and by Lemma 49(a) cost $\geq (2m+1) - m = m+1$. The partition $\{0,1\}, \{2,3\}, \ldots, \{2m-2, 2m-1\}, \{2m\}$ has cost $m+1$.

(iii) In an optimum $\sum f = -m$, so exactly m clusters have $f = -1$ (each connected, of size 2 or 3) and all others have $f = 0$; at most one vertex lies outside the $f = -1$ clusters. A cluster with $f = -1$ that contains the pendant vertex 0 contains its only neighbour 1; likewise for $2m$ and $2m-1$. Suppose $1, 2m-1$ lie in one cluster C^*. If $f(C^*) = -1$ and $|C^*| = 2$, then $C^* = \{1, 2m-1\}$ contains no pendant, and both pendants are outside the $f = -1$ clusters: two vertices outside, a contradiction. If $f(C^*) = -1$ and $|C^*| = 3$, it contains at most one pendant; any pendant not in C^* has its only neighbour in C^* and lies in no other $f = -1$ cluster, so exactly one pendant is outside and the remaining $2m-3$ vertices must form $m-1$ clusters of size ≥ 2, impossible. If $f(C^*) \geq 0$, at most $2m-1$ vertices remain for m clusters of size ≥ 2. So 1 and $2m-1$ are in different clusters, i.e. e^* is deleted. □

So the pointer realised by the deleted edge e^* joins members at distance $m-1$ in $I(H_m)$: its two ends are not adjacent in any $I(H)^r$ with $r < m-1$, and a decomposition of $I(H)^r$ has no reason to put them in one bag. Both ends have a conflict with the pair, so the two flags that name the pair must agree although the two members are far apart.

Proposition 76 (NF-bad fails for distance 2 and 3; computer-assisted)**.** *The following statement is false for "far" meaning distance ≥ 2 and for "far" meaning distance ≥ 3 in $I(H)$:* there is an optimum in which every far two-sided edit touches a locally bad member.

Witnesses. Both instances have $n = 10$, a pair-maximal modification-disjoint packing, a unique optimum, OPT $= |H| + 1 = 6$, no locally bad member, and exactly one edit, a hard deleted edge, which is two-sided (found and rechecked by enumerating all set partitions). *Distance 2:* $E = \{01, 06, 12, 23, 29, 34, 45, 56, 67, 78, 79\}$, $H = \{(0,1,2), (2,3,4), (4,5,6), (6,7,8), (2,9,7)\}$; the optimum $\{0,1\}, \{2,9\}, \{3,4\}, \{5,6\}, \{7,8\}$ deletes $\{0,6\}$ (witnesses 1 and 5). *Distance 3:* $E = \{01, 08, 12, 14, 23, 34, 45, 49, 56, 67, 78\}$, $H = \{(0,1,2), (2,3,4), (4,5,6), (6,7,8), (1,4,9)\}$; the optimum $\{0,1\}, \{2,3\}, \{4,9\}, \{5,6\}, \{7,8\}$ deletes $\{0,8\}$ (witnesses 1 and 7). In both, $I(H)$ has $c = 3$. □

Remark 77 (Scope). Pointers at distance $\leq K$ are bag-local in a decomposition of $I(H)^K$, whose width is a function of (w, c, K), so the version of the statement that matters is the one with "far" larger than any function of (ℓ, w). Proposition 76 does not refute it, and Proposition 75 does not either: the far ends of its edit are exactly the two locally bad members. So the idea "put the locally bad members into every bag" is excluded for distances 2 and 3 only; for unbounded distance it is open.

Conjecture 78 (Λ; not proved)**.** *Call a hard pair $\{a, b\}$* potentially two-sided *if there are soft partners t of a and t' of b with $b \in \Delta(a,t) \cup \Gamma_h(a,t)$, $a \in \Delta(b,t') \cup \Gamma_h(b,t')$ and both weights $\leq \ell$.*

Let Λ_ℓ be $I(H)$ plus an edge between the members of a and b for every such pair. Then CEaMP is FPT in $(\ell, D, \mathrm{tw}(\Lambda_\ell))$.

We have no proof; a proof would need a sound dynamic program for one-sided edits in the presence of cascades. By Proposition 76 the graph Λ_ℓ cannot simply be replaced by $I(H)$ plus the locally bad members.

Statement	Status
Lemma 66 (W1), Lemma 69 (F1), Lemma 70 (DEL)	proved
Lemma 67 (W2); tightness of the constant $2D$	proved; attained for $D = 2$ only (computer)
Corollary 68 (LB)	proved, a lower bound, not exact at $\ell = 0$
Lemma 71 (BAD)	proved
Proposition 72 (candidate lists, optimal S, (T2)/deleted)	proved
Theorem 73 (P) and Proposition 74	proved (in-degrees ≥ 1, $\ell \leq 4$)
Proposition 75 (FAR)	proved; computer-checked for $m = 3, 4, 5$
Proposition 76 (NF-bad fails at distance 2 and 3)	computer-assisted
NF-bad for unbounded distance	open
Conjecture 78 (Λ)	conjecture
FPT in $\ell + w$	**open**

11 Reducing components of $I(H)$, and an obstruction to the reduction lemma

Conjecture 64 asks for a polynomial-time reduction that bounds $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma')$. This section proves what the rule of [14] gives when it is applied to components of $I(H)$ of *any* size (Theorem 82), reformulates the conjecture (Proposition 79) and shows that the natural generalisation of the rule to unions of *members* cannot prove it, already for $w = 1$ and $\ell = 1$ (Proposition 84). **The reduction lemma ML, the Trigger Lemma below and the question whether CEaMP is FPT in $\ell + w$ remain open.** Soundness of the reduction rule is cited from [14] (Lemma 6.3); everything else is proved here, except for the computer evidence, which is labelled.

Conventions. (G, H, ℓ) with H a packing, pair-maximal unless said otherwise; $D = 2c$, $B = 2D + 3\ell$, $Z = B + D + 1$, BIG, V', Γ' as in Section 9. The components of $I(H)$ are $T_1, \ldots, T_r$, W_j is the union of the vertex sets of the members of T_j, $p_j = |T_j|$, $\tau_j = \mathrm{OPT}(G[W_j]) \geq p_j$; T_j is *tight* if $\tau_j = p_j$. For a set $\mathcal{F}$ of members let $W_\mathcal{F} = \bigcup_{P \in \mathcal{F}} V(P)$; $\mathcal{F}$ is *pair-closed* if no member outside $\mathcal{F}$ has two vertices in $W_\mathcal{F}$ (so no outside member has a pair inside $W_\mathcal{F}$). For an optimal solution $S_\mathcal{F}$ of $G[W_\mathcal{F}]$ say that the *R-condition* holds if for every $y \notin W_\mathcal{F}$ the set $N(y) \cap W_\mathcal{F}$ is empty or exactly one cluster of $G[W_\mathcal{F}] \triangle S_\mathcal{F}$ (this is (R1)+(R2) of Section 6). $\mathcal{F}$ is *reducible* if some such $S_\mathcal{F}$ satisfies the R-condition, and *irreducible* otherwise. *Rule 6.2* ([14], specialised): if $\mathcal{F}$ is reducible by $S_\mathcal{F}$, then $\mathrm{OPT}(G) = \mathrm{OPT}(G \triangle S_\mathcal{F}) + |S_\mathcal{F}|$ (Lemma 6.3 of [14], *cited*; it holds for every induced subgraph). If $\mathcal{F}$ is tight, then $|S_\mathcal{F}| = |\mathcal{F}|$ and $(G \triangle S_\mathcal{F}, H \setminus \mathcal{F}, \ell)$ is equivalent to (G, H, ℓ) (members outside $\mathcal{F}$ have no pair inside $W_\mathcal{F}$, so $H \setminus \mathcal{F}$ is still a packing of the new graph and ℓ is unchanged).

11.1 Reformulation of ML

Proposition 79 (Structure of Γ')**.** *Let (G, H, ℓ) be a YES instance with H pair-maximal.*

(a) $\Gamma' = W[V'] \cup \mathrm{HG}[V']$, where W is the graph of soft pairs and HG *the graph of hard edges.*

(b) Put $Z^* = \max\{Z, (\ell+1)(2D+2\ell+1)\}$. Every hard component K not in BIG *has $|K| \le Z^*$. So "reject if a non-*BIG *hard component has more than Z^* vertices" is a safe polynomial rule.*

(c) Let Q' be Γ' with every hard component contracted. Then $\mathrm{tw}(Q') \le \mathrm{tw}(\Gamma') \le Z^*(\mathrm{tw}(Q')+1)-1$.

Proof. (a) Every edge of G is hard or soft, and soft pairs are edges of W. (b) Take an optimal S with $|S| \le |H| + \ell$ and let U be its edited hard pairs. If no edge of K is deleted, K lies in one cluster C. If C is exceptional, $|C| \le 2D+\ell+1 \le Z$ (Lemma 53(α)). If not, C is a union of whole hard components (Lemma 53(β)); with several components $|C| \le 2D$, and a single component $K = C$ is clean, so each $y \in K$ has all other vertices of K as hard neighbours or soft partners and $|K| \le d_h(y) + D + 1 \le B + D + 1 = Z$ ($K \not\subseteq$ BIG). If edges of K are deleted, there are at most $\ell+1$ pieces of K (components of the kept hard edges); K is connected, so each piece contains an endpoint of a deleted edge and lies in an exceptional cluster of size $\le 2D+\ell+1$; thus $|K| \le (\ell+1)(2D+2\ell+1)$. (c) Hard components are connected in Γ' by hard edges, so Q' is a minor of Γ'. Conversely replace every node of a tree decomposition of Q' by the vertices of its component (of size $\le Z^*$ by (b)). □

Computer evidence (audit, 200 instances with $n = 6, \dots, 8$, all 640 optimal partitions, 166 of which split a hard component): every piece of a split non-BIG component lies in an exceptional cluster, the number of pieces is at most $\ell+1$, sizes within the bounds, no failure (n is too small for Z^* to bite). By Proposition 38 the soft graph W has treewidth $\le 3w+2$, so the unbounded treewidth of Γ' in Proposition 61 comes from hard edges between far vertices, which are free.

11.2 Violations force an edited boundary pair

Lemma 80 (D)**.** *Let S be any solution, $\mathcal{F}$ pair-closed, $S_{\mathcal{F}} = S \cap \binom{W_{\mathcal{F}}}{2}$ and $y \notin W_{\mathcal{F}}$. If $N(y) \cap W_{\mathcal{F}}$ is neither empty nor a cluster of $G[W_{\mathcal{F}}] \triangle S_{\mathcal{F}}$, then S contains a pair $\{y, u\}$ with $u \in W_{\mathcal{F}}$.*

Proof. Suppose not. Then $N_{G\triangle S}(y) \cap W_{\mathcal{F}} = N_G(y) \cap W_{\mathcal{F}}$. In the cluster graph $G \triangle S$ this set is $\mathrm{cluster}(y) \cap W_{\mathcal{F}}$ (as $y \notin W_{\mathcal{F}}$), which is empty or a cluster of the induced subgraph $(G\triangle S)[W_{\mathcal{F}}] = G[W_{\mathcal{F}}] \triangle S_{\mathcal{F}}$. □

Lemma 80 is the engine of Lemma 26. (The pair $\{y, u\}$ is either hard or a packed pair of a member through u that is not in $\mathcal{F}$; for a whole component only the first case occurs, which is why the counting of [14] works for components.)

Proposition 81 (Tight and reducible components are decidable)**.** *For a component T of $I(H)$ and a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w, one decides in time $3^{w+1}n^{O(1)}$ whether T is tight and whether it is reducible, and finds S_T.*

Proof. A tight solution consists of one edited pair per member and nothing else (each member needs at least one edited pair and the pair sets are disjoint), and such a solution of $G[W_T]$ is optimal since $\tau_T \ge p_T$. Variables: the three choices of each member. Constraint: $G[W_T] \triangle S$ has no induced P_3, i.e. every triple of W_T is fine. A triple with a soft pair involves at most three members (one per soft pair, pair sets being disjoint); each owns two of the three vertices of the triple, so any two of them share a vertex, they form a clique of $I(H)$ and lie in a common bag. A triple without soft pair is checked statically. The R-condition at $y \notin W_T$, $A_y = N(y) \cap W_T \neq \emptyset$: (i) every pair inside A_y is an edge of $G \triangle S$ and (ii) every pair between A_y and $W_T \setminus A_y$ is a non-edge of $G \triangle S$ (given that $G[W_T] \triangle S$ is a cluster graph this says A_y is a cluster). Each such pair is hard (static) or owned by one member (a unary constraint). So tightness is a CSP, and reducibility a CSP with additional

unary constraints, with domain size 3 and scopes inside bags of the restriction of the decomposition to T (width $\leq w$); dynamic programming gives $3^{w+1}n^{O(1)}$. □

Theorem 82 (Component reduction)**.** *Let H be* any *packing, $\ell' = \ell - \sum_j(\tau_j - p_j)$, and apply Rule 6.2 to every reducible tight component (found by Proposition 81). Then, modulo the cited soundness of Rule 6.2 (Lemma 6.3 of [14]), the reduced instance is equivalent to (G, H, ℓ), and if it is a YES instance then $\ell' \geq 0$ and the number r of components of I of the remaining packing satisfies $r \leq \ell + \ell' \leq 2\ell$. In particular* if more than 2ℓ components remain, the answer is NO. *No τ_j of a non-tight component is needed by the algorithm.*

Proof. The rule. The set S_j used for a reducible tight component T_j consists of pairs inside W_j. So $G[W_i]$ and the sets $N(y) \cap W_i$ $(i \neq j)$ do not change, τ_i, tightness and (ir)reducibility of the other components are unchanged, ℓ and ℓ' are unchanged (Lemma 25), and one pass reaches an instance with no reducible tight component.

Counting. Work in the reduced instance. Let $\mathcal{A}$ be the set of tight (irreducible) components and $\mathcal{B}$ the set of non-tight ones. Since $\sum_j \tau_j = |H| + \sum_j(\tau_j - p_j)$, we have $|H| + \ell = \sum_j \tau_j + \ell'$. For a solution S put $S_j = S \cap \binom{W_j}{2}$ (a solution of $G[W_j]$, so $|S_j| \geq \tau_j$) and S_{ext} for the pairs of S inside no W_j; $|S| = \sum_j |S_j| + |S_{\text{ext}}| \geq \sum_j \tau_j$, so $\ell' < 0$ gives NO (Lemma 24). Let S be optimal with $|S| \leq \sum_j \tau_j + \ell'$. For $j \in \mathcal{A}$, either $|S_j| \geq \tau_j + 1$, or S_j is an optimal solution of $G[W_j]$; since T_j is irreducible S_j violates the R-condition at some $y \notin W_j$, and Lemma 80 (a component is pair-closed) gives an edited pair $\{y, u\}$ with $u \in W_j$. It lies in no $\binom{W_i}{2}$, so it is in S_{ext}, and it is counted for at most two components (those of its two ends). Hence $|S_{\text{ext}}| \geq |\mathcal{A}_b|/2$ where $\mathcal{A}_b$ are the components of the second kind, and $|S| \geq \sum_j \tau_j + |\mathcal{A}_a| + |\mathcal{A}_b|/2 \geq \sum_j \tau_j + |\mathcal{A}|/2$. Thus $|\mathcal{A}| \leq 2\ell'$. Each $j \in \mathcal{B}$ has $\tau_j - p_j \geq 1$, so $|\mathcal{B}| \leq \sum_j(\tau_j - p_j) = \ell - \ell'$. Therefore $r \leq 2\ell' + \ell - \ell' = \ell + \ell' \leq 2\ell$ (as $\ell' \leq \ell$). □

The theorem is phrased through the number of remaining components so that it does not need the τ_j of non-tight components, which are not computable in polynomial time for a large component.

Corollary 83. *(a) For $\ell = 0$ a YES instance is reduced to the empty packing; this agrees with Theorem 5. (b)* Alternation with Lemma 30. *Applying Lemma 30 may lower the budget by $|M| \geq 1$ and raises the treewidth of I by at most $|M|$; the alternation of reduction and maximalisation stops after at most ℓ rounds. It ends with a pair-maximal packing, a budget $\ell^* \leq \ell$, treewidth $w^* \leq w + \ell$, and at most $2\ell^*$ components of the intersection graph.*

Proof. (a) $r \leq 2\ell = 0$. (b) Each round with $M \neq \emptyset$ lowers the budget by $|M|$; in the last round $M = \emptyset$, i.e. the packing produced by the last reduction pass is already pair-maximal, and Theorem 82 applies to it. □

What remains, after the reduction, is the case of *few but arbitrarily large* components of $I(H)$ (for $w = 1$, a single tree of members), which is Open Problem 7.

Computer evidence (audit, independent code, 1,350 instances with $n = 7, \ldots, 11$ and arbitrary packings): Lemma 80 had no failure in about $4 \cdot 10^5$ checks of a pair (partition, y); the tightness decided by enumerating all 3^p states agrees with the dynamic program of Proposition 81 in all instances; Rule 6.2 gave $\text{OPT}(G \triangle S_j) + |S_j| = \text{OPT}(G)$ in 850 applications to R-satisfying tight S_j; one pass lowered OPT by exactly $\sum p_j$ in all instances, leaving no reducible tight component; and $|\mathcal{A}| \leq 2\ell'$, $|\mathcal{B}| \leq \ell - \ell'$, $r \leq \ell + \ell'$ in all 4,050 pairs (instance, ℓ) with $\ell \in \{\text{OPT} - |H|, +1, +2\}$.

11.3 Why Rule 6.2 on unions of members cannot prove ML

Proposition 84 (The family $N^*(F)$)**.** *Let F be a cubic graph with an orientation of in-degree at most 2 at every vertex. Let F' be F plus a new vertex $*$ and an edge $e_0 = (t \to *)$, $t \in V(F)$. Order the edges of F' as $e_0, e_1, \dots, e_N$ so that e_0 comes first,* consecutive edges have different heads and $\mathrm{head}(e_1) \neq \mathrm{tail}(e_0) = t$ *(possible, since every head occurs at most twice and t has in-degree at most 2). Write $h(i)$ and $\mathrm{t}(i)$ for the head and tail of e_i. The instance $N^*(F)$ has vertices a_i, b_i, c_i, u_i $(0 \le i \le N)$, z and y; for $v \in V(F')$ the sets $K_v^+ = \{a_i : \mathrm{t}(i) = v\} \cup \{b_i, c_i, u_i : h(i) = v\}$ (so $K_*^+ = \{b_0, c_0, u_0\}$). Edges: all pairs inside each K_v^+; the cross edges a_ib_i; the spine edges b_iu_{i+1} $(i < N)$ and b_Nz; and yu_0, yc_0 (and no other edge at y). Packing: $P_i = (a_i, b_i, c_i)$ and $X_i = (u_i, b_i, u_{i+1})$, both with centre b_i ($u_{N+1} := z$); $\ell = 1$. Then:*

(F1) the members are induced P_3's with pairwise disjoint pair sets, H is pair-maximal, $I(H)$ is a caterpillar (spine $X_0, \dots, X_N$, leaf P_i at X_i), so $w = 1$, $c = 2$, $D = 4$;

(F2) $(G, H, 1)$ is a YES instance and $\mathrm{OPT} = |H| + 1$*;*

(F3) all hard degrees are at most $7 \le B = 11$, so $\mathrm{BIG} = \emptyset$*;*

(F4) F is a minor of Γ', so $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma') \ge \mathrm{tw}(F)$, which is $\Omega(|V(F)|)$ for cubic expanders [8] (cited);

(F5) $I(H)$ is connected and tight: $\tau = |H|$;

(F6) every nonempty pair-closed set $\mathcal{F}$ of members (connected or not) is irreducible.

Proof. (F1) Every induced P_3 of G uses a cross edge or a spine edge or a y-edge, because two edges inside cliques at a common vertex lie in one clique. P_i is induced: a_ib_i is a cross edge, b_ic_i lies in $K_{h(i)}^+$, $a_ic_i \notin E$ because $\mathrm{t}(i) \neq h(i)$. X_i is induced: u_ib_i lies in $K_{h(i)}^+$, b_iu_{i+1} is a spine edge, and $u_iu_{i+1} \notin E$ since consecutive heads differ (z is adjacent to b_N only). The pair sets $\{a_ib_i, b_ic_i, a_ic_i\}$, $\{u_ib_i, b_iu_{i+1}, u_iu_{i+1}\}$ are pairwise disjoint. Pair-maximality: no two hard edges form an induced P_3. The soft edges are a_ib_i, b_ic_i, u_ib_i, b_iu_{i+1}, so the hard edges are the other clique edges and yu_0, yc_0. Two hard clique edges at a vertex lie in one clique, so their other ends are adjacent; the hard edges at y go to u_0, c_0, which are adjacent; and a hard edge at u_0 or c_0 inside $K_*^+ = \{b_0, c_0, u_0\}$ can only be u_0c_0, whose ends are both adjacent to y.

(F2) The partition $\{K_v^+\}$ together with $\{z\}$, with y put into K_*^+, deletes exactly the $2(N+1) = |H|$ cross and spine edges (all packed) and inserts the single pair yb_0; its cost is $|H| + 1$. For $\mathrm{OPT} \ge |H| + 1$ see (F6) below.

(F3) A vertex of K_v^+ has at most $|K_v^+| - 1 = 2 + 2\,\mathrm{in}(v) \le 6$ hard neighbours inside its clique, and u_0, c_0 have one more hard neighbour, y (which has hard degree 2).

(F4) Contract every K_v^+ (a clique). The cross edges a_ib_i join $K_{\mathrm{t}(i)}^+$ and $K_{h(i)}^+$, so the quotient contains F.

(F5) In the partition of (F2), the pair a_ib_i is deleted, b_ic_i kept, a_ic_i a non-edge in different clusters; u_ib_i kept, b_iu_{i+1} deleted, u_iu_{i+1} a non-edge in different clusters. So its restriction to $W = V \setminus \{y\}$ edits exactly one pair per member: $\tau \le |H|$, hence $\tau = |H|$.

(F6) For pair-closed $\mathcal{F}$ the restriction of the solution of (F2) to $W_{\mathcal{F}}$ has at most $|\mathcal{F}|$ edits (no member outside $\mathcal{F}$ has a pair inside $W_{\mathcal{F}}$, and yb_0 leaves $W_{\mathcal{F}}$), so $\tau(G[W_{\mathcal{F}}]) = |\mathcal{F}|$ and the optimal $S_{\mathcal{F}}$ are the *tight* ones: exactly one edited pair per member of $\mathcal{F}$ and no hard pair is edited. Suppose such an $S_{\mathcal{F}}$ satisfied the R-condition. We use repeatedly: two vertices $p, q \in W_{\mathcal{F}}$ joined by a hard non-edge are non-adjacent in $G[W_{\mathcal{F}}] \triangle S_{\mathcal{F}}$, and a hard edge is kept.

Case 1: $\mathcal{F}$ contains a spine member; let X_i be the one of smallest index.

$i \geq 1$. Then $X_{i-1} \notin \mathcal{F}$, and $P_{i-1} \notin \mathcal{F}$: otherwise $b_{i-1}, u_i \in W_\mathcal{F}$ and the pair $b_{i-1}u_i$ of the outside member X_{i-1} would lie inside $W_\mathcal{F}$. So $a_{i-1}, b_{i-1}, u_{i-1} \notin W_\mathcal{F}$ and $N(b_{i-1}) \cap W_\mathcal{F} = \{u_i\} \cup M$ with $M = K^+_{h(i-1)} \cap W_\mathcal{F}$. For $m \in M$ the pair $u_i m$ is a non-edge ($h(i) \neq h(i-1)$) and is soft only if $m = u_{i+1}$. If M contains some $m \neq u_{i+1}$, then u_i, m are two non-adjacent vertices of $N(b_{i-1}) \cap W_\mathcal{F}$: the R-condition fails. If $M = \{u_{i+1}\}$, the set $\{u_i, u_{i+1}\}$ must be a cluster, so X_i inserts $u_i u_{i+1}$ and keeps $u_i b_i$, $b_i u_{i+1}$; then b_i lies in this cluster, but $b_i \notin N(b_{i-1})$: contradiction. So $M = \emptyset$ and $\{u_i\}$ is a cluster, i.e. X_i deletes $u_i b_i$. If $P_i \notin \mathcal{F}$, the vertex $c_i \notin W_\mathcal{F}$ is adjacent to u_i and b_i, which lie in different clusters: the R-condition fails at c_i. If $P_i \in \mathcal{F}$, the hard edge $u_i c_i$ is kept, contradicting that u_i is a singleton.

$i = 0$. The vertex $y \notin W_\mathcal{F}$ has $N(y) \cap W_\mathcal{F} = \{u_0\}$ if $P_0 \notin \mathcal{F}$ and $\{u_0, c_0\}$ if $P_0 \in \mathcal{F}$. First case: $\{u_0\}$ is a cluster, so X_0 deletes $u_0 b_0$, and $c_0 \notin W_\mathcal{F}$, adjacent to $u_0, b_0 \in W_\mathcal{F}$ in different clusters, violates the condition. Second case: $\{u_0, c_0\}$ must be a cluster, so b_0 is separated from both: X_0 deletes $u_0 b_0$ and P_0 deletes $b_0 c_0$. Then $a_0 b_0$ and $b_0 u_1$ are kept, so a_0, u_1 are adjacent to b_0. Now $a_0 \in K^+_t$ and $u_1 \in K^+_{h(1)}$ with $h(1) \neq t$ *by the ordering condition*, so $a_0 u_1$ is a hard non-edge (the soft partners of a_0 are b_0, c_0), and $a_0 b_0 u_1$ is an induced P_3 of $G[W_\mathcal{F}] \triangle S_\mathcal{F}$: contradiction.

Case 2: $\mathcal{F}$ contains only leaves. Take $P_i \in \mathcal{F}$; $u_i, u_{i+1} \notin W_\mathcal{F}$ (for $i = N$ read z for u_{i+1}). If $i = N$ then $N(z) \cap W_\mathcal{F} = \{b_N\}$ must be a cluster, i.e. b_N is a singleton; but each of the three single edits of P_N (delete $a_N b_N$, delete $b_N c_N$, insert $a_N c_N$) keeps b_N with a_N or c_N. So let $i < N$. Then $N(u_{i+1}) \cap W_\mathcal{F} = \{b_i\} \cup M$ with $M = K^+_{h(i+1)} \cap W_\mathcal{F}$. For $m \in M$ the pair $b_i m$ is a non-edge ($h(i+1) \neq h(i)$) unless $m = a_i$ (possible when $\mathrm{t}(i) = h(i+1)$), and it is soft only if $m = a_i$ (the soft partners of b_i are a_i, c_i, u_i, u_{i+1}). *(2a)* If M contains some $m \neq a_i$, then b_i, m are non-adjacent in $N(u_{i+1}) \cap W_\mathcal{F}$: failure. *(2b)* If $M = \emptyset$, then $\{b_i\}$ is a cluster, impossible as above. *(2c)* If $M = \{a_i\}$, then $P_{i+1} \notin \mathcal{F}$ and $b_{i+1} \in K^+_{h(i+1)}$ is outside $W_\mathcal{F}$ with $N(b_{i+1}) \cap W_\mathcal{F} = \{a_i\}$; this must be a cluster, so a_i is a singleton and $a_i b_i$ is deleted. But then $\{a_i, b_i\} = N(u_{i+1}) \cap W_\mathcal{F}$ is not a cluster ($a_i b_i$ is not an edge of $G \triangle S_\mathcal{F}$): contradiction.

So $\mathcal{F}$ is irreducible. For the lower bound of (F2): if $\mathrm{OPT} = |H|$, an optimum S has $|S| = \tau$ for the whole component, so $S = S_T$ with $T = I(H)$ tight and optimal on $W = V \setminus \{y\}$; by (F6) it violates the R-condition at y, and Lemma 80 gives an edited pair $\{y, u\}$, which contradicts $S = S_T$. So $\mathrm{OPT} \geq |H| + 1$. □

Remark 85 (What is verified, and what is not). The repaired proof of (F6) (the ordering condition in the case $i = 0$, and sub-case (2c)) follows the repair indicated by the audit and was not audited again. The computer checks of the audit (own construction, all claims (F1)–(F5), $\mathrm{OPT} = |H|+1$ by an exact subset dynamic program for the triangle, $n = 18$) found no failure of (F6) in the following cases: for the triangle all 90 pair-closed subfamilies with $|\mathcal{F}| \leq 6$ and the whole component $\mathcal{F} = T$; for K_4 ($n = 30$) all 632 pair-closed subfamilies with $|\mathcal{F}| \leq 4$, for 8 random admissible orderings. The whole component was checked for the triangle only. No claim is made beyond this coverage and the proof above.

Consequence (a precise obstruction, not a refutation of ML). No reduction obtained by iterating Rule 6.2 on pair-closed unions of members (the form used for components in Section 6 and in Theorem 82) can prove Conjecture 64 by itself: on $N^*(F)$ it removes nothing, although $\ell = 1$, $w = 1$, $\mathrm{BIG} = \emptyset$ and $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma') = \Omega(|V(F)|)$. In particular the counting argument of Lemma 26 does not extend from components to members: all $2(N + 1)$ members are irreducible although $\ell = 1$. The mechanism is Lemma 80: along the spine each member is made irreducible by an edit at a shared vertex of its neighbour, down to the trigger y. Other generalisations of the rule (to sets W that are not unions of members) are not excluded.

Conjecture 86 (TL: trigger lemma; not proved, not tested at scale)**.** *If T is a tight irreducible component, there is a set Y of at most $g(\ell, D)$ outside vertices, computable in polynomial time, such that every solution of cost at most $|H| + \ell$ whose restriction to W_T is tight edits an unpacked pair at a vertex of Y.*

In $N^*(F)$ the vertex y plays this role. We do not know whether the conjecture is true and claim no consequence for CEaMP.

Statement	Status
Proposition 79 (Γ', hard components, Z^*)	proved; computer-checked ($n \leq 8$)
Lemma 80	proved
Proposition 81 (3^{w+1} test)	proved
Theorem 82 (at most 2ℓ components)	proved modulo cited [14] Lemma 6.3
Proposition 84 ($N^*(F)$)	proved; computer coverage as in Remark 85
Conjecture 86 (TL)	conjecture
Conjecture 64 (ML)	conjecture
FPT in $\ell + w$	**open**

12 Why tunnel reductions stall

Status of this section. Statements labelled Lemma, Proposition or Observation are proved here (with the cited earlier lemmas), and their proofs were re-derived and tested by brute force in an independent audit. Statements labelled *computer evidence* are exhaustive or sampled searches over small instances (all set partitions, $n \leq 10$) and are not theorems. Statements labelled *heuristic* are arguments without a full proof. Neither W[1]-hardness nor fixed-parameter tractability of CEaMP in $\ell + w$ follows from anything below (Open Problem 2).

The most natural attempt at W[1]-hardness in $\ell + w$ is a reduction from Grid Tiling in which hard edges between far-apart vertices (*tunnels*) carry equalities between distant parts of $I(H)$ of bounded width. The lemmas below say what a tunnel can and cannot do, and isolate one missing gadget.

12.1 Zero-excess solutions and tunnels

Notation of Section 9: a pair is *soft* if it belongs to a member of H and *hard* otherwise; $Q(v)$ is the set of soft partners of v. A solution S is *zero-excess* (ZE) if $|S| = |H|$. A member (a, b, c) (centre b) is in state L, R or M if its edited pair is ab, bc or ac. By Lemma 1 a ZE solution has exactly one edit in each member and no other edit, so it is determined by its vector of states; let $\Sigma = \Sigma(G, H) \subseteq \{L, R, M\}^H$ be the set of these vectors. None of the lemmas of this subsection and the next needs pair-maximality.

Lemma 87 (Zero-excess structure)**.** *Let S be a ZE solution. (a) Every hard edge lies inside a cluster and every hard non-edge joins two clusters. (b) Every member is in one of the states L, R, M. (c) Every hard component lies in one cluster, and two vertices of one cluster in different hard components form a soft pair.*

Proof. (a),(b) are Lemma 1 with $|S| = |H|$: no hard pair is edited and each member has exactly one edit. A member (a, b, c) with togetherness pattern (t_{ab}, t_{bc}, t_{ac}) has the cluster patterns $000, 100, 010, 111$ of costs $2, 1, 1, 1$, so the one-edit patterns are R, L, M. (c) A hard edge is unedited, so its ends are together; two vertices of one cluster in different hard components are not joined by a hard edge, and a hard non-edge inside a cluster would be edited, so the pair is soft. □

A *tunnel* is a hard edge xx' with $N_h(x) = \{x'\}$, $N_h(x') = \{x\}$ and $Q(x) \cap Q(x') = \emptyset$; tunnels are always taken pairwise vertex-disjoint. A *stub* at x is a new vertex x' adjacent to x only (then $Q(x') = \emptyset$). A vertex is an *anchor* if it lies in a member and has no hard edge. *Cutting* a tunnel means editing xx' (one hard edit).

Lemma 88 (A tunnel is a lock)**.** *Let xx' be a tunnel and S a solution in which all hard pairs at x and at x' are unedited. Then the cluster of x is $\{x, x'\}$. If S is ZE, then no member has x as centre, every member through x has x as an end with the pair at x that is an edge deleted, and the other two vertices of that member are together.*

Proof. Let $t \neq x, x'$ be in the cluster of x. If $t \notin Q(x)$ then xt is hard, hence a non-edge as $N_h(x) = \{x'\}$, hence edited, a contradiction; so $t \in Q(x)$, and likewise $t \in Q(x')$, contradicting $Q(x) \cap Q(x') = \emptyset$. In a ZE solution a member (y, x, z) with centre x would have both pairs at x apart, hence two edits. If x is an end, the pair x–centre is apart (an edit), the non-edge at x is apart (no edit), so the remaining pair is together. □

Lemma 89 (Anchors: singleton = forced states; inactive anchors cost nothing)**.** *Let x be an anchor and σ a ZE solution of (G, H). Then x is a singleton of σ iff every member through x has x as an end and is in the state that deletes the edge at x. Moreover: (a) if G' is G with a stub at x, then G' has a ZE solution iff G has a ZE solution in which x is a singleton; (b) if x_1, x_2 are anchors that lie in no common member, are non-adjacent and have $Q(x_1) \cap Q(x_2) = \emptyset$, and G' is G plus the edge x_1x_2, then G' has a ZE solution iff G has a ZE solution in which x_1 and x_2 are both singletons.*

Proof. The first statement: ($\Rightarrow$) as in Lemma 88; ($\Leftarrow$) the soft partners of x are its mates in members, and these are apart from x; x has no hard edge, and its hard non-edges are unedited. (a),(b) ($\Rightarrow$): by Lemma 88 the cluster is $\{x, x'\}$ (resp. $\{x_1, x_2\}$); split it into singletons. No other pair changes status or togetherness. ($\Leftarrow$) join the singleton to its stub (resp. join the two singletons). □

Thus an anchor costs nothing when it is a singleton in some ZE solution, and the point of a tunnel is precisely that this singleton requirement is a constraint on the member states through x: a *lock*. (A lock fixes the states of the members through x to unit values; it never forces more.)

Lemma 90 (Rigidity at a lock)**.** *Let S be ZE. (a) If y, z are together then for every $q \notin \{y, z\}$, q is together with y iff with z. Hence if qz is hard and qy soft, the soft pair qy is forced to be together iff $qz \in E$; if both are soft, the owners of yz, qy, qz form a clique of $I(H)$ (a triangle if distinct). (b) If u, w and w, v are together, then uv is an edge or a soft pair.*

Proof. Transitivity of "together"; for (b) a hard pair inside a cluster is an unedited edge (Lemma 87(a)). □

Consequently the two vertices that a lock bridges (the mates y, z of a locked member) are *occupied*: $y \sim z$ is a cluster that cannot also be bridged to a third vertex unless the pair is an edge or soft.

12.2 Memory across a tree decomposition

Let (T, X) be a tree decomposition of $I(H)$, $e = tt'$ an edge of T, B the members in both bags of e, and M_1, M_2 the members that occur only on the side of t, resp. t'. A set S of anchors is a *face* if some ZE solution of (G, H) makes every $x \in S$ a singleton; equivalently (Lemma 89) the partial vector of forced states is the restriction of an element of Σ. A *minimal non-face* (a *core*) is a non-face all of whose proper subsets are faces.

Lemma 91 (Splice). *(a) If $\sigma, \sigma' \in \Sigma$ agree on B, the vector equal to σ on $M_1 \cup B$ and to σ' on M_2 is in Σ. (b) Let $S = S_1 \cup S_2$ be a core with all members through anchors of S_i in M_i ($i = 1, 2$, both parts non-empty). For $b \in S$ let $\sigma^b \in \Sigma$ make all anchors of $S \setminus \{b\}$ singletons. Then $\{\sigma^b|_B : b \in S_1\}$ and $\{\sigma^a|_B : a \in S_2\}$ are disjoint.*

Proof. (a) $\sigma \in \Sigma$ iff no vertex triple is an induced P_3 after editing; the status of a triple's pairs depends on the owners of its packed pairs, a clique of $I(H)$ (Observation 4), so contained in one bag, hence in $M_1 \cup B$ or in $M_2 \cup B$; all constraints are satisfied by the combined vector. (b) If $\sigma^b|_B = \sigma^a|_B$ with $b \in S_1$, $a \in S_2$, splice σ^a on $M_1 \cup B$ with σ^b on M_2: the anchors of S_1 are singletons (they are in $S \setminus \{a\}$, and their members are in M_1), those of S_2 likewise, so S is a face, a contradiction. □

Heuristic reading. A core of size N spread along a path decomposition makes the $N-1$ boundary bags separate "the released anchor is on the left" from "on the right": the bag state must remember, at every boundary, one bit of information about where the (single) unlocked anchor is. Lemma 91 proves only the disjointness above, not that a single bit is carried.

Lemma 92 (Majority closure bounds cores). *Suppose Σ is closed under a majority operation $m : \{L, R, M\}^3 \to \{L, R, M\}$ applied coordinatewise ($m(a, a, b) = m(a, b, a) = m(b, a, a) = a$). Then every core has at most two anchors.*

Proof. Let T be the set of members through the anchors of a set S and $R' = \mathrm{proj}_T(\Sigma)$, closed under m. By Lemma 89, S is a face iff the partial vector t of forced states (if consistent) is in R'. Claim: if every pair of coordinates of t is in the corresponding binary projection of R', then $t \in R'$. Induction on $|T|$; $|T| \le 2$ is trivial. For $|T| \ge 3$ choose three coordinates i_1, i_2, i_3 and $u_j \in R'$ extending t on $T \setminus \{i_j\}$ (induction). Then $m(u_1, u_2, u_3) = t$: at i_1 the vectors u_2, u_3 agree with t, similarly at i_2, i_3, and elsewhere all three agree. A binary subtuple of t involves at most two anchors, so if all pairs of anchors are faces, S is a face. □

(This is the Baker–Pixley argument; the proof above is self-contained.)

12.3 Fan-out of released tunnels, and the tunnel-release model

Lemma 93 (Released ends have small hard degree). *Let H be pair-maximal, $D \ge \max_v |Q(v)|$, and S an optimal solution with $|S| \le |H| + \ell$. (a) Every endpoint of an edited hard pair (in particular of a cut hard edge) has hard degree at most $D + \ell$. (b) Every hard component containing a vertex of hard degree larger than $2D + 3\ell$ is a whole cluster of S in which no* hard *pair is edited.*

Proof. (a) Lemma 51(a) gives $d_h(x) \le D + u$ and $u \le |S| - |H| \le \ell$. (b) Lemma 53(γ) with $B = 2D + 3\ell$; hard pairs inside the cluster are unedited by Lemma 53(β). Soft pairs inside the component may be edited (take K_9 minus one edge ac with $H = \{(a, b, c)\}$). □

Proposition 94 (Bounded-degree Grid Tiling is easy). *Grid Tiling (find $a_1, \ldots, a_k, b_1, \ldots, b_k \in [n]$ with $(a_i, b_j) \in S_{ij}$ for all i, j) is solvable in time $n\, d^{2k}$ poly on instances where every value has at most d partners in every S_{ij}.*

Proof. Guess a_1 (n ways); each b_j has at most d candidates, being a partner of a_1 in S_{1j}; then each a_i has at most d candidates, being a partner of b_1 in S_{i1}. □

Heuristic consequence. By Lemma 93 a tunnel that is ever released in an optimum has bounded fan-out, and by Proposition 94 a Grid Tiling reduction cannot write the relations S_{ij} into tunnels

of unbounded fan-out; a tile would have to be encoded as a *position* on a track, the tunnels forming a matching between two orderings of the same tiles. The packing lemmas HUB$^+$ (Lemma 33) and SM (Lemma 36) are not violated by tunnels of hard degree one; the obstruction is not there but in the rigidity of Lemmas 88–90.

The tunnel-release model. Fix a packing H and a set $\mathcal{T}$ of tunnels (stubs allowed). A *TR-solution* is a solution with exactly one edit in every member whose hard edits are cuts of tunnels; its excess is the number of cuts. For $R \subseteq \mathcal{T}$ let $f(R) = 1$ iff G minus the tunnel edges of R has a ZE solution; call $S \subseteq \mathcal{T}$ *lockable* if $f(\mathcal{T} \setminus S) = 1$, and a minimal non-lockable set a *core*.

Proposition 95 (Bounded cores give FPT in the model)**.** *(i) f is monotone. (ii) $f(R) = 1$ iff R meets every core. (iii) The minimum number of cuts of a TR-solution is the minimum size of a hitting set of the cores. (iv) If every core has at most d tunnels, this minimum is computable in time $d^\ell 3^{w+1} n^{O(1)}$ (or decides that it exceeds ℓ), given a tree decomposition of $I(H)$ of width w.*

Proof. (i) Given a ZE solution of G minus R' and $R' \subseteq R$, each tunnel of $R \setminus R'$ is a cluster $\{x, x'\}$ (Lemma 88); splitting it into singletons changes no edit. (ii),(iii): $f(R) = 1$ iff $\mathcal{T} \setminus R$ is lockable iff it contains no core, as non-lockability is upward closed; a TR-solution with cut set R exists iff $f(R) = 1$. (iv) Test f with the $\ell = 0$ dynamic program of Theorem 5; find a core inside $\mathcal{T} \setminus R$ by deleting tunnels one at a time while the rest stays non-lockable; branch on which of its at most d tunnels is cut, to depth ℓ. □

This is a statement about a restricted model, not about CEaMP: solutions in which a member receives two edits, or a hard pair other than a tunnel edge is edited, are excluded, and they can be strictly cheaper. Computer evidence: in 931 random tunnelled instances (two or three tunnels, $n \leq 10$) with a finite hitting-set value, 411 had OPT $- |H|$ strictly smaller than that value. Inside the model, a W[1]-hardness proof therefore needs cores of unbounded size, and by Lemma 91 a core of size N cannot be absorbed by a bounded-width decomposition without the memory described above; this last implication is heuristic.

12.4 Computer evidence

All items of this subsection are computer evidence: independent brute-force confirmations on small instances, not theorems.

- *Cost sharing of a tunnel.* Let $P = (x, y, z)$ and $P' = (x', y', z')$ be vertex-disjoint members and let z, z' have pendant hard neighbours t, t', so that the only ZE state of each member is R (x joins y). Then OPT $= 2$ without a tunnel, 4 with private stubs at x and x', 3 with one tunnel xx' (one cut serves both members), and 2 again with the tunnel if the pendant neighbours are removed (state L is available: an inactive anchor costs nothing).

- *A local flip gadget exists.* Let G^* have vertices $0, 1, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7$ and edges $01, 04, 05, 14, 15, 45, 03, 13, 36, 37, 06, 56$, with members $(6, 3, 7), (4, 1, 3), (5, 0, 3), (4, 5, 6), (6, 0, 1)$ and anchor $x = 7$ (its only hard edges are 04 and 15, the anchor has none; $c = 3$). It is valid, pair-maximal and tight (OPT $= |H| = 5$), and has exactly five ZE solutions: with x a singleton, $\{0, 1, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$ and $\{0, 1, 4, 5\}, \{3, 6\}$; with x not a singleton, $\{0, 1, 4, 5, 6\}, \{3, 7\}$, $\{0, 1, 4, 5\}, \{3, 6, 7\}$ and $\{0, 1, 4, 5\}, \{3, 7\}, \{6\}$. On the pair of members $m_3 = (4, 5, 6)$, $m_1 = (4, 1, 3)$ the locked relation (anchor a singleton) is the equality on $\{M, R\}$, while releasing the anchor admits (M, R): the stored value flips only when the tunnel at x is cut. Adding a vertex t adjacent to $0, 1, 4, 5, 6$ makes the unique

optimum have x released (OPT $= 5$); with a stub on x the optimum is 6. Searches over random configurations reported in the working notes (not re-run for this paper) found no flip gadget with three or four members ($n \leq 7$, resp. 8) and 128 with five members at $n = 8$. The relation of G^* is not determined by its binary projections ($RRRMM$ is pairwise consistent but not a solution).

- *No cores of size ≥ 3 in small tight graphs.* Among all connected graphs on at most 7 vertices (atlas) with OPT equal to the packing number, and about 1,700 random connected tight graphs with $n = 8, 9$, no set of vertices is a minimal non-face of size 3 (faces of vertex sets via optimal partitions); searches reported in the working notes give the same up to $n = 9$, and by ILP up to $n = 17$. Cores of size 2 occur.

- *Negative composition results (searches reported in the working notes; not re-run for this paper, small search spaces).* Rings of $N = 3, \ldots, 7$ copies of G^* sharing a vertex are tight but no single anchor can be a singleton for $N \geq 4$ (explained by Lemma 90(b): the shared vertex lies in two bridges); other ways of chaining G^* (wire members, identification of vertices, shared pieces) were not tight, or had all anchors simultaneously lockable, or none; composing the 1,860 flip records found, an alternating chain with a bridge-free gadget (it does not transmit the bit), odd rings of K_2 pieces, and gadgets with separate clean sockets for an OR-wire chain ($n \leq 9$) produced no chain. These results are evidence, not theorems.

- *Majority closure fails exactly where hardness could begin; the notes' conjecture is false in its first form.* For $c \leq 2$ the set Σ was closed under the uniform "all distinct $\mapsto M$" majority in almost all random tight instances, but not in all: a tight instance with $n = 6$, $c = 2$, edges $03, 05, 12, 14, 23, 24, 25, 34, 35, 45$ and members $(0, 5, 4), (1, 2, 5), (0, 3, 2), (1, 4, 3)$ has $\Sigma = \{LLLL, LMLM, MLML, RRRR\}$, and the majority of $LMLM, MLML, RRRR$ is $MMMM \notin \Sigma$ (about 1.4% of the sampled tight instances with $n = 6$, $c \leq 2$ and $|\Sigma| \geq 3$, 0.4% over $n = 6, \ldots, 9$). All tested instances with $c \leq 2$ nevertheless had Σ determined by its binary projections, and none had a core of size 3.

12.5 What a reduction would need, and what is open

Heuristic blueprint. Suppose a family of tight instances G_N of bounded $\mathrm{tw}(I(H_N))$ and bounded c had N clean anchors $x_1, \ldots, x_N$ such that stubs on all x_j force OPT $= |H| + 1$ while stubs on any $N - 1$ of them do not (a core of size N), and such that the bit "the released anchor is at position $\leq t$" could be read at every position and compared across two such tracks by equality wires. Then Grid Tiling would reduce to CEaMP with $\ell = k^2$ and width $O(k^2)$: a tile $(a, b) \in S_{ij}$ is one anchor on a track ordered by (a, b) and one on a track ordered by (b, a), joined by a tunnel of fan-out one (so HUB$^+$ and Lemma 93 hold trivially); one shared cut per cell encodes the tile; the equalities of positions at block boundaries give $a_{ij} = a_{i,j+1}$ and $b_{ij} = b_{i+1,j}$. This is a sketch; none of its steps has been written out as a proof, since the family does not exist as far as we know.

Open Problem 1 (The chain object)**.** Is there a family (G_N, H_N) with c and $\mathrm{tw}(I(H_N))$ bounded independently of N, with (G_N, H_N) tight, and with N anchors forming a core of size N (equivalently, by Proposition 95, unbounded cores in the tunnel-release model)? We know a single local gadget that flips a stored value when its anchor is released (G^*, computer evidence) but no way of composing such gadgets, and Lemma 90(b) explains why the obvious compositions fail: the two vertices bridged by a lock are occupied and cannot be shared with the next gadget. By Lemma 92 such a family needs a Σ not closed under any uniform majority operation.

Conjecture 96 (Cores for $c \leq 2$)**.** *If $c \leq 2$, every core (minimal non-face among clean anchors) of a tight instance has at most two anchors.*

Evidence for Conjecture 96: no core of size 3 occurred in any tested tight instance (any c): the 723 tight connected graphs on 4 to 7 vertices, about 1,700 random ones with $n = 8, 9$, and 10^4 sampled instances with $n \leq 10$ (small search space). The stronger statement "Σ is closed under the majority $m(\text{all distinct}) = M$ when $c \leq 2$" that Lemma 92 would use is *false* (see above), so Conjecture 96 is not implied by it. If Conjecture 96 were true, then with Proposition 95 the tunnel-release model would be fixed-parameter tractable for $c \leq 2$, and any hardness proof by tunnels would need $c \geq 3$, where G^* already lives.

13 Limits of the parameterization

13.1 An ETH lower bound in the exponent

Theorem 97. *Assume ETH. There is no algorithm that decides CEaMP with $\ell = 0$ in time $2^{o(\mathrm{tw}(I(H)))}n^{O(1)}$. This holds even when every vertex lies in at most 23 packed P_3's (so $I(H)$ has maximum degree at most 66), and whether or not a tree decomposition is supplied.*

Proof. Li, Pilipczuk and Sorge [13, Thm. 1] give a polynomial reduction from 3-SAT to CEaMP with $\ell = 0$ and at most 23 packed P_3's per vertex. We use it as a black box together with its size accounting. After a linear preprocessing every clause has exactly three distinct variables and every variable occurs at least twice; let N be the number of variables and m the number of clauses, so $\sum_i m_i = 3m$ for the occurrence counts m_i. By the gadget descriptions of [13] (read in the audit, not recomputed constant by constant): a variable gadget has $4m_i$ cliques of 5 vertices and 25 packed P_3's per triple of consecutive cliques, hence $20m_i$ vertices and $50m_i$ packed P_3's; a clause gadget has $20 + 114$ vertices (clique sizes $1, 1, 4, 14$ and $34, 46, 34$), $6 + 12$ transferring P_3's, and $O(1)$ padding P_3's from a triangle packing on cliques of constant size. Hence $|V| \approx 194m$ and $|H| = O(m)$ with an absolute constant (not computed; a crude count gives about $3000m$). By the Sparsification Lemma (Impagliazzo, Paturi and Zane [10]; see also [4]) we may assume $m = O(N)$ at the cost of $2^{o(N)}$ extra time. Then $|H| = O(N)$ and $\mathrm{tw}(I(H)) \leq |H| - 1 = O(N)$ (one bag). An algorithm with running time $2^{o(\mathrm{tw}(I(H)))}n^{O(1)}$, which may compute its own decomposition, would therefore decide 3-SAT in time $2^{o(N)}$, contradicting ETH. □

Remark 98 (Caveats). (1) The bound is on the exponent only: it does not show that the base 3 (or 7) is tight, and $2^{o(w)}$ excludes $3^{o(w)}$ and $7^{o(w)}$ alike. A SETH-type bound $(3 - \varepsilon)^w$ is open. (2) The proof uses only $w \leq |H| - 1$; it does not exhibit hardness for instances of small $|H|$ relative to w. (3) The constants of the size table were read from the reduction and not re-derived one by one; the structural claim (every gadget has $O(1)$ size per clause or occurrence) was re-derived. (4) The statement refers to the version-3 arXiv text of [13].

13.2 Other parameters do not suffice

Proposition 99. *CEaMP is NP-hard when $I(H)$ has no edge ($w = 0$, vertex-disjoint packing), with ℓ part of the input. Hence w alone is not enough, and (by Theorem 1 of [13]) neither is $\ell = 0$ alone.*

Proof. Cluster Editing is NP-hard (e.g. already on graphs of maximum degree 6 [11]). Given (G, k) compute greedily a maximal set H of vertex-disjoint induced P_3's (if none, G is a cluster graph). Vertex-disjoint implies modification-disjoint and $I(H)$ is edgeless. Since $\mathrm{OPT} \geq |H|$, (G, k) is a YES instance iff $(G, H, k - |H|)$ is (a NO instance if $k < |H|$). □

Proposition 100. $\mathrm{tw}(G)$ *and* $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ *are incomparable, in the following sense. (a) For the star* $G = K_{1,2m}$ *(*$m \geq 1$*) every packing* $H \neq \emptyset$ *has* $I(H) = K_{|H|}$ *and every YES instance* (G, H, ℓ) *satisfies* $\ell + \mathrm{tw}(I(H)) \geq 2m - 2$*, while* $\mathrm{tw}(G) = 1$*. (b) For the* $k \times k$ *grid* G *and a family* H *of vertex-disjoint induced* P_3*'s along rows,* $\mathrm{tw}(I(H)) = 0$ *and* $\mathrm{tw}(G) = k$*.*

Proof. (a) Leaves have degree one, so the centre of any induced P_3 is the hub v; all packed P_3's are (a, v, b) with distinct leaves (the pairs va are disjoint), pairwise sharing v, so $I(H) = K_p$, $p = |H| \leq m$, $\mathrm{tw} = p - 1$. If the hub's cluster contains j leaves, the cost is $(2m - j) + \binom{j}{2}$ (the other leaves are best left as singletons), which is minimized, with value $2m - 1$, at $j \in \{1, 2\}$; so $\mathrm{OPT} = 2m - 1$ and a YES instance has $\ell \geq 2m - 1 - p$, i.e. $\ell + \mathrm{tw}(I(H)) \geq 2m - 2$. (b) Rows of a grid are induced P_3's (no triangles) and $\mathrm{tw}(k \times k \text{ grid}) = k$ is standard. □

Thus hubs do not make $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ large by themselves; they force a tradeoff: small $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ on a star forces large ℓ.

14 Open problems

Notation as above; $w = \mathrm{tw}(I(H))$.

Open Problem 2 (Main question: (ℓ, w) in general)**.** Is CEaMP fixed-parameter tractable parameterized by $\ell + w$, i.e. solvable in $f(\ell, w)n^{O(1)}$ time, or is it W[1]-hard in $\ell + w$? Known: XP in ℓ and FPT in w for each fixed ℓ only via $n^{2\ell}$ (Theorem 6); FPT in ℓ when $w = 0$ by [14], and FPT in (ℓ, s) when the components of $I(H)$ span at most s vertices (Theorem 22); the case $H = \emptyset$ (plain Cluster Editing, $\ell = k$) is FPT. Note that adding c to the parameter changes nothing, since $c \leq w + 1$. Also known: $n^{\ell} f(\ell, w) 7^{w+\ell+1}$ time (Theorem 57) and FPT in (ℓ, D, ω) (Theorem 59), where ω is not bounded by (ℓ, w) (Proposition 61). A positive answer needs a bound $g(\ell, w)$ on the number of candidate *positions* of the first endpoint of each unpacked edit: given one endpoint, the other has at most $f(\ell, D)$ candidates (Corollary 54), so only the placement of at most ℓ bounded objects is free. Locality is proved for type T1 pairs, in particular soft-free merges (Corollary 41), but *not* for type T2 pairs, which include generic merges (Proposition 45). A negative answer has to encode $[n]$-valued information through type T2 pairs or deleted hard edges (a heuristic observation, Remark 48). Sections 10 and 11 add: candidate lists for (T2) pairs and deleted edits of an optimum (Proposition 72), a pruned FPT theorem (Theorem 73), an obstruction family with a far deleted edge (Proposition 75), and a polynomial reduction to at most 2ℓ components of $I(H)$ (Theorem 82); they do not settle the question. What exactly remains is listed in Problems 4–6.

Open Problem 3 (Chain object and cores for $c \leq 2$)**.** Section 12 reduces the tunnel route to hardness to one missing gadget: a family of tight instances of bounded c and bounded $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ with a core of unbounded size (Open Problem 1). Is there one? Conversely, is every core of a tight instance with $c \leq 2$ of size at most two (Conjecture 96), which would make the tunnel-release model fixed-parameter tractable for $c \leq 2$? The stronger uniform-majority closure for $c \leq 2$ is false (explicit instance in Section 12). Only local evidence exists (a 7-vertex flip gadget with $c = 3$ and negative composition searches); nothing here bears on CEaMP itself outside the restricted model.

Open Problem 4 (Pointers of type T2)**.** Can the far ends of inserted pairs of type T2 (a kept hard edge az with a far from z in $I(H)$, and a soft pair zb; by Lemma 44 the end a is one of at most ℓ vertices fixed by the anchor (z, b)) be handled in a dynamic program of width bounded by $g(\ell, w)$? In particular, can a merge pointer between two pieces joined by a soft pair be forced at unbounded distance in $I(H)$? The computer evidence available (Remark 47) concerns only insertions inside

one piece and is silent on this. What is known: the far end a lies in an explicit list of at most $D\ell$ vertices determined by its soft anchor (Proposition 72), and the position of the *first* end is the open point; Proposition 75 shows that in an optimum a pointer can join members at any distance in $I(H)$ (there for a deleted edge), so the answer cannot come from locality in a fixed power of $I(H)$.

Open Problem 5 (Pointers realised by deleted hard edges)**.** The same question for deleted hard edges between far members of H (the other source of non-locality identified in Section 8.6). Given one endpoint, the other is one of at most $D + \ell$ hard neighbours (Corollary 54); the open point is the position of the first endpoint and the interaction of the far ends with the rest of the solution. Proposition 75 gives, for every $m \geq 3$, an instance with $w = 1$, $c = 2$, $\ell = 1$ in which every optimum deletes one hard edge between members at distance $m - 1$ in $I(H)$, so the two flags that name such an edit must agree between far bags. Placing the locally bad members in every bag does not help for "far" meaning distance 2 or 3 (Proposition 76); for unbounded distance this is open (Remark 77). Conjecture 78 is an untested proposal for the right interaction graph.

Open Problem 6 (The reduction lemma ML)**.** Is Conjecture 64 true: is there a polynomial-time reduction after which the treewidth ω of the graph Γ' of Theorem 59 is bounded by a function of (ℓ, w)? A positive answer would give FPT in $\ell + w$ (Observation 65). The family of Proposition 61 shows that a reduction is necessary; for $c = 1$ the rule of [14] is such a reduction, for $w \geq 1$ it is unknown. Partial results: a polynomial reduction leaves at most 2ℓ components of $I(H)$ (Theorem 82); the same rule on pair-closed unions of members does nothing on the family $N^*(F)$ of Proposition 84 ($w = 1$, $\ell = 1$, $\mathrm{tw}(\Gamma')$ unbounded); the Trigger Lemma (Conjecture 86) is a conjecture.

Open Problem 7 ($w = 1$ with unbounded tree components)**.** If $I(H)$ is a forest ($w \leq 1$, hence $c \leq 2$) with components of unbounded size, is CEaMP FPT in ℓ? Theorem 22 settles bounded components, in particular perfect matchings (Corollary 23), but its counting argument is at the level of whole components and gives nothing for a single large tree component. Theorem 82 reduces the general case to at most 2ℓ components, so the case of few, arbitrarily large components is what remains.

Open Problem 8 (Half-integral and intermediate packings)**.** Is CEaMP with $c = 2$ FPT in ℓ? What is the complexity of $\ell = 0$ for $3 \leq c \leq 22$? Both are open in [13], whose authors say a W[1]-hardness result for $c = 2$ "would also not be surprising".

Open Problem 9 (Base of the exponent)**.** For $\ell = 0$, does a $(3 - \varepsilon)^w n^{O(1)}$ (or even $2^{o(w)}$ with a smaller base) algorithm exist, or is there a SETH-type lower bound? Theorem 97 gives only the exponent.

Open Problem 10 (Treewidth of G)**.** What is the complexity of CEaMP with $\ell = 0$ (or of Cluster Editing) when $\mathrm{tw}(G)$ is bounded? We found no published result on Cluster Editing parameterized by treewidth alone (Section 15), so this must be proved rather than cited.

Open Problem 11 (Tightness of the defect bound)**.** Is the constant $2D$ in Lemma 67 attained for $D \geq 4$? It is attained for $D = 2$ in a computer search; for $D = 4, 6$ the search reached only $1/2$ and $1/3$ of the bound.

15 Related work

Packing lower bounds. van Bevern, Froese and Komusiewicz [14] parameterize F-free editing above the size of a vertex-disjoint packing; for Cluster Editing they obtain an $O(4^\ell \ell^3 + m + n)$-time

algorithm for P_3 packings (Thm. 6.13), and for cost-t packings an $O(1.62^{(2t+1)\ell} + nm + n1.62^t)$ algorithm and a kernel with $O(t\ell)$ vertices. They show NP-hardness at $\ell = 0$ of K_3-free editing for edge-disjoint packings and of K_q-free editing, $q \geq 6$, for vertex-disjoint packings, and leave open Cluster Editing above edge-disjoint packings and the stronger modification-disjoint bound. Li, Pilipczuk and Sorge [13] answer the latter: NP-hard at $\ell = 0$ with at most 23 packed P_3's per vertex, $n^{2\ell+O(1)}$ for $c = 2$, and open for $c = 2$ in ℓ and for $3 \leq c \leq 22$ at $\ell = 0$. They report "grid-like structures" as the obstacle. Our $\mathrm{tw}(I(H))$ parameter does not appear in either paper.

Twins and normal forms. The twin lemma (Lemma 10) is the critical-clique property behind the kernelizations of Guo [9]; the closed-neighbourhood reduction rule that generalises it is Reduction Rule 6.2 of [14], which Section 6 applies to components of $I(H)$. Pair-maximality and the structure of R (Lemma 12) are our own bookkeeping; we make no priority claim.

Reduction rule on components and unions of members. Section 11 applies Reduction Rule 6.2 of [14] to components of $I(H)$ of any size (Theorem 82); its soundness is Lemma 6.3 of [14], which we cite and do not re-prove (it was supported by our own tests on 850 applications). The counting argument for the number of irreducible components follows the structure of the argument of [14] but is carried out here with Lemma 80. The family $N^*(F)$ of Proposition 84 only shows that the rule applied to pair-closed unions of members does not reduce a family with $w = 1$; it says nothing about the rule for $c = 1$.

Treewidth of expanders. Propositions 61 and 84 use the fact that cubic expanders have treewidth linear in the number of vertices, which we cite from Grohe and Marx [8] (their relation between tree width, bramble size and expansion); we did not re-derive or re-check it.

Citations and treewidth. Semantic Scholar lists seven records citing [13] (checked 2026-10-20): the survey of Crespelle et al. [3], the vertex-splitting paper of Firbas et al. [5] (it uses modification-disjoint P_3 packings as a lower-bound tool), Bocci et al. [1], Garvardt et al. [7], the PACE 2021 Cluster Editing report, a 2021 thesis of the first author of [13], and a record of [13] itself under a variant title. We opened the first four; none improves $c = 2$, settles $3 \leq c \leq 22$, or uses a treewidth-type parameter. The PACE report and the thesis were not opened. Further searches (web, arXiv listing for "cluster editing" with "packing" or "treewidth", Semantic Scholar) found no paper on cluster editing parameterized by the treewidth of a packing intersection graph, on fixed-parameter tractability or W[1]-hardness of CEaMP for $c = 2$ or $c \geq 3$, or using the terms "$1/c$-integral" or "CEaMP" besides [13]; this is a "not found", not proof of absence (an arXiv search covers only titles and abstracts, and citation databases are incomplete). We found no paper stating the complexity of plain Cluster Editing or Deletion parameterized by treewidth. The nearby s-Club Cluster Edge Deletion is W[1]-hard parameterized by pathwidth plus the maximum number of allowed s-clubs, hence by treewidth plus that parameter, and fixed-parameter tractable by treedepth [6]; as a deletion problem with a diameter bound it does not transfer to editing. Komusiewicz and Uhlmann [11] show that Cluster Editing is NP-hard at maximum degree 6 and has no $2^{o(k)}\mathrm{poly}(n)$ algorithm under ETH; this is consistent with the fact that bounded degree of $I(H)$ does not give tractability (Theorem 97).

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